

Colette's Home Bible

La Belle Maison

MAKE ANY ROOM LOOK EXPENSIVE
WITHOUT BUYING ANYTHING NEW

COLETTE DUBOIS

La Belle Maison — Make Any Room Look Expensive Without Buying Anything New
Written by Colette Dubois. Published by Chez Colette.
First edition.

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DISCLAIMER

This book is educational. It describes principles of light, colour, proportion and material, and how to apply them to an ordinary home. It is not professional advice, and it is not a substitute for a qualified tradesperson.

Nothing in this book asks you to carry out electrical, gas, plumbing or structural work. Where a correction touches any of those, you are told to stop and call someone licensed — and you should.

Some corrections involve drilling, ladders, and hand tools. Work within your own competence. If you rent, read your tenancy agreement before you make a permanent change to anything; a chapter of this book is devoted entirely to the corrections that need no permission.

If you suspect damp, mould, lead paint or asbestos in your home, this book will not help you with it and does not try to. Those are surveyors' and specialists' work, and the reasons are explained where they come up.

Every measurement is given in both metric and imperial. Where a price is mentioned it is an order of magnitude, not a quotation.

A NOTE ON THE PICTURES

This book is drawn, not photographed. Every diagram in it is a line drawing made for the page, because a photograph of somebody else's beautiful room teaches you nothing about your own. Any room described in an example is an example, written to make a principle concrete. None of them is a real client.

BEFORE WE START

A word from Colette

I grew up in a building that was never meant for people. It was built for looms.

The Croix-Rousse is the hill above Lyon where the silk weavers worked. Their Jacquard looms stood nearly four metres tall, so the buildings were put up with four-metre ceilings and enormous windows facing north, because north light does not move and does not glare and you can match a thread by it all day. The weavers are long gone. Ordinary families live in their workrooms now, and mine was one of them.

So I was raised being told which windows were the good ones. That is a strange thing to grow up knowing, and it turns out to be the most useful thing in this book.

My grandmother made curtains. Not as a hobby — as a trade, for forty-one years, in other people's apartments all over that city. Curtains, blinds, cushions, loose covers, upholstery. She saw the inside of hundreds of homes and she had hard opinions about every one of them. She kept a cloth-bound notebook of every window she ever measured: the drop, the width, the fullness, the colour she had mixed to go with it, and the name of the family. Near the end of her life she made me promise I would write it all down properly before it was lost.

This is me keeping that promise, with fourteen years of my own work added to hers.

Those fourteen years were not spent in beautiful houses. They were spent in small flats, rented flats, ground-floor rooms that never saw the sun, and apartments that a landlord had ruined with the cheapest white paint and the wrong lights. That is the work I know. If you are looking for a book about châteaux, this is not it.

I left the trade because it only knows one verb. *Buy.* A client would ask me why her sitting room felt wrong and the profession had trained me to answer with a shopping list. And most of the time the shopping list was not the answer. Most of the time the room was suffering three or four specific things that could be named, and two of them could be fixed before dinner with what was already in the flat.

That is the whole argument of this book, and I will say it once here and then spend two hundred pages proving it.

> THE ARGUMENT
>
> *A room is not decorated. A room is corrected.*

Your taste was never the problem. Nobody ever showed you what to look at. Let me show you.

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HOW TO USE IT

Read Part One first. It is short and everything else depends on it, because it teaches you what to look at. After that the book is a reference and you may take it in any order you like.

If you want to do something tonight, turn to **The Room Audit** on page 181: one page, ten minutes, and it tells you which part to open. If you just need a number, **The Measurements** on page 165 collects every figure in the book.

PART ONE

How to Read a Room

Before you change anything, you have to be able to see what is wrong. This part teaches you the four errors that ruin almost every ordinary room, the three questions that find them, and the order in which corrections have to be made if they are not going to waste your money.

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CHAPTER ONE

The room is not the problem

You have already tried. That is the part nobody credits you for.

You have moved the sofa. You have moved it back. You have bought cushions, and then different cushions. At some point you painted a wall, and it looked better for about a week, and then it went back to looking the way it looked before. You have a folder of saved photographs of rooms you like, and not one of them looks like yours, and you cannot say why.

So you have quietly arrived at the conclusion that the problem is you. That other people have an eye and you do not. That your room is simply an ordinary room and this is what an ordinary room looks like.

I have been in several hundred of these rooms. That is not what is happening.

What is happening is that you are being asked to solve a problem you have not been given the vocabulary for. Nobody taught you to look at a room the way a decorator looks at a room, which is not as a collection of objects but as a set of relationships — between the light and the wall, between the height of a thing and the height of your eye, between one material and the next. Without that vocabulary there is only one move available to you, and that move is to buy something. So you buy something, and it changes the objects in the room without changing any of the relationships, and the room looks the same.

And every single part of this industry is content for that to continue.

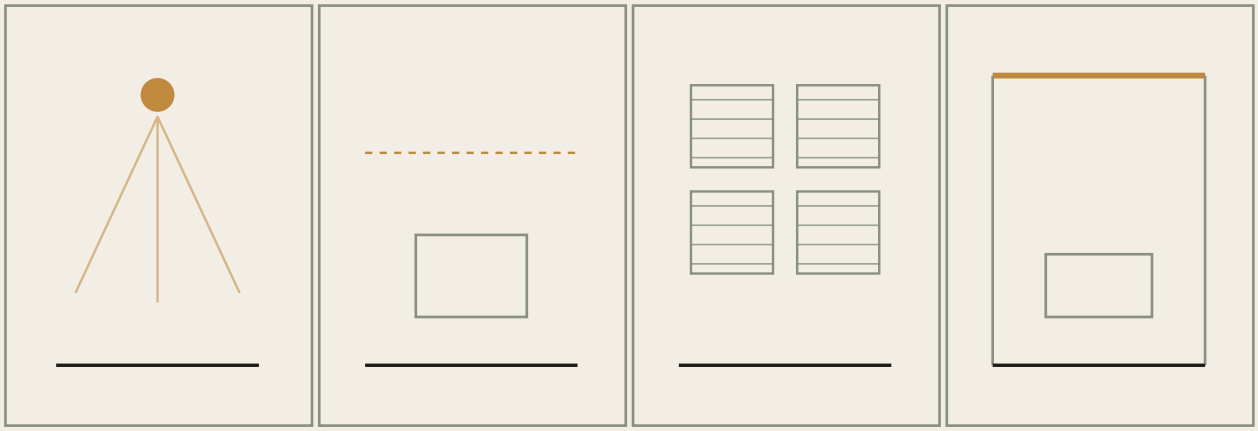
> **WHAT WE ARE ACTUALLY DOING**
>
> *Almost no ordinary room is short of objects. Nearly all of them are suffering three or four specific, nameable errors.*

Three or four. Not thirty. That is the good news buried in this, and it is the reason this book is possible at all. The errors repeat. They are the same errors, in flat after flat, in one country after another, and once you know their names you will see them in every room you walk into for the rest of your life — including on television, including in the photographs you saved.

Most of them cost nothing to correct. Some of them take twenty minutes. One or two are worth real money, and when we get to those I will tell you plainly.

The four errors

Here they are. Every one of them gets its own page after this, and every one of them gets a whole part of the book later on. For now, just learn the four names.



ONE · THE ROOM IS LIT FROM ONE HEIGHT

There is a light in the middle of the ceiling and that is all there is. Every object in the room is lit from the same angle, so nothing has any depth, and everyone in the room looks tired.

TWO · EVERYTHING IS HUNG TOO LOW

The pictures, the curtain pole, the mirror, the pendant. All of it sitting lower than it should, which drags the whole room down towards the floor and makes the ceiling feel closer than it is.

THREE · ONE TEXTURE, REPEATED

Everything in the room is the same kind of surface. Four soft things, or four shiny things, or four flat painted things. The room reads as a showroom, or as a waiting area, and you cannot say why because nothing in it is ugly.

FOUR · NOBODY HAS EVER LOOKED AT THE CEILING

It is the largest surface in the room. No furniture will ever hide any part of it. It is the last thing you see at night and the first thing you see in the morning. And you painted it white without once asking whether that was the right answer.

ERROR ONE

The room is lit from one height

Go and stand in your sitting room tonight with the lights on as you normally have them. Now look at the ceiling, and count the sources.

In most rooms the answer is one. There is a fitting in the middle of the ceiling, it is doing all of the work, and everything you own is being lit from directly above.

Here is why that single fact is doing so much damage.

Light from directly overhead falls on the top of everything and nothing else. The top of the sofa arm is bright, the front of it is not. The top of your head is bright and your eye sockets are in shadow, which is why everyone in a room lit this way looks exhausted. Nothing has a lit side and a shaded side, so nothing has any apparent depth — and a room without depth reads flat whatever you paid for the furniture in it.

And because that one fitting lights the whole room from one point, it has to be bright. So the brightness is the thing you notice, and the room feels like a place where tasks are performed rather than a place where anyone sits.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE THREE HEIGHTS**
>
> *Light must arrive at three heights — overhead, table, and floor. A room lit from one height is a room lit like a corridor.*

This is my rule rather than a law of physics, and Part Two is entirely about it. But the correction is so cheap that I want you to have it now.

THE TWENTY-MINUTE VERSION

Tonight, turn the ceiling light off. Put two lamps on in the room instead — any two lamps you already own, one at roughly the height of a side table and one lower or taller than that — and put them in two different corners rather than side by side. Then sit down in the chair you actually sit in and look at the room.

Nothing bought, nothing moved more than a metre. And every object in that room now has a lit side and a shaded side, which is the whole difference between a room and a corridor.

> **IF YOU ONLY HAVE ONE LAMP**
>
> Use it, and turn the ceiling light off anyway. One lamp and a dark corner beats one ceiling fitting and none — page 102.

ERROR TWO

Everything is hung too low

This is the most common error in this book and the cheapest one to correct, which is a combination you will not meet often.

Almost everything that hangs in an ordinary home hangs lower than it should. Pictures, mirrors, curtain poles, pendant lights, shelves, coat hooks. It happens for a reason that is completely understandable: you hang a thing at the height where it is comfortable to hold it up against the wall. That is roughly the height of your own hands at rest, and your hands at rest are a good deal lower than where the object needed to go.

Repeat that across nine or ten objects and the effect is cumulative. The whole visual weight of the room collects in a band about a metre off the floor, everything above that band is empty, and the empty part reads as unfinished while the crowded part reads as cluttered. Both at once, in the same room.

THE TWO NUMBERS THAT FIX MOST OF IT

A picture hangs with its **centre** at	145 cm · 57 in
A curtain pole goes as close to the ceiling as it can, and the curtain drops to **the floor**	0–1 cm clearance

One hundred and forty-five centimetres to the centre of the picture — not to the top, not to the bottom, and not to the hook. This is the standard hanging height used in galleries and museums, and the reason it works is that it puts the middle of the work at the eye level of an average standing adult. It is not a matter of taste. It is a matter of where human eyes are.

Go and measure one picture in your home right now. If the centre of it is at 120 or 125 centimetres, which it probably is, you have found one of your three or four errors, and the fix costs one nail hole and four minutes.

ONE HONEST EXCEPTION

Art hung above a sofa or a console follows the furniture, not the room — leave roughly 15 to 25 cm (6 to 10 in) between the top of the furniture and the bottom of the frame, and let that decide the height. Page 88 covers the whole business of hanging over furniture, including what to do when the two rules disagree.

Curtains are the larger prize and they get their own chapter, because moving a curtain pole upward by twenty centimetres does something to a room that is genuinely difficult to believe until you have seen it. The window appears taller. The ceiling appears higher. The wall stops looking like a wall with a hole in it.

ERROR THREE

One texture, repeated

This is the error that makes a room full of nice things feel like a hotel lobby.

Stand in the doorway and do not look at colour or at shape. Look only at *surface*. What is each thing in this room actually made of, and what would it feel like under your hand?

In a great many rooms the honest answer comes back as one material wearing four costumes. A grey fabric sofa, a grey fabric armchair, a grey fabric ottoman, and a grey fabric curtain: four soft things. Or: a glass table, a gloss-painted unit, a mirror, and a chrome lamp — four hard shiny things. Nothing in either room is ugly. Nothing is even badly chosen. And the room is lifeless, because a surface only reads as interesting next to a surface that is not like it.

A hand runs over linen and then over oak and then over unglazed clay and registers three completely different things. A hand that runs over four woven surfaces registers one thing, four times. Your eye does exactly the same arithmetic, faster, and without telling you.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE FOURTH TEXTURE**
>
> *A room reads as finished when four textures meet: something woven, something wooden, something ceramic or stone, and something living. Three is a showroom. Four is a home.*

This is mine, and it is a rule of thumb rather than a truth — but I have used it for fourteen years and it has never once let me down in a room that was not working. Count the families. If you can only find two, you have found another of your errors, and it is almost always the cheapest one in the book to fix, because the missing family is usually clay or wood and both of those can be answered from a charity shop for the price of a coffee.

THE FOUR FAMILIES

FAMILY	READS AS	WHERE IT USUALLY IS ALREADY
Woven	soft, absorbs light	sofa, curtain, rug, cushion, throw
Wooden	warm, grained, matte	floor, table, frame, shelf, chair leg
Ceramic or stone	cool, dense, slightly rough	almost always the missing one
Living	irregular, moves	one plant, or branches in water

Metal and glass are not a fifth family so much as a seasoning. A room can carry a little and does not need any. If your room is all metal and glass, what it is missing is probably wood.

ERROR FOUR

Nobody has ever looked at the ceiling

In French we have a name for the ceiling that English does not have. We call it *le cinquième mur* — the fifth wall.

I did not understand what a good name that was until I started working in other people's homes and noticed that the ceiling was the only surface in the house that nobody had ever made a decision about. Every other surface had been considered. Somebody had chosen the floor. Somebody had chosen, or at least argued about, the colour of the walls. The ceiling was white because ceilings are white.

Consider what that surface actually is. It is the largest single uninterrupted plane in the room — larger than any wall, because no window or door is cut out of it. It is the only surface that no piece of furniture will ever stand in front of, which means you see all of it, all of the time. And it is the last thing you look at before you go to sleep and the first thing you look at when you wake up.

One coat of paint. Nobody sells it to you, because there is nothing in it for anyone.

> **THE LAW OF THE FIFTH WALL**
>
> *The ceiling is the largest surface in the room, the only one no furniture will ever hide, and the only one you painted white without once asking why.*

WHAT THE CEILING IS DOING TO YOUR ROOM RIGHT NOW

A pale ceiling appears to recede. A darker ceiling appears to come closer. That is a real perceptual effect and you can use it in either direction, which is the part almost nobody is told: a low ceiling is not automatically improved by white paint, and a very high ceiling in a small room is often improved by a darker one, because it brings the room down to a human scale and makes it feel occupied rather than echoing.

The choice depends on what the room is for and what is wrong with it, and Part Three gives you the whole decision. What I want from you here is smaller. I want you to go into the room you like least in your home, lie on the floor, and look up for thirty seconds.

Most people discover two things. The ceiling is not actually white any more — it has gone cream, or grey, or yellow near the light fitting. And there is more of it than they remembered.

HOW TO LOOK

The three questions

You now know the four errors by name. This is how you find which of them are in your room.

Do not do this from the doorway. Sit down in the chair you actually use, at the time of day you actually use the room, with the lights as you actually have them. A room that is being inspected is not the room you live in.

1. **Where is the light coming from, and how many places is it coming from?** Count the sources that are switched on. Then look at one solid object — a jug, a lamp base, the arm of a chair — and find its shadow. If it does not have one, the room has a single source and you have error one.

2. **Where is the highest thing on the wall, and where is my eye?** Sit still and look straight ahead without tilting your head. Note where your gaze lands on the far wall. Now look at the top edge of the highest picture, mirror or shelf. If everything on that wall sits below where you were already looking, you have error two.

3. **How many different materials can I count, and how many families do they belong to?** Not how many objects — how many *kinds of surface*. Woven, wooden, ceramic or stone, living. Fewer than three families is error three.

Then, last, look up. If you cannot remember making a decision about that surface, you have error four, and you have almost certainly got it, because almost everyone has.

WHAT YOU ARE LIKELY TO FIND

Three of the four. That is the ordinary result and it is not a disaster — it is why the room has been resisting you. Four separate problems, none of which is fixable by buying a cushion, and nobody ever told you their names.

DO NOT FIX ANYTHING YET

Write down what you found and put the pencil down. The order in which these get corrected matters a great deal, and doing them in the wrong order is how people spend money twice. That is the subject of page 15 and it is the most expensive page in this book to ignore.

The page opposite is the audit written out properly, with room to fill in. Photocopy it, or print that page on its own, and keep a filled copy for every room in the house.

WORKSHEET

The ten-minute room audit

Sat in the chair you use, at the hour you use it, with the lights as you normally have them.

ROOM

TIME OF DAY / DATE

ONE · LIGHT

SOURCES SWITCHED ON — HOW MANY

AT HOW MANY DIFFERENT HEIGHTS

- [ ] I picked one solid object and it has a visible shadow

TWO · HEIGHT

CENTRE HEIGHT OF THE MAIN PICTURE

GAP UNDER THE CURTAIN HEM

- [ ] Something on the wall is above my seated eye line

THREE · TEXTURE

- [ ] Woven — fabric, rug, weave
- [ ] Wooden — grained, matte
- [ ] Ceramic or stone — cool, dense
- [ ] Living — a plant, or branches in water

FOUR · THE FIFTH WALL

WHAT COLOUR IS THE CEILING ACTUALLY, LOOKING AT IT NOW

THE VERDICT

ERRORS FOUND, IN THE ORDER I WILL CORRECT THEM (SEE PAGE 15)

Why your room photographs badly when it looks fine to you

Nearly everyone has had this experience, and almost nobody knows what it means.

You stand in the room and it is perfectly pleasant. You take a photograph of it to send to somebody and the photograph is dreadful. The proportions look wrong, the colours look muddy, the whole thing looks cheaper than it does in life. So you conclude that you are bad at photography.

You are not. The camera is telling you the truth and your eye has been protecting you from it.

Your eye is not a camera. It moves constantly, it adjusts its exposure locally as it moves, and — this is the important part — your brain edits out what it already knows is there. You have not properly *seen* the cable behind the television for two years. Your visual system has decided it is not information and it stopped sending it to you. A camera has no such filter. It flattens the room to one plane, fixes one exposure for the whole frame, and reports back every single thing in it.

So the photograph is a free diagnosis. Use it that way.

> **HOW TO USE IT**
>
> *Photograph the room, then look at the photograph rather than the room. The first three things that annoy you in the picture are the three errors you have stopped being able to see.*

TWO REFINEMENTS THAT MAKE IT SHARPER

- **Turn the photograph upside down.** This is an old drawing-class trick and it works for exactly the same reason: inverted, the image stops being a room you recognise and becomes a pattern of shapes and tones. Errors of proportion and balance leap out. It is startling how well this works on a wall of pictures.
- **Turn it black and white.** With colour removed, what is left is the distribution of light and dark, and light and dark is what gives a room depth. A photograph that goes to uniform mid-grey is a photograph of a room lit from one height.

Keep those photographs. When you have finished correcting the room, take the same photograph from the same spot at the same hour. It is the only honest before-and-after there is, and it will show you things you did not know you had fixed.

THE MOST EXPENSIVE PAGE TO IGNORE

The order of operations

Corrections have to be made in a particular order, because each one changes the answer to the next.

This is the page that saves you money. Not because anything on it is difficult, but because the natural order — the order in which people actually do it — is almost exactly backwards, and doing it backwards means paying twice.

Here is the order. It goes from the thing that nothing depends on, to the thing that depends on everything.



1. **Clear.** Take out of the room everything that is broken, everything you do not like, and everything that is there because it has always been there. Do not replace any of it yet. An emptier room is easier to read, and a surprising number of rooms are substantially fixed at this stage. It costs nothing.
2. **Light.** Lamps, bulbs, heights, and what you can stop blocking. This comes before colour and it is not negotiable, for the reason on the next page. It is usually the cheapest real change in the room and almost always the largest.
3. **Height.** Curtain pole up, pictures to 145, shelves and mirrors adjusted. Nail holes and an afternoon. Do this before you paint, because you will be filling holes anyway and because the new heights change where the eye goes.
4. **Texture.** The missing families. Fabric, wood, clay, something living. Usually one object, usually cheap, and it is what makes a corrected room feel lived in rather than merely tidy.
5. **Colour.** Walls, ceiling, woodwork. Last, always — and only now, when you know what light the room will actually be living in and what else is already in it. By the time you arrive here, a surprising number of rooms no longer need painting at all.

THE EXPENSIVE MISTAKE

Buying furniture at any point in this list. Furniture is not a stage. It comes after all five, if it comes at all, and most of the rooms I have corrected needed none.

Why colour comes fourth and not first

Everybody starts with paint. It is the wrong place to start, and here is the reason in one sentence: a colour is not a property of the paint. It is what happens when that paint meets the light in your room.

Change the light and you have changed the colour. Not your perception of it — the actual wavelengths coming off that wall into your eye. The same tin of paint on a north-facing wall and a south-facing wall is two different colours, and anybody who has painted both will tell you so.

So when you choose a colour before you have settled the light, you are answering a question whose terms have not been set yet. Then you fix the lighting afterwards, and the colour you chose turns out to be wrong, and you paint again. I have watched people do this three times in the same room.

THE TWO THINGS THAT DECIDE A COLOUR BEFORE YOU HAVE CHOSEN IT

- **Which way the window faces.** North light in the northern hemisphere never carries direct sun; it is cool and steady all day, and it will push a warm grey towards blue. South light is warm and strong and will push a cool white towards yellow. This is the first page of Part Two and it is the single most useful fact in the book.
- **What your bulbs are.** A bulb has a colour temperature printed on the box and most people have never looked at it. Twenty-seven hundred kelvin is warm domestic light; four to five thousand is the light shops and offices are lit with. Put a colour chosen under one of those under the other and it is unrecognisable.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

"You are not choosing a colour. You are choosing what the light will do to it." — my father was a house painter and he mixed his own colours, and this is the only thing he ever said about paint that I have never had cause to revise.

There is one more reason to leave paint until fourth, and it is the practical one. Paint is the most disruptive and least reversible thing on the list. You have to empty the room, cover the floor, and lose two days. Lamps take twenty minutes and can be undone. Curtain poles take an afternoon. It is simply better sense to exhaust the cheap reversible moves first — and a great many rooms never need the paint at all once the first three stages are done.

Everything you need to own

This is the complete list. It is short on purpose, and I would rather you questioned it than trusted it.

TOOL	WHAT IT IS FOR	ROUGHLY
A retractable tape measure, 5 m, metric and imperial on the same blade	Every number in this book. Nothing else in the list matters as much.	a few dollars
A pencil and a rubber	Marking a wall. Never a pen.	pennies
A small spirit level, 20–30 cm	Poles, shelves, rows of pictures. A phone app is not good enough for a two-metre pole.	under $15
Low-tack masking tape	Marking heights on a wall before you commit to a hole. The most useful thing on this list after the tape measure.	a few dollars
Two large sheets of white paper, A2 or bigger	Testing paint properly. Page 48 explains why a small chip cannot tell you anything.	a few dollars
A drill, if you own the wall	Poles and heavy mirrors. Borrow one before you buy one.	borrow it

WHAT IS DELIBERATELY NOT ON THE LIST

No colour fan deck — you will be given the six whites that matter and the reason each one fails, and a fan of two thousand chips makes the decision harder rather than easier. No laser measure; a tape is more accurate at room distances and never needs a battery. No design software. No mood-board app. No subscription to anything.

THE ONE THING WORTH BORROWING RATHER THAN BUYING

A stepladder. You will need one for perhaps two afternoons in the whole of this book, and then it will live in a cupboard for a decade. Ask a neighbour. It is also how you find out whether your neighbour has a drill.

AND THE MASKING TAPE, BECAUSE I MEAN IT

Before you put a hole in anything, cut a piece of tape the width of the object and stick it on the wall at the height you are considering. Leave it there for a day. Walk past it. Sit down and look at it. Almost every hanging error in this book would be prevented by that one habit, and the tape costs less than the filler you would otherwise need.

What this book will not do

I would rather tell you now than have you find out two hundred pages from here.

IT WILL NOT MAKE A SMALL FLAT INTO A LARGE ONE

There are real techniques in here for making a small room read as larger and more deliberate, and they work. None of them adds a square metre. If your flat is too small for your life, that is a different problem and no book solves it.

IT WILL NOT HELP YOU WITH DAMP, MOULD, LEAD OR ASBESTOS

These come up in old buildings and they are not decorating problems. Damp has a cause and until the cause is found nothing you put on that wall will stay there. Paint in buildings from before the late 1970s may contain lead, and disturbing it by sanding is the dangerous part. Some materials in older buildings contain asbestos and must not be drilled or cut. If you suspect any of these, the correct next step is a surveyor or a licensed specialist, not a paintbrush. I will say so again each time it comes up.

IT WILL NOT DO ELECTRICAL, GAS, PLUMBING OR STRUCTURAL WORK

Nothing in this book asks you to. Where a correction would — moving a ceiling fitting, adding a socket, taking out anything that holds the building up — you are told to stop and call somebody licensed. There is more good work available to you without touching any of that than you will get through in a year.

IT CANNOT GET YOU PERMISSION

If you rent, some of this is not available to you, and Part Six is written entirely for that situation — every correction in it needs no drill, no paint and nobody's consent. If your building is listed or protected, check before you change a window, a door or anything on the outside.

IT IS NOT AGAINST SPENDING MONEY

This is the one people get wrong about me. I am against *wasted* money, which is a completely different position. There are things in this book I will tell you to spend on, because the cheap version is a false economy and you will buy it twice:

- A good lamp. It will outlive the room.
- Lined curtains, in enough fabric. The single largest visible difference money makes.
- A sofa whose cover can be taken off, or which can be reupholstered.
- Decent bulbs, which cost very little and change everything.

Everything else in the ordinary decorating budget is negotiable, and a good deal of it is listed on page 189 under the heading of what not to buy.

SIX THINGS YOU HAVE BEEN TOLD

That are wrong — part one

ONE · “PAINT A SMALL ROOM WHITE TO MAKE IT LOOK BIGGER”

This is the most repeated piece of advice in the subject and it is the one I disagree with most sharply. A small room painted flat white does not read as bigger. It reads as small and unfinished, because white shows you exactly where the walls are and there is nothing else for the eye to do. Meanwhile every mark, every radiator, every cable is on full display against it.

A small room painted a deep, quiet colour reads as *deliberate*. The corners soften, the walls stop announcing their distance, and the room feels like a decision rather than a shortage. This is my position and not a physical law, so I have marked it as mine — but Part Three gives you the whole argument and the cases where white genuinely is the right answer.

TWO · “GET THE BIGGEST LIGHT YOU CAN FOR A DARK ROOM”

A dark room is rarely short of lumens. It is short of *directions*. One very bright ceiling fitting in a dark room produces a bright ceiling and a dim room, because all it can do is illuminate the plane it is attached to and the tops of things. Three modest lamps at three heights will make that room feel twice as bright as one powerful pendant, using less electricity.

THREE · “PUSH THE FURNITURE AGAINST THE WALLS TO MAKE SPACE”

In a small room this is often exactly wrong. Furniture flat against every wall leaves a void in the middle, and a void does not read as space — it reads as a waiting room. Pulling a sofa five or ten centimetres off the wall, and letting one chair sit at an angle, gives the room an inside. The floor you lose is floor nobody was standing on.

WHY THESE PERSIST

Not one of the three is a conspiracy. They are all true of *showrooms*, which are lit from above, painted pale so the stock reads, and arranged around a central aisle. Advice written for a shop floor got repeated until it sounded like advice for a home.

That are wrong — part two

FOUR · “AN ACCENT WALL WILL TRANSFORM THE ROOM”

One wall in a different colour does not transform a room. It divides it. The eye reads the coloured wall as nearer than the others, so a room with one dark wall and three pale ones feels shorter in that direction, not deeper. If the wall you chose is the one with the window in it, you have also just put your only source of light in front of your darkest surface, which is the least useful arrangement available.

There is a version of this that works, and it is not an accent wall — it is taking one colour all the way round the room and onto the ceiling, so the room reads as a single volume. Page 62.

FIVE · “MIRRORS DOUBLE THE LIGHT”

A mirror reflects what is in front of it. That is the whole mechanism. A mirror opposite a window reflects the window and genuinely helps, because it puts a second bright rectangle into the room. A mirror opposite a blank wall reflects a blank wall, adds nothing, and has cost you the wall it is hanging on. Before you hang a mirror, stand where it will go and look at what you would be looking at.

SIX · “YOU NEED A FEATURE, A FOCAL POINT, A STATEMENT PIECE”

A room needs somewhere for the eye to rest, which is not the same thing and is usually cheaper. A window with the curtains hung properly is a focal point. A fireplace is a focal point. A bookcase with actual books in it is a focal point. The word *statement* is doing commercial work in that sentence, and the thing being stated is usually a price.

> **CARRY THIS ONE FORWARD**
>
> *Almost every piece of decorating advice you have absorbed was written to sell something. Ask what each rule would have you buy, and a surprising number of them dissolve.*

That is the end of Part One. You know the four errors, you know how to find them, and you know the order in which to correct them. Everything after this is detail, and the detail starts where it has to start.

PART TWO

Light

Light is the first correction and the largest one, and it is almost always the cheapest. This part covers what your windows are giving you, how to read a bulb box, the three heights a room has to be lit from, and what to do with a room that gets no sun at all.

Which way does your window face · 23
The three heights · 28
Colour temperature · 34
The room with no natural light · 39
The lighting plan · 42

CHAPTER TWO

Why light comes first

You cannot see anything in a room except light. Everything else you think you are looking at is light coming off a surface.

That sounds like a philosophical remark and it is in fact a completely practical one. The colour of your wall is light. The texture of your sofa is light — specifically, it is the pattern of tiny highlights and shadows across a weave, which is why velvet and linen look different even in the same colour. The apparent size of the room is light, because your eye judges depth largely from how brightness falls off across a surface.

Change the light and you have changed all three. Nothing else in decorating has that reach.

Which is why it is first, and why the money goes furthest here. Three good bulbs and a lamp you already own will do more for a room than a new rug at ten times the price. I have seen it happen in an afternoon more times than I can count, and it still surprises the person who lives there.

THE TWO HALVES OF THE PROBLEM

A room has daylight, which you did not choose and cannot change, and it has electric light, which you chose without thinking about it and can change tonight. They have to be handled differently.

- **Daylight** is a fixed fact of the building. What you can do is find out exactly what you have been given, stop wasting it, and choose colours that work with it rather than against it. That is the first six pages of this part.
- **Electric light** is entirely yours. Number of sources, their heights, the colour of the bulbs, whether they dim, what the shades do. Almost every error in the fourth error list lives here, and almost every one is correctable for under the price of a takeaway meal.

WHY I KNOW THIS

The building I grew up in was put up for silk looms, and the looms needed north light — light with no direct sun in it, that does not move across the day and does not glare, so a weaver could match a thread at nine in the morning and at four in the afternoon and get the same answer. Two hundred years later I am telling you the same thing about your sitting room. The weavers were right.

So we start with the window, because the window sets the terms for everything else.

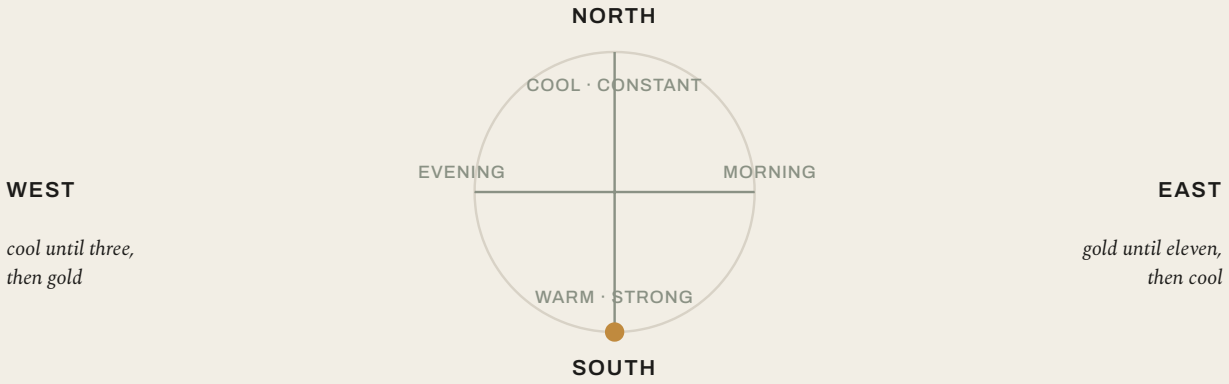
Which way does your window face?

If you take one thing from this book, take this. Almost nobody knows the answer for their own home, and every colour decision depends on it.

HOW TO FIND OUT, THREE WAYS

1. **The compass on your phone.** Stand at the window looking out. The bearing it shows is the direction the window faces. Thirty seconds, and it is the only thing your phone is better at than a tape measure.
2. **Midday.** In the northern hemisphere the sun is due south in the middle of the day. Stand at the window at noon. If the sun is in front of you, the window faces roughly south. Behind you, roughly north.
3. **Watch it for a day.** Direct sun in the early morning means east. Direct sun in the evening means west. Direct sun in the middle of the day means south. No direct sun at all, ever, at any hour, in any season — north.

Everything in this part and in Part Three assumes the northern hemisphere. If you are south of the equator, swap north and south throughout and leave east and west as they are.



Write the answer down for every room in the house. Put it on the audit sheet. You will use it on the paint page, on the bulb page, on the curtain page, and every time you are standing in a shop wondering whether a colour will work.

COLETTE'S FIRST LAW

Light before colour. You cannot choose a colour until you know which way the window faces.

NORTH-FACING

Cool, steady, and unfairly maligned

A north-facing room receives no direct sunlight at any point in the day or the year. Estate agents treat this as a defect. Painters and weavers have always treated it as the best light there is.

Both are right about different things. What north light is, precisely, is light from the whole dome of the sky rather than from the sun. That gives it two properties, and understanding them is the whole of managing a north room.

It does not move. There is no patch of sun crossing the floor, no hour when the room transforms, no glare. The light at nine is the light at four. This is why every proper painter's studio and every weaver's atelier in Europe faces north, and why my grandmother would only match a thread at a north window.

It is cool. Skylight is blue-biased, so everything in a north room is being lit by very slightly blue light, all day, forever.

WHAT THIS DOES TO YOUR COLOURS

It pushes them cold. A warm grey turns blue. A greige goes grey. A white with any blue in it goes clinical — and a great many fashionable whites have blue in them, which is exactly why they look so unpleasant in north rooms and so crisp in the showroom photograph that was taken in a south room.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **Choose colours with warmth in them, and more warmth than you think.** A colour that looks slightly too yellow or too pink on the chip will look correct on the wall. Part Three gives you the specific whites.
- **Do not fight it with brightness.** Adding more cool light to a cool room makes it colder. Add warmth instead: 2700 K bulbs, and lamps rather than the ceiling.
- **Lean into it.** A north room will never be a sunny room, and a north room pretending to be sunny is the saddest thing in decorating. Deeper, warmer, quieter colours make it feel intentional. This is the room to be brave in.
- **Use the steadiness.** It is the one room in the house where a colour will look the same in the morning and the evening. If you have art you care about, or you sew, or you paint, this is where it goes.

THE TEST

Hold a sheet of plain white paper up in your north room at midday, then carry it to a south-facing window. The same sheet of paper. The difference startles people — and it is applied to every surface in both rooms, permanently.

SOUTH-FACING

Warm, strong, and harder to handle than people expect

A south-facing room gets direct sun for most of the day. Everyone wants one. Nobody warns you that it is the most difficult light to decorate for.

The difficulty is that it changes. Direct sunlight is enormously stronger than skylight, and it arrives, crosses the room, and leaves. So a south room is really three rooms: a bright one in the morning, a blazing one at midday, and a normal one after the sun has moved past. A colour that is handsome at ten can be bleached to nothing at two.

It is also warm. Direct sun is yellow-biased, which means a south room flatters warm colours and can turn a cool colour muddy. And in summer it is a heat problem as much as a light problem.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **You can afford cool colours here, and you generally should.** This is the room where a grey-green, a slate blue, or a proper cool white works — the sun supplies the warmth so the paint does not have to. In a south room, warm colours on top of warm light can tip into orange.
- **Test at the worst hour, not the best.** Judge a colour in a south room at full midday sun. If it survives that, it will be fine the rest of the day. Judge it at six in the evening and you will choose wrong.
- **Give yourself a way to soften the sun.** A sheer panel behind the main curtain, or a blind you can drop at midday, turns direct sun into diffused light without turning the room dark. This is what shutters do in Mediterranean buildings, and it is the single most useful thing you can add to a south room.
- **Expect fading, and plan for it.** Strong sun over years will lighten textiles, paper and some woods. Rotate cushions. Do not put a watercolour you love on the wall the sun crosses. This is not pessimism, it is just what ultraviolet does.

THE ONE THAT CATCHES PEOPLE

Gloss and satin finishes in a south room. Direct sun across a shiny wall shows every roller mark, every filled hole, every unevenness in the plaster, in a way that no other light does. In a strong south room, keep walls matte and save the sheen for woodwork.

EAST AND WEST-FACING

The rooms with two personalities

An east or west room has direct sun for part of the day and skylight for the rest. So it has two characters, and the decision you have to make is which one you are decorating for.

That decision is not a matter of taste. It is a matter of when you are in the room.

EAST

Direct sun from sunrise until late morning, then cool skylight for the rest of the day. The sun is low and the light is clear and slightly golden, and then at some point mid-morning it simply goes, and from then on the room behaves like a north room.

Decorate it for the afternoon, because the afternoon is most of the room's life. Which means treating it much like a north room: warmth in the colours, 2700 K bulbs, lamps for the evening. The morning sun will be a gift on top of that rather than something you have to accommodate.

Best use: kitchens and breakfast rooms, and bedrooms for people who like to wake with the light.

WEST

Cool skylight all morning, then direct sun from mid-afternoon until sunset — and evening sun is the warmest, most orange light of the day, arriving at a very low angle, straight into the room and straight into your eyes.

Decorate it for the evening if that is when you use it, which for a sitting room it usually is. West rooms can carry cooler colours than you would expect, because that evening light is so warm it will pull everything back. But you will need something to cut the glare — a sheer, a blind, a shutter.

Best use: sitting rooms and dining rooms, where the golden hour lands exactly when you want it.

IF YOUR ROOM HAS WINDOWS ON TWO SIDES

Then you are fortunate and you have a slightly more interesting problem. Cross-lit rooms are the easiest rooms in the world to make look good, because everything in them has a lit side and a shaded side without you doing anything at all — the two errors of flatness and of single direction are solved by the architecture.

Work out which window is dominant, by sitting in the room at the hour you use it and seeing which one is actually doing the lighting. Decorate for that one. Treat the second window as modelling light and do not block it, ever, with a piece of furniture or a plant.

WORKSHEET

What light do I actually have?

One row per room. Fill it in once and you will use it for years. The last column is the one that matters.

ROOM	FACES	DIRECT SUN, WHICH HOURS	WHEN I USE IT	DECORATE FOR

THE RULE FOR THE LAST COLUMN

IF IT FACES	THEN COLOURS WANT TO BE	AND BULBS WANT TO BE
North	warmer than you think — more yellow, more pink in them	2700 K
South	cooler — the sun supplies the warmth	2700 K
East, used mornings	can go cool	2700 K
East, used afternoons	treat as north — warmer	2700 K
West, used evenings	can go cool	2700 K
No window	see page 39	2700 K

You will notice the last column does not vary. That is not laziness; it is the conclusion of page 34, and it is the shortest chapter in this book.

ONE MORE COLUMN WORTH ADDING YOURSELF

What is outside the window. A brick wall two metres away, a large tree, a white-rendered building opposite — each of these changes the light reaching you more than the compass does. Green light off a tree in summer is a real and often unexplained reason a room's colours look wrong from May to September.

ELECTRIC LIGHT

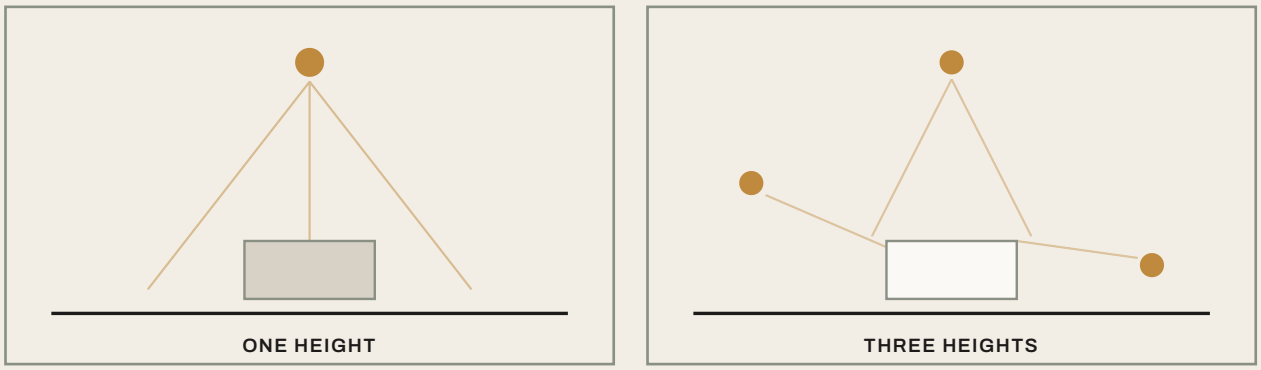
The three heights

Here is the rule stated plainly, and then the reason, and then the numbers.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE THREE HEIGHTS**
>
> *Light must arrive at three heights — overhead, table, and floor. A room lit from one height is a room lit like a corridor.*

This is mine and I will not dress it up as physics. But the reason underneath it is physics, and the reason is *modelling*. An object looks solid when one side of it is lit and another is not. That is the only cue your eye has for three-dimensionality in a still scene, and it requires light to arrive from more than one direction.

Put light at three different heights and every object in the room is caught from three angles. The jug has a bright side, a mid side and a shadow. The sofa arm has a top, a face and an underside. The room acquires depth, which is the quality people are describing when they say a room feels "warm" or "inviting" and cannot say why.



THE THREE, AND WHAT EACH ONE IS FOR

HEIGHT	ROUGHLY	ITS JOB
Overhead	ceiling	General fill. The least useful of the three, and the only one most rooms have.
Table	100–150 cm	The workhorse. Sits at seated eye level, lights faces kindly, gives the room its glow.
Floor	below 60 cm	Depth and atmosphere. Lights the bottom half of the room, which nothing else does.

Three sources, three heights, three switches. If you do nothing else in this book, do this.

HEIGHT ONE

Overhead, and what it is good for

I have spent a page telling you that the ceiling light is the problem. Now let me be fair to it, because there are three jobs it does that nothing else can.

- **Finding things.** You want a lot of even light when you are looking for a dropped earring or cleaning the room. That is a task, it lasts four minutes, and it is exactly what a ceiling fitting is for.
- **Safety.** Stairs, thresholds, anywhere someone might trip. Overhead light shows the edge of a step better than a lamp does.
- **Work.** A kitchen counter and a bathroom mirror need light from above and in front. In a kitchen this is not a compromise, it is correct.

What the ceiling light is *not* for is being the light you sit in. That is the whole error. It is a tool, not a setting, and the mistake is leaving the tool switched on all evening.

IF YOU ARE STUCK WITH A SINGLE CENTRAL FITTING

Most rented flats have exactly one, in the middle of the ceiling, and you cannot move it without an electrician. Three things you can do without touching the wiring:

1. **Change the shade so it throws light sideways and up, not straight down.** An open-topped drum or a fabric shade will bounce a good deal of its output off the ceiling, and light that has bounced off a surface is soft, directionless and much kinder than light straight from a bulb. This turns your worst fitting into something closer to indirect light, for the price of a shade.
2. **Reduce it and warm it.** Put in a lower-output 2700 K bulb than you think you need. You are no longer asking it to light the room; the lamps are doing that.
3. **Put it on a dimmer if the fitting and bulb allow.** See page 37 — and check that the bulb says dimmable, because most do not.

> **NEVER**
>
> A bare bulb in a ceiling fitting, in a room anybody sits in. It is the single harshest light source available in a home: a small, very bright point directly overhead, producing hard shadows in every eye socket in the room. If a shade is missing, a paper lantern costs almost nothing and is a real improvement.

One honest exception: a beautiful pendant, hung low over a dining table, is one of the great pleasures of a room. But look at what it is doing — hung that low it is no longer overhead light, it is table-height light with a cable. The height is the point.

HEIGHT TWO

Table height — the one that does the work

If you may only have one lamp, it goes here. This is the height that makes a room feel like somewhere people live.

The reason is that it is at the height of a seated person's eye. Light arriving from roughly your own eye level does two things at once: it lights faces from the front rather than the top, which is enormously more flattering, and it puts a bright object in your field of view without glaring, which reads as warmth.

THE NUMBER THAT MATTERS

Bottom of the shade, above the floor, for a lamp beside a chair or sofa	100–115 cm · 40–45 in
Which for a table at typical side-table height means a lamp of about	45–60 cm · 18–24 in
Bottom of the shade, for a lamp on a desk or console you stand at	125–135 cm · 49–53 in

The rule behind all three: **the bottom of the shade should sit at or just below the eye level of whoever is using the lamp.** Sit down in the chair and hold your hand at your eye. That is where the bottom edge of the shade wants to be. Higher and you are looking at the bulb. Much lower and the light pools on the table and never reaches your book.

This is why so many lamps are the wrong size — not the wrong style, the wrong *size*. A lamp is chosen in a shop, at standing height, on a display plinth. Then it goes onto a low side table beside a low sofa, and the shade ends up at chest height, and the room is lit from the chest up only.

HOW TO CHECK A LAMP BEFORE YOU BUY IT

Take two numbers with you: the height of the table it will stand on, and your own seated eye height (sit in a dining chair and have somebody measure from the floor to your eye — for most adults it lands between 110 and 125 cm). Table height plus lamp height to the bottom of the shade should land in that range. This is the only measurement anybody needs to buy a lamp, and no shop displays it.

WHERE THEY GO

Not side by side. Two lamps at table height on the same wall light one half of a room twice. Put them diagonally opposite, or at least on two different walls, so their light crosses. Two lamps on two walls is a lit room; two lamps on one wall is a lit wall.

HEIGHT THREE

Floor level — the one nobody does

This is the height that almost no ordinary home has, and it is the one that makes a room look like a photograph.

Think about where the light is in your room. It is all in the top half. Ceiling fitting at two and a half metres, perhaps a lamp at a metre. Everything below knee height is lit only by whatever falls down there, which is very little, because light falls off quickly with distance — double the distance from a source and you have a quarter of the light.

So the bottom third of the room sits in gloom, and because the bottom third of the room is where the floor is, the room reads as sitting in a dark pool. Adding a single low source transforms this, and it costs almost nothing because the fitting can be very modest.

FIVE WAYS TO DO IT, CHEAPEST FIRST

1. **A small lamp on the floor behind a chair or a plant.** Aimed up a wall or into the leaves. You cannot see the source, only the glow. This is the cheapest genuine transformation in the whole of this book — any small lamp you already own, put on the floor.
2. **A lamp on the lowest surface in the room.** A hearth, a stack of books, a low stool, the bottom shelf of a bookcase.
3. **An uplighter in a corner.** A canister that sits on the floor and throws light up the two walls of a corner. The corner glows, the ceiling picks it up, and the room gains a soft general light with no visible source.
4. **Candles.** Not a joke and not a decoration. A candle is a light source at table or floor height with the warmest colour temperature in the house, and four of them grouped is a real light. Never left unattended, never near a curtain.
5. **Lit shelving.** A strip tucked under a shelf, invisible, washing down the books below. The most expensive option here and the most permanent.

> ### WHY IT WORKS
>
> *Light from below reverses every shadow in the room. Nothing else you can do in twenty minutes changes a room this much.*

One caution, since the effect is strong: low light aimed at a face is theatrical and unflattering — it is how a horror film is lit. Aim it at a wall, a corner, a plant or a bookshelf, never across the seating.

How many lamps, and where they go

More than you have. Almost certainly more than you think is reasonable.

THE COUNT

Minimum separate light sources in any room anybody sits in	3
A sitting room, comfortably	4–6
Of which on the ceiling	1, off in the evening
Of which below 60 cm	at least 1

Five lamps in a sitting room sounds like a great many until you realise that each is small, dim and doing one job. Five modest sources use less electricity than one bright pendant trying to light the whole room, and the room will feel brighter. Brightness in a room is not the total output; it is how many surfaces have light on them.

WHERE THEY GO — THE FOUR RULES

1. **Spread them around the perimeter, not the middle.** Light on the walls makes a room feel larger, because the walls are what define its size and a lit wall reads as further away. Light in the middle does the opposite.

2. **Get one into every corner you can.** Dark corners make a room feel smaller and slightly unresolved. Not every corner — one should stay dark, see page 102 — but the others want something.

3. **Put one where you sit and one where you look.** A lamp beside your chair for reading, and a lamp at the far end of the room so there is something lit to look towards. A room where all the light is behind you feels like a cinema.

4. **Never point one at the television.** Or at a mirror, or at any glass, from opposite. You will spend the evening looking at the reflection of a bulb.

THE SWITCH PROBLEM, WHICH NOBODY MENTIONS

Five lamps means five switches in five awkward places, and a system you have to walk around the room to operate will be abandoned within a fortnight. Solve it before you build it: put lamps on a single switched extension where you can, or use plug adaptors you can control together. A lighting scheme that takes one action to turn on is a lighting scheme you will actually use, and that matters more than any individual fitting.

The numbers, collected

Every height in this chapter on one page, so you can take it to a shop.

WHAT	MEASURED TO	HEIGHT
Lamp beside a sofa or armchair	bottom of shade, from floor	100–115 cm / 40–45 in
Lamp on a desk or console	bottom of shade, from floor	125–135 cm / 49–53 in
Bedside lamp	bottom of shade, from floor	95–110 cm / 37–43 in
Floor lamp beside a chair	bottom of shade, from floor	115–130 cm / 45–51 in
Uplighter or low lamp	top of fitting, from floor	under 60 cm / 24 in
Pendant over a dining table	bottom of shade, above tabletop	75–90 cm / 30–35 in
Pendant over a kitchen island	bottom of shade, above worktop	70–80 cm / 28–32 in
Wall light in a corridor	centre of fitting, from floor	150–165 cm / 59–65 in
Wall lights either side of a mirror	centre of fitting, from floor	150–165 cm / 59–65 in
Bathroom mirror lighting	—	at the sides, not above

TWO RULES THAT EXPLAIN MOST OF THE TABLE

- **You should not be able to see the bulb from where you sit.** Every height above is really this rule expressed in centimetres for a particular piece of furniture. If you can see the bulb, the lamp is too high or you are too low.
- **Light a face from the side, not from above.** This is why a bathroom mirror wants lights beside it rather than over it — a fitting above a mirror puts your own eye sockets in shadow, which is why you look worse in a hotel bathroom than you do at home.

THE PENDANT OVER THE TABLE, BECAUSE IT GETS ARGUED ABOUT

Seventy-five to ninety centimetres above the tabletop looks far too low when the room is empty. It is correct when people are sitting down — it lights the food and the faces and not the ceiling, and you can see across the table underneath it. Hang it, then sit down before you judge it. Everyone who raises it wishes they had not.

THE NUMBER ON THE BOX

Colour temperature

There is a number on every bulb box that decides more about how your home feels than the price of your furniture, and most people have never read it.

It is printed in kelvin, with a capital K, and it describes the colour of the light rather than how much of it there is. The scale is confusing because it runs backwards from how you would expect: **a low number is warm and orange, a high number is cool and blue.**



THE WHOLE RECOMMENDATION

COLETTE'S RULE OF THE WARM BULB

Twenty-seven hundred kelvin, or nothing. Everything above three thousand is shop lighting, and a shop wants you to look at objects, not live among them.

Two thousand seven hundred kelvin is the colour of the old incandescent bulbs everybody grew up with, and it is the colour every human being alive associates with evening and with being at home. It is warm without being orange. It flatters skin. It makes wood look like wood.

Three thousand is acceptable and very slightly cooler; some people prefer it in a kitchen or bathroom. Four thousand belongs in a garage or a shop. Five thousand and up is sold as "daylight" and has no business in a room where anyone relaxes, because it tells the human body it is the middle of the day.

THE OTHER NUMBER WORTH FINDING

CRI, the colour rendering index, on a scale to one hundred. It measures how faithfully a light source shows colours compared with a reference light. A cheap bulb may sit around eighty, and under it your red cushion is a slightly brown cushion and your skin looks grey. Ninety or above is what you want, and it is often printed very small or as "CRI 90+". It costs a little more and it is the difference between your colours working and not working after dark.

THE QUIET PART

Why every shop you buy from is lit wrong

Walk into any large homeware shop and look up. The light is cool, it is bright, and there is a great deal of it, coming from directly overhead across the whole ceiling.

Every single thing about that is the opposite of what this chapter has told you to do. And it is not a mistake. It is correct — for a shop.

Cool bright overhead light makes goods read clearly. It shows edges and colours at a glance, it reaches into every aisle without shadows anyone could trip in, it keeps people alert and moving, and it is cheap to run and easy to maintain at scale. A shop is a place where objects are examined. It is lit for examining objects.

Your sitting room is not a place where objects are examined. But here is the consequence, and it is worth sitting with for a moment:

Every purchase you have ever made for your home, you made under light that your home will never have.

You chose the grey of that sofa at four thousand kelvin from above. You will live with it at two thousand seven hundred from the side. Those are genuinely different colours. This is the real reason the cushion looked one way in the shop and another way at home, and why people assume they have been somehow deceived. Nobody deceived you. Two different lights.

AND THE ECONOMICS UNDERNEATH IT

Nobody decided this in a room somewhere. It is quieter and sadder than that.

There is no money in telling you the answer is a two-dollar bulb. There is a great deal of money in a shop floor arranged so that the object looks its absolute best under lighting conditions that you will never reproduce, and in the next purchase you make when the first one disappoints you at home. Nobody has to intend that for it to be how the whole thing works.

So the fix is not a boycott, it is a habit:

- Never make a final colour decision in a shop. Bring the sample home.
- Judge fabric and paint in the room they are going into, at the hour you use it, with your own lamps on.
- Change your bulbs before you change anything else, so that the light you are judging in is the light you will keep.

What to actually buy

This page is the cheapest correction in the book. An afternoon, a handful of bulbs, and the light in your home stops being wrong.

THE SPECIFICATION, EVERY TIME

- **2700 K.** Sometimes sold as "warm white", but the words on the front vary between brands and the number does not. Find the number.
- **CRI 90 or above** if it is stated. If nothing is stated, assume it is not.
- **Dimmable**, if there is any chance the fitting is ever on a dimmer. It must say so explicitly.
- **The output you want, in lumens** — not watts. Watts describe how much electricity it uses, which used to be a rough proxy for brightness and is not any more.

LUMENS, ROUGHLY

FOR	LUMENS	OLD MONEY
A bedside or accent lamp	200–400	25–40 W
A table lamp doing real work	400–700	40–60 W
A reading lamp	700–900	60–75 W
A ceiling fitting in a sitting room	700–1000	60–75 W
A kitchen ceiling	1500–3000 total	—

Go lower than you expect on everything except the kitchen. The commonest error after colour temperature is buying bulbs that are far too bright, because the packaging competes on brightness.

AND THE SHAPE

Under a fabric shade, buy the cheapest thing that meets the specification above — nobody sees it. In an open fitting where the bulb shows, buy frosted or opal rather than clear: a visible filament is charming in a photograph and glaring in a room, because you are looking straight at a naked point source.

DO IT IN ONE GO

Walk round the house with a bag and count every socket, including the ones in fittings you never use. Buy them all at once, in the same specification, and change them in one afternoon. Mixed colour temperatures in one room is worse than either temperature alone — it is the only genuinely unfixable lighting error, because the eye cannot settle on a white point. If you do nothing else: make every bulb in a single room match.

Dimming, which matters more than brightness

A room needs different amounts of light at four in the afternoon and eleven at night. A room with one setting is wrong twice a day.

This is the part of lighting that people skip because it sounds like a luxury, and it is closer to a necessity. Your eye adapts: at eleven at night, with your pupils wide, the light you wanted at four in the afternoon is uncomfortably bright. And the amount of light in a room is one of the strongest signals your body uses to decide whether it is time to wind down.

FOUR WAYS, IN ORDER OF COST

1. **Separate switches.** The cheapest dimmer in the world is having five lamps on five plugs and turning two of them off. No wiring, no cost, and it is genuinely most of the benefit. Two lamps at eleven at night is a different room from five.
2. **An in-line dimmer on a lamp flex.** A small wheel that sits on the cable. Inexpensive, plugs in, nothing to install. The bulb must say dimmable.
3. **A plug-in dimmer or a smart plug.** Sits between the plug and the socket. Works with a remote or a phone. More expensive, no tools, and it lets you dim several lamps together.
4. **A wall dimmer.** Replaces the light switch. This is electrical work behind a faceplate and it needs an electrician — and if you rent, it needs permission. Do not do this one yourself.

THE DIMMABLE LED PROBLEM, WHICH CATCHES NEARLY EVERYONE

Most LED bulbs are *not* dimmable, and putting a non-dimmable LED on a dimmer gives you flicker, buzzing, a bulb that cuts out before the bottom of the range, or a shortened life. It has to say **dimmable** on the box. And even dimmable LEDs vary in how well they behave with any given dimmer, so if you are fitting several, buy one and try it before buying ten.

ONE THING BETTER THAN A DIMMER

A dimmed bulb gets dimmer but it does not get much warmer. Real evening light — a fire, a candle, a setting sun — gets warmer as it gets lower, and that is the quality a dimmer cannot reproduce on its own.

Which is why a candle or two, at the point in the evening when you have dimmed everything else, does something a dimmer cannot. It is not decoration. It is the only source in the house at around two thousand kelvin, and it is the reason a room with candles in it feels late in a way that a dimmed room does not.

What a shade actually does

A shade is not a decoration on a lamp. It is the part that decides where the light goes, and choosing it by appearance alone is how people end up with a lamp that does not light anything.

THE THREE BEHAVIOURS

SHADE	WHAT IT DOES WITH THE LIGHT	USE IT FOR
Opaque — card, metal, lined fabric	Sends light up and down in two cones. The shade itself stays dark.	Reading. Lighting a specific surface. Anywhere you want a pool rather than a glow.
Translucent — unlined linen, paper, parchment	Glows in every direction and lights the room generally. The shade becomes a soft object.	Atmosphere. The workhorse of a sitting room. Almost always the right answer at table height.
Directional — a hood, a cone, a spot	Sends light one way only.	A desk. A picture. Washing a wall. Never as the only light in a room.

COLOUR INSIDE THE SHADE

Look inside the shades you own. The inner surface is the last thing the light touches before it reaches you, and it tints everything.

- **White or off-white inside:** reflects efficiently, keeps the light neutral. The safe default.
- **Gold, brass or warm cream inside:** warms the light and increases the glow. Genuinely lovely in a north room and one of the oldest tricks there is.
- **Black or dark inside:** absorbs most of the light. Very dramatic, very inefficient. One in a room, never two.

THE PROPORTION RULE FOR A TABLE LAMP

Shade height, as a share of the whole lamp	about one third
Shade width at the bottom, compared with the base width	roughly twice
The shade must hide	the bulb and the fitting, from seated

That last line is the one that matters, and the first two are only rules of thumb that usually produce it. Sit down. If you can see the bulb or the metal collar it screws into, the shade is too small or too shallow, whatever the arithmetic says.

The room that gets no sun

A basement flat. A ground-floor room with a wall two metres away. A north room on a dark street. I have worked in a great many of these and I am not going to pretend they are the same as a room with a view.

Here is the honest position, and then what genuinely helps.

The honest position: a room with no useful daylight cannot be made to feel like a room with daylight. Every technique for "brightening" such a room is really a technique for making it feel intentional instead of deficient. That is achievable, and it is a different goal from the one the magazines imply.

WHAT DOES NOT WORK, WHICH IS MOST OF THE USUAL ADVICE

- **Brilliant white.** The most common advice and the worst. White needs light to be white; without it, white goes grey and dead. You have painted the room the colour of the problem.
- **More lumens.** A dark room flooded with cool light becomes a lit dark room — gloomy and glaring at once.
- **A mirror on a blank wall.** It reflects the blank wall. Page 20.

WHAT WORKS

1. **Stop trying to be bright and commit to being warm.** This is the whole strategy. A deep, warm, enveloping colour in a sunless room reads as a decision — a study, a snug, a dining room for the evening. The same room in pale grey reads as a mistake. Deep green, warm brown-red, ink blue, a proper dark plaster colour. Be braver than feels sensible.
2. **Four or five small warm sources, none overhead**, with one dark corner left alone. You are building an evening room, so light it like an evening.
3. **Every texture you can find.** Texture is what gives a dark room something to do — light catching a coarse weave, a worn timber, a matte glaze. This is the room for the roughest, most tactile things you own.
4. **Something living, realistically.** Choose the tolerant plants and accept slow growth, or use branches in water.
5. **Take back whatever daylight exists.** Page 41. Here every centimetre of glass matters, and it is usually half blocked.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My grandmother made curtains for a dressmaker whose courtyard workroom never saw the sun. She lined its walls in a dark red and put six lamps in it. Everyone who came in said it was the loveliest room in the building. It was the darkest.

Corridors, landings and internal rooms

Nobody decorates a corridor and everybody walks through one several times an hour. It is the most neglected surface area in a home.

A corridor has a particular problem: it is long, narrow, usually windowless, and lit by one or two ceiling fittings that produce bright patches with gloom between them. So you walk down a tunnel of alternating light and dark, and the corridor feels longer and meaner than it is.

THE CORRECTION

- **Light the walls, not the floor.** Two or three wall lights along one side, centred around 150 to 165 cm, will do more than any number of ceiling fittings. Lit walls make a narrow space feel wider; a lit floor makes it feel like a route.
- **If you cannot add wiring, use the surfaces.** A small lamp on a narrow console, or a shelf at the far end with a lamp on it, gives you a lit destination. A corridor with something lit at the end of it stops being a tunnel.
- **Hang things at the right height, all the way along.** A corridor is the easiest place in the house to hang pictures, because you walk past rather than sitting, so the standard 145 cm centre is exactly right. A run of small pictures at a consistent height turns dead space into the best wall in the flat.
- **Do not paint it the same white as everything else.** A corridor is a transition and can take a stronger colour than a room you sit in, because you are only in it for four seconds. It is the cheapest place to be brave, because it is small and nobody lives in it.

INTERNAL ROOMS AND WINDOWLESS BATHROOMS

Treat these as the sunless room on page 39, with two additions. First, a windowless bathroom has a humidity problem as well as a light problem, and the extract fan matters more than anything decorative — if it does not clear the mirror within a few minutes of a shower, that is a ventilation job and worth sorting before you paint.

Second, these are the rooms where mirror placement is genuinely powerful, because a mirror opposite a lit wall or a lamp will double what little light there is and give the eye some depth. Put the light source and the mirror opposite each other, and stand where you will stand to check what you will be looking at.

BATHROOMS AND ELECTRICITY

Lighting and sockets in a bathroom are governed by specific rules about how close a fitting may be to water, and those rules exist for an extremely good reason. Anything beyond changing a bulb in an existing fitting is an electrician's job. There is no version of this where doing it yourself is sensible.

The daylight you are throwing away

Before you buy a single lamp, go and get back the light you already have. It is free, it takes an hour, and almost every home I have been in was wasting between a fifth and a third of it.

GO AND LOOK AT YOUR WINDOW. ALL OF IT.

1. **What is standing in front of it?** A tall plant, a lamp, a drying rack, a chair with coats on it, a stack of boxes that has been there since you moved in. Anything in the lower third of a window is taking light from the whole room.
2. **Where do the curtains sit when they are open?** This is the big one. In most homes the open curtains cover fifteen to twenty centimetres of glass down each side, because the pole is barely wider than the window. That is a tenth of your window, permanently, in every room, for years. The fix is a wider pole — it should extend 15 to 25 cm beyond the frame on each side so the curtains stack on the wall rather than on the glass.
3. **Is the blind fully up?** A roller blind left a third down is invisible to you after a week. Go and look. Roll it right up.
4. **Are the nets or sheers doing anything?** Permanent net curtains on a window that nobody can see into are costing you light for no reason. If privacy is only needed in the evening, a blind you drop is better than a sheer you never move.
5. **Is the glass clean, inside and out?** Unglamorous and genuinely significant on a window that has not been washed in a year or two, especially on a street.
6. **What colour is the reveal?** The little returns of wall at the sides of the window. If they are a dark colour, or grubby, they are absorbing light at the exact point it enters the room. Painting the reveal the palest thing in the room is a trick worth knowing.

> **WORTH SAYING ON ITS OWN**
>
> *Most people's curtains, when open, cover a tenth of their window. Nobody notices, because the curtains have always been there.*

Do all six of those before you spend anything. Then reassess the room. A surprising number of "dark" rooms are ordinary rooms with a blocked window, and you will have spent nothing.

WORKSHEET

The lighting plan for one room

One sheet per room. Fill the left column with what you have now, the right with what it should be.

ROOM

FACES / USED WHEN

SOURCE	HEIGHT NOW	SHOULD BE	BULB NOW	SHOULD BE
Ceiling				2700 K
				2700 K
				2700 K
				2700 K
				2700 K

THE THREE CHECKS

- [ ] At least one source below 60 cm / 24 in
- [ ] At least one source between 100 and 135 cm / 40 and 53 in
- [ ] Every bulb in this room is the same colour temperature
- [ ] I cannot see a bulb from where I sit
- [ ] The ceiling light can be off and the room still works
- [ ] One corner is deliberately left dark

FREE LIGHT I AM CURRENTLY WASTING

- [ ] Nothing stands in front of the lower third of the window
- [ ] Open curtains stack on the wall, not on the glass
- [ ] Blinds go fully up; no nets on a window nobody overlooks
- [ ] Glass is clean, both sides

WHAT I WILL DO FIRST, AND WHAT IT COSTS

WHAT NOT TO BUY

Lighting

Six things this industry sells constantly that will not solve the problem you bought them for.

COLOUR-CHANGING SMART BULBS, FOR A SITTING ROOM

The colour-changing is not the problem; the problem is that they are usually bought *instead* of a second lamp. A single ceiling fitting that can turn pink is still a single ceiling fitting. If you want smart bulbs, put them in three lamps at three heights and you have something genuinely good. One is a novelty.

"DAYLIGHT" BULBS FOR A DARK ROOM

Sold specifically at the problem and it makes it worse. Five or six thousand kelvin in a room with no daylight gives you a cold blue room. The word on the box is doing the selling.

A BRIGHTER CEILING FITTING

The instinct when a room is gloomy, and it is treating a direction problem as a quantity problem. You will get a bright ceiling and the same gloomy room.

SPOTLIGHT TRACKS AND DOWNLIGHT GRIDS, RETROFITTED

Often sold as a modern fix for a dull room. What they produce is a ceiling of small bright sources all pointing straight down — error one, multiplied. They have real uses over a worktop or aimed at art. As general lighting for a room where people sit, they are the most expensive way to get a corridor.

VERY CHEAP MULTIPACKS OF BULBS

Where the colour temperature and the CRI are not printed, both are usually bad. Your colours will not work after dark and you will not know why. A bulb is the highest-leverage cheap thing in a house; buy the ones with the numbers on.

A DIMMER SWITCH, BEFORE YOU HAVE CHECKED YOUR BULBS

Fitting a dimmer to non-dimmable LEDs produces flicker and buzz, and people conclude the dimmer is faulty. Check the bulbs first. And a wall dimmer is electrical work behind a faceplate, which is an electrician's job.

WHAT TO BUY INSTEAD, IN ORDER

2700 K bulbs for the whole house. Then one lamp for the floor, if you do not already own something that will do. Then an in-line dimmer for the lamp you sit next to. That is a complete lighting correction for a room, and in most homes it comes to less than the cost of a single ceiling fitting.

Part Two, in nine lines

ONE

Light before colour. You cannot choose a colour until you know which way the window faces.

TWO

Light must arrive at three heights — overhead, table, floor. A room lit from one height is a room lit like a corridor.

THREE

Twenty-seven hundred kelvin, or nothing.

AND THE SIX THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **You should never see a bulb from where you sit.** Every height in this part is that one rule, measured for a particular piece of furniture.
- **Every bulb in one room must match.** Mixed colour temperatures is the only lighting error the eye cannot get used to.
- **Brightness is not output, it is how many surfaces have light on them.** Five small lamps beat one big pendant, and use less electricity.
- **Light the walls, not the middle.** Lit walls make a room read larger.
- **Get the free light back first.** Widen the pole, unblock the sill, raise the blind, wash the glass. Before you spend anything.
- **Never make a final colour decision in a shop.** You are standing under four thousand kelvin from above, and you will never live under it.

IF YOU DO EXACTLY ONE THING

Buy 2700 K bulbs for the whole house and change them all in one afternoon. It is the cheapest, fastest, largest single correction available to you, and everything in Part Three depends on it, because you are about to choose colours and you need to know what light they will be living in.

Turn the ceiling light off tonight and put on two lamps instead. That is Part Two. Everything else is detail.

PART THREE

Colour

Colour is the correction people reach for first and should make fourth. This part covers how to test a colour so it cannot surprise you, what an undertone is and how to see one, the six whites worth knowing, why a small pale room looks smaller, and what to do with the ceiling.

How to actually test a colour · 47
Undertone · 50
The six whites · 53
The small pale room · 57
The fifth wall · 61
Sheen · 65

CHAPTER THREE

Colour is not a property of paint

This is the sentence that makes the rest of this part make sense, so I am going to spend a page on it.

When you look at a painted wall, what reaches your eye is not the paint. It is light that has hit the paint and bounced off it, having lost the wavelengths the pigment absorbed. So the colour you see is the product of two things: what the paint absorbs, and what the light was made of before it arrived.

Change either one and the colour changes. Not your impression of it — the actual light entering your eye.

This is why the same tin produces two different colours on a north wall and a south wall in the same flat. It is why the colour you chose under the shop's lights is not the colour you have at home. And it is why so many people conclude they are bad at choosing colours, when what actually happened is that they chose correctly for a light they do not own.

> **THE FIRST LAW AGAIN, BECAUSE NOW YOU CAN SEE WHY**
>
> *Light before colour. You cannot choose a colour until you know which way the window faces.*

THE NAME FOR THIS, SINCE KNOWING IT HELPS

When two colours match under one light and stop matching under another, the effect is called **metamerism**. It is the reason a cushion and a wall that agreed in the shop can disagree in your sitting room, and it is not anybody's fault. Two different pigment mixes can reflect the same overall colour under one light source and separate completely under another.

You cannot prevent it. You can only ever judge a colour in the place and the light it will live in — which is the entire method of the next four pages.

WHAT THIS PART WILL AND WILL NOT DO

It will give you a way of testing colour that removes almost all of the risk, a working understanding of undertone, the handful of whites that are worth knowing by behaviour, and a clear position on ceilings, woodwork and sheen.

It will not give you a palette to copy. I do not know your windows, and anybody who offers you a colour scheme without knowing which way your room faces is selling you something.

How to actually test a colour

One method. It takes two days of waiting and about twenty minutes of work, and it is the difference between choosing a colour and gambling on one.

1. **Buy sample pots, not chips.** Two or three shortlisted colours. A chip is printed ink on card; a sample pot is the actual paint.
2. **Paint two large sheets of paper per colour, not the wall.** A2 or larger — the biggest cheap paper you can find. Two coats, edge to edge, and let it dry fully. Paper rather than wall for three reasons: you can move it, the colour underneath is not showing through, and you are not left with test patches to cover later.
3. **Leave a white border, or cut the sheet to size.** Colour is judged against whatever surrounds it. A patch of colour on an existing wall is being read against that wall and will look wrong in a way that tells you nothing.
4. **Move the sheets around the room and leave them for two days.** On the wall facing the window. On the wall opposite it. In the darkest corner. Beside the curtain. Next to the sofa. Tape them up and go about your life.
5. **Look at them at four moments** — morning, the middle of the day, dusk, and at night with only your own lamps on. A colour that survives all four is a colour you can commit to. Most shortlists lose a candidate at dusk.

> **WHY PAPER AND NOT THE WALL**
>
> *A patch painted on a wall is being judged against the colour beside it. A sheet you can move is being judged against the room.*

THE COST OF SKIPPING THIS

A sample pot and two sheets of paper cost a few dollars. Repainting a room because the colour was wrong costs a weekend, the paint, and the furniture moving — twice. I have never met anybody who regretted the two days.

Why a two-centimetre chip tells you nothing

Every paint brand hands you a fan of small printed rectangles and invites you to choose a wall from one. It cannot be done, and here are the four reasons.

ONE · IT IS INK, NOT PAINT

A printed chip is a reproduction. It has none of the paint's actual pigment, none of its finish, and none of the way real paint sits and scatters light on a surface. It is a photograph of a colour.

TWO · SCALE CHANGES WHAT YOU SEE

A colour covering a whole wall reads as considerably more saturated and usually darker than the same colour on a small card. This is partly the eye adapting and partly light bouncing between walls, each bounce deepening the colour. A colour that looks gentle on a chip can be startling at four square metres. **Choose one or two steps paler than the chip you liked.**

THREE · IT IS SURROUNDED BY OTHER COLOURS

On a fan deck your chip sits between two neighbours, and your eye reads it against them. Pull it out and lay it on white paper and it is a different colour. This is simultaneous contrast and you cannot switch it off; you can only control what surrounds the sample.

FOUR · YOU ARE LOOKING AT IT UNDER SHOP LIGHT

Which is roughly four thousand kelvin from overhead and has nothing to do with your home. Page 35.

THE ONE THING ON A PAINT CARD WORTH READING

Many brands print an **LRV** — Light Reflectance Value — a number from 0 to 100 describing how much light the colour bounces back, where 0 is a theoretical black and 100 a theoretical white. It is the single most useful figure on the card, because it predicts how a colour will behave in a dark room better than the colour itself does. Anything above about 70 is behaving as a pale colour. Below about 25 it is behaving as a dark one.

Use the chips to narrow fifty colours to three. Then stop using them and paint the paper.

Reading the sheets once they are up

You have three painted sheets taped around the room and two days have passed. This is how to read them, because most people look and cannot say what they are seeing.

ASK FOUR QUESTIONS, IN THIS ORDER

1. **At the darkest moment of the day, is it still a colour?** Look at dusk, before the lamps go on. Many pale colours collapse to grey at this hour. If it goes dead, it will be dead every evening of the year.
2. **In the brightest light it gets, does it go chalky or garish?** Direct sun on a pale colour can bleach it to nothing; direct sun on a saturated one can make it shout.
3. **Under your own lamps at night, has it changed hue?** Not just darkened — changed. Greens go grey, greys go lilac, whites go yellow. This is the test that catches the most mistakes, and it is the one nobody runs.
4. **Against the things that are staying in the room** — the floor, the sofa, the curtain, the door — does it sit comfortably or does one of them start to look wrong? Move the sheet next to each in turn.

WHAT A GOOD ANSWER LOOKS LIKE

The colour you want is the one that is slightly less interesting than its rivals at every hour, and never actively wrong at any of them. Colours that are thrilling at one particular moment are usually exhausting to live with, because the other twenty-three hours are the compromise.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My father used to say that the colour you notice is the colour you will get tired of. He chose for the light, not for the card, and he always looked at a colour last thing at night before he would agree to mix a full tin of it.

IF TWO SURVIVE

Take the paler one. Every colour goes a little deeper once it covers a whole room and the light starts bouncing between the walls, and almost nobody in the history of decorating has wished their walls were darker after the second coat.

Undertone, and why nobody explains it

This is the concept that separates people who can choose colours from people who cannot, and it is usually described so vaguely that it sounds like intuition. It is not. It is a simple thing.

Almost no paint colour is pure. A grey is never only grey; there is a little blue in it, or a little green, or a little violet, or a little brown. That trace is the **undertone**, and it is what the colour reveals when it is put next to something else or lit by something else.

You can ignore a colour's undertone right up until the moment it meets another colour. Then it is the only thing that matters. A grey with a blue undertone beside a grey with a green undertone will look dirty, and neither is a bad colour. They simply disagree.

WHY THIS RUINS SO MANY ROOMS

Because most rooms are not one colour. They are a wall colour, a ceiling white, a woodwork white, a floor, a sofa and a curtain — six things, each with an undertone, chosen at different times by different logics. If four of them lean warm and two lean cool, the room will feel subtly wrong and nobody will be able to say why. Everything in it is perfectly nice.

> **THE PRACTICAL RULE**
>
> *You do not need to know which undertone a room has. You need all of them to be the same one.*

THE SHORTCUT, IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS PAGE

Decide once, for the whole flat, whether you are warm or cool. Then choose everything on that side — the whites, the greys, the timber, the metals. A consistently warm room and a consistently cool room are both beautiful. A room that is half of each is the one that reads as cheap.

Which one should you pick? Look at what you cannot change. The floor, usually. A honey oak floor has decided that your flat is warm, whatever you were planning. Fighting the largest surface in the room is a losing argument.

How to see an undertone

You cannot see an undertone by staring at a colour on its own. You can only see it by comparison, and once you know the trick you will never lose it.

THE WHITE PAPER TEST

Take a sheet of ordinary printer paper — which is a very cool, very bright white — and hold your sample against it.

- If the sample suddenly looks yellow, pink or brown, it is **warm**.
- If it looks blue, grey or slightly violet, it is **cool**.
- If it looks green, it is green, and greens behave as their own family — see below.

That is the whole test. It takes four seconds and it works on paint, fabric, tile and timber equally.

THE THREE-SAMPLE TEST, WHICH IS BETTER

Put your candidate between two colours you already know. If you have a warm white and a cool white to hand, lay the sample between them. The one it resembles is the side it is on. This is more reliable than the paper test because it gives your eye two references instead of one.

THE UNDERTONES YOU WILL MEET MOST OFTEN

FAMILY	WARM VERSION LEANS	COOL VERSION LEANS
White	cream, yellow, a little pink	blue, grey, violet
Grey	brown — a "greige"	blue or violet
Green	olive, moss, yellow-green	sage, teal, blue-green
Beige	orange, gold	pink, mauve — the classic trap
Timber	oak, cherry, walnut	ash, limed oak, grey-washed

THE BEIGE TRAP, SINCE IT CATCHES EVERYONE

Beiges and taupes are the hardest colours in the shop, because a great many of them have a pink or mauve undertone that is invisible on a chip and unmistakable on a wall in afternoon light. If you are considering a beige, run the paper test twice — once in daylight and once under a lamp — before you buy anything.

There is no such thing as white

Every paint brand sells between forty and a hundred whites. That is not cynicism. It is because white is not a colour but a whole family of them, and the differences are the entire point.

A white paint is a white pigment with a small amount of something else added. What that something else is decides everything about how the colour behaves on your wall.

THE THREE THINGS THAT DIFFER BETWEEN WHITES

- **The undertone.** Yellow, red, blue, green or grey, in a very small quantity. This is what decides whether your room feels warm or cold.
- **How much of it there is.** A white with a trace of yellow is a warm white; a white with a good deal of yellow is cream, which behaves as a colour and not as a white.
- **Whether any black or grey has been added.** A white knocked back with grey is softer, less reflective, and much easier to live with than a brilliant white — and most of the whites that decorators use are of this kind.

THE ONE TO BE CAREFUL OF

Most brands sell a **brilliant white** or **pure white** which has optical brighteners in it, making it the coldest and most reflective thing you can put on a wall. It is designed to read as clean and it does. It is also unforgiving: it shows every flaw in the plaster, it goes blue in a north room, and it makes everything you put against it look slightly grubby, including other whites.

It has real uses — a gallery, a workshop, a ceiling in a room that needs every photon it can get. It is almost never the right white for a room where people sit.

> **IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING ABOUT WHITE**
>
> *A white with a little grey in it looks expensive. A brilliant white looks like a rental.*

That is a judgement rather than a fact, and it is one I will defend. Brilliant white is what a landlord reaches for because it is cheap, fast and neutral to every future tenant. Your eye has learned that association, and it applies it to your own walls.

THE SIX WHITES

Described by behaviour, not by brand

I am not going to give you product names, because they change, they differ by country, and a name tells you nothing about what a colour will do in your room. I am going to describe six whites by how they behave. Every brand sells all six.

ONE · BRILLIANT WHITE

No undertone, often optically brightened. LRV near 90 or above.

The coldest and most reflective. Shows every imperfection. Goes blue in north light. Makes adjacent whites look dirty.

Use it for: a ceiling in a genuinely dark room where reflectance matters more than warmth. A workshop. Almost nothing else.

TWO · SOFT WHITE — WHITE WITH A LITTLE GREY

Grey undertone, LRV roughly 80 to 88.

The most useful white there is. Reads as white but has enough body to stop it glaring, and it is forgiving of imperfect plaster. Works in more rooms than anything else in this list.

Use it for: walls in almost any room, ceilings in most rooms, and woodwork if you want it quiet. If you cannot decide, this is the answer.

THREE · WARM WHITE — WHITE WITH A LITTLE YELLOW

Yellow undertone, LRV roughly 80 to 88.

Gentle, slightly sunny, flatters skin and timber. In strong south light it can tip towards cream, which some people love and some find dated.

Use it for: north-facing rooms, which need the warmth; rooms with honey or oak floors; bedrooms.

READING THE NUMBERS

LRV figures here are the ordinary ranges these whites fall into, not a rule. Use them to compare candidates on the same card: a white at 84 will behave noticeably differently in a dark room from one at 74, and the number will tell you that before your eye does.

The six whites, continued

FOUR · COOL WHITE — WHITE WITH A LITTLE BLUE OR VIOLET

Blue undertone, LRV roughly 80 to 88.

Crisp and slightly austere. In a south-facing room it is genuinely beautiful, because the warm sunlight cancels the blue and leaves something very clean. In a north-facing room it is bleak.

Use it for: south and west rooms, bathrooms, kitchens with a lot of daylight. Never a north room.

FIVE · GREIGE — WHITE KNOCKED WELL BACK WITH WARM GREY

Brown-grey undertone, LRV roughly 60 to 75.

No longer really a white; it is a very pale colour. Reads as soft, quiet and slightly expensive, and it is extremely forgiving of poor light and poor plaster.

Use it for: the room you cannot make work. Hallways, north rooms, rooms with a lot of mismatched furniture that needs calming down.

SIX · CREAM — WHITE WITH A GOOD DEAL OF YELLOW

Strong yellow undertone, LRV roughly 70 to 84.

Behaves as a colour, not a white. Warm, soft, and strongly associated with older interiors; whether that reads as handsome or dated depends entirely on what you put with it. It is unbeatable against dark timber, old brass and worn stone.

Use it for: period rooms, rooms with substantial woodwork, anywhere with an open fire.

THE MOST COMMON WHITE MISTAKE

Using two different whites in the same room without meaning to — a cool white on the ceiling and a warm white on the walls, or trade white on the woodwork and something chosen on the walls. The eye reads the mismatch as dirt rather than as a decision. Either use one white throughout, or make the difference large enough to be obviously deliberate.

Which white for which room

The whole of the last three pages, reduced to a table you can take to the shop. Find your room's orientation on the left.

ROOM FACES	CHOOSE	AVOID	BECAUSE
North	Warm white · Greige · Cream	Cool white · Brilliant white	The light is blue all day and will drain anything cool. Warmth in the paint replaces warmth the window cannot give.
South	Cool white · Soft white	Cream · strong warm white	The sun supplies the warmth. A warm white under warm light tips into yellow.
East used mornings	Soft white · Cool white	Cream	Morning sun is clear and slightly golden; the room can take something crisper.
East used afternoons	Warm white · Greige	Cool white	After mid-morning it behaves exactly like a north room. Treat it as one.
West	Soft white · Cool white	Cream	Cool all morning, then very warm evening light pulls everything back. Cool paint is safe here.
No window	None of them — see page 39	all whites	White needs light to be white. Without it, go warm and deep instead.

TWO NOTES ON USING THIS TABLE

It is a starting point, not a verdict. It narrows a hundred whites to about a dozen. You still paint the sheets and you still look at them at dusk.

What is outside the window can override it. A large tree throws green light into a room for half the year. A red brick wall two metres away throws warm light in all year. If either is true of your room, test more carefully than the table suggests.

Where white fails

White is the default, which means it is chosen far more often than it is decided. Here are the five rooms where it is the wrong answer, and what to do instead.

ONE · THE ROOM WITH NO DAYLIGHT

Covered on page 39 and worth repeating here: white needs light to be white. In a sunless room it goes grey and dead, and a grey dead room announces what it is missing. Go warm and deep instead.

TWO · THE SMALL ROOM YOU WANT TO FEEL FINISHED

See the next page, which argues this one out properly.

THREE · THE ROOM WITH BAD PLASTER

White, and especially brilliant white, is the least forgiving finish there is. Every ripple, patch and filled hole reads. A colour with some depth in it, in a matt finish, hides a surprising amount. If your walls are old and uneven, paint is doing repair work as well as decoration.

FOUR · THE TRANSITIONAL SPACE

Hallways, landings, corridors, cloakrooms. You are in them for seconds, so they can carry a much stronger colour than a room you sit in — and because they are small and dark they tend to make white look grubby. This is the cheapest place in the house to be brave.

FIVE · THE ROOM THAT IS ALREADY FULL OF WHITE THINGS

A white kitchen with white units, white tiles and white appliances does not need white walls as well. At some point the room stops reading as clean and starts reading as unresolved, because there is nothing for the eye to measure the whites against.

> **THE TEST**
>
> *Ask whether you chose white or defaulted to it. If you cannot say what the alternative was, you defaulted.*

None of which is an argument against white. Half the rooms I have worked in ended up white, and page 55 exists because choosing the right one matters. It is an argument against white as a way of avoiding the decision.

MY MOST UNPOPULAR POSITION

A small room painted pale looks smaller

I want to mark this clearly: this is my professional opinion and not a law of physics. It is also the piece of advice I have most often been argued with about, and most often been thanked for later.

The standard advice is that pale colours make a small room feel larger. The reasoning is that pale walls reflect more light, and a brighter room reads as bigger. The first half of that is true — a high-LRV colour genuinely does bounce more light. The conclusion does not follow.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS IN A SMALL PALE ROOM

- **You can see exactly where the walls are.** A pale wall is legible. Every corner, every junction, every edge is clearly drawn, and your eye measures the room accurately — which in a small room is not what you want.
- **Every flaw is on display.** The radiator, the cables, the patched plaster, the mismatched skirting. In a small room these are close to you and there is nowhere for them to hide.
- **It reads as unfinished.** Because the association is with rooms that have not been decided about: rentals, new builds before anyone moves in, rooms between tenants.

WHAT HAPPENS IN A SMALL DARK ROOM

The corners soften and the eye loses the exact edges of the space, so the room stops announcing its dimensions. The flaws recede. And most importantly it reads as *deliberate* — nobody paints a room deep green by accident, so the room is immediately understood as a choice rather than a shortage.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE SMALL PALE ROOM**
>
> *A small room painted pale does not look bigger. It looks small and cheap. A small room painted deep looks deliberate.*

WHERE I CONCEDE

If the small room is also the only room, and you are in it all day, and it has one small window, a deep colour can genuinely be oppressive. And if you are selling the flat, pale is the commercially safe answer, because buyers are told the same advice I am arguing with. Both of those are real. Neither is about how the room looks.

What a deep colour actually does

If you are going to take the argument on the last page seriously, you need to know what you are buying. Four things happen, and the third surprises people.

ONE · THE EDGES OF THE ROOM STOP BEING LEGIBLE

In a dark room, the corner where two walls meet carries very little contrast, so your eye cannot place it precisely. The room's boundary becomes approximate. This is the whole mechanism behind "it feels bigger", and it is the opposite of the reason usually given.

TWO · EVERYTHING IN FRONT OF THE WALL GAINS CONTRAST

A pale lamp against a dark wall has enormous presence. A picture frame reads. A plant reads. A face reads. In a pale room all of these are competing with a bright background and lose; in a dark room they are lit objects against a quiet ground, which is how a painting is hung in a gallery and why it works.

THREE · THE LIGHTING STARTS DOING MUCH MORE WORK

This is the one people are not warned about. A dark room absorbs light rather than bouncing it, so a single ceiling fitting will not carry it — the room will simply be gloomy. Deep colour and the three heights from Part Two are a package. If you paint a room dark and light it from one point, you will hate it, and you will blame the colour.

FOUR · THE ROOM ACQUIRES A TIME OF DAY

A dark room is at its best in the evening, under lamps, and is frankly a little sombre at ten in the morning. That is fine for a sitting room, a dining room or a study. It is a real consideration for a room you work in all day.

BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Paint the sheets, as always, but for a deep colour paint *four* and put them on all four walls at once, because a dark colour on one wall of a pale room tells you nothing about a dark room. And check page 61 first: in most cases a deep colour wants the ceiling and woodwork to go with it, and that changes the size of the job.

How dark is dark enough

The commonest failure with a deep colour is not going far enough. A mid-tone is the one place you genuinely should not stop.

There are broadly three places a wall colour can sit, and the middle one is the trap.

ROUGHLY	READS AS	VERDICT
LRV 70–90	Pale. The wall is a background and stays quiet.	Works. Commits to being light.
LRV 35–70	Mid-tone. Too dark to disappear, too pale to enclose.	**The trap.** Often reads as a colour that was meant to be braver.
LRV under 25	Deep. The wall recedes and becomes a ground.	Works. Commits to being dark.

These bands are a working guide rather than a standard, and the boundaries are soft — a saturated mid-tone in a well-lit room can be excellent. But if you find yourself choosing a colour because it seems like a sensible compromise between pale and dark, that is usually the signal to go one way or the other.

WHY THE MIDDLE FAILS

Because both mechanisms need commitment. A pale colour works by reflecting light and staying out of the way; a deep colour works by absorbing light and softening the edges. A mid-tone does neither. It is bright enough that you still read every corner, and dark enough that the room is noticeably dimmer. You have paid the cost of the dark room and bought none of the benefit.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

A client in Lyon asked my grandmother what colour to paint a small dining room. She said: either a colour you could read a book against, or a colour you could not. Anything in between and you will repaint it within two years. She was right about that woman, who repainted it within two years.

THE PRACTICAL VERSION

Choose your candidate. Then find the version of it two or three steps darker on the same strip and test that one too. Nine times out of ten the darker one is the answer.

WORKSHEET

Choosing a colour for one room

Fill the top before you go shopping. Fill the bottom after the sheets have been up for two days.

ROOM

FACES / USED WHEN

WARM OR COOL (DECIDED BY THE FLOOR)

WHAT IS OUTSIDE THE WINDOW

THE THREE CANDIDATES

COLOUR	LRV	UNDERTONE (PAPER TEST)	WARM / COOL

THE FOUR VIEWINGS

	MORNING	MIDDAY	DUSK	LAMPS ONLY
Candidate 1				
Candidate 2				
Candidate 3				

THE CHECKS

- [ ] Painted on paper, two coats, not on the wall
- [ ] Moved to at least three positions in the room
- [ ] Held against the floor, the sofa and the curtain
- [ ] Still a colour at dusk, before the lamps go on
- [ ] Has not changed hue under my own lamps at night
- [ ] Same undertone as everything else staying in the room

CHOSEN — AND ONE SENTENCE ON WHY

THE FIFTH WALL

What to do with a ceiling

You met *le cinquième mur* on page 11. Here is the decision, and there are only three answers.

ONE · A WHITE, BUT CHOSEN RATHER THAN ASSUMED

The default, and correct more often than not — but not brilliant white, and not a different white from the walls. The usual best answer is **the wall colour mixed with white at about a quarter strength**, which most merchants will do for you. It reads as white, it belongs to the room, and the junction where wall meets ceiling stops being a hard line.

TWO · THE SAME COLOUR AS THE WALLS

Wall colour taken straight across the ceiling. This is the one that surprises people, and in the right room it is the best thing in this part of the book. What it does is remove the boundary between wall and ceiling, so the room reads as a single volume rather than a box with a lid.

Best in: small rooms, rooms with awkward angles or sloping ceilings, box rooms, and any room you want to feel enclosing rather than tall. It is also the answer to a ceiling covered in pipework or patches, because it stops advertising them.

THREE · DARKER THAN THE WALLS

A deliberate move for a room with a high ceiling that feels cold or cavernous. A darker ceiling appears to come closer, which brings a tall room down to a human scale.

Best in: high-ceilinged period rooms — a Haussmannian apartment runs between two point eight and three point two metres, and a room like that can carry a dark ceiling easily. A dining room. Anywhere you want the evening to feel intimate.

THE ONE THING NOT TO DO

Leave the old brilliant white ceiling in place while painting the walls a considered colour. It is the most common half-finished job there is: a careful colour on four surfaces and a cold builder's white on the fifth, meeting it in a hard line all the way round the room. Whatever you choose, choose it.

One colour, everywhere

Walls, ceiling, woodwork, skirting, door, window frame — all in the same colour. It sounds extreme. It is the single most reliable way to make an ordinary room look considered.

WHY IT WORKS

Every junction in a room is a place where the eye stops: wall to ceiling, wall to skirting, wall to architrave, architrave to door. An ordinary room has dozens, and each one is drawn in high contrast because the woodwork is white and the wall is not. Your eye spends the whole time tracing an outline of the room's plumbing.

Take the contrast out of those junctions and they stop being events. What is left is a single quiet volume with your furniture in it — and the furniture, the art and the people become the things you look at, because they are now the only things with contrast in the room.

WHERE IT EARNS ITS KEEP MOST

- **Rooms with ugly or excessive woodwork.** Boxed-in pipes, a radiator, four doors, a fuse box. Painting all of it out is the only cheap fix that genuinely works.
- **Small rooms and awkward shapes.** Attic rooms with sloping ceilings, box rooms, under-stair spaces.
- **Hallways**, which are almost entirely made of junctions.

HOW TO DO IT PROPERLY

Use **one colour in different finishes**, not one finish everywhere: matt on the walls and ceiling, eggshell or satin on the woodwork. The colour reads as continuous, but the woodwork is durable and washable, and the slight difference in sheen gives the room a subtle life that a single flat finish does not have. Page 65 covers sheens.

> ### WHY THIS IS NOT JUST A TREND
>
> *Before white paint was cheap, rooms were routinely finished in one colour throughout, because mixing several was expensive. What looks like a bold modern choice is mostly a return to the ordinary.*

Skirtings, architraves and doors

Woodwork is white because woodwork is white. It is the same unexamined default as the ceiling, and it is doing more harm in more rooms.

Add up the woodwork in an ordinary room: skirting all the way round, architrave round the door and the window, the door itself, perhaps a picture rail. It is a considerable area, and in most homes it is painted the brightest white in the house, in the shiniest finish in the house, outlining every edge of the room in high contrast.

THE FOUR OPTIONS, FROM QUIETEST TO LOUDEST

1. **The same colour as the walls.** Everything disappears. See the previous page. The best answer in most small and awkward rooms.
2. **A shade or two deeper than the walls, same colour family.** The woodwork reads as a soft frame rather than a bright outline. Elegant, easy, and almost impossible to get wrong.
3. **A soft white or greige rather than brilliant white.** If you want the contrast of white woodwork without the glare. This is the standard decorator's answer and it suits period rooms with good mouldings that deserve to be seen.
4. **A deliberately contrasting colour.** A deep green skirting under pale walls, a black door. A real move with real presence, and the one most likely to go wrong. Commit to it across the whole room or it looks like an unfinished job.

THE DOOR IS WORTH ITS OWN THOUGHT

A door is a large flat rectangle at eye level, and painting it the wall colour makes it vanish — which is usually what you want in a small room with several doors. Painting it a deep colour when the walls are pale makes it an object, which is worth doing when the door is handsome and there is only one of them.

OLD PAINT, AND PLEASE READ THIS ONE

Woodwork in older buildings can carry many layers. In the United States, lead-based paint was banned for residential use in 1978; other countries have their own dates, generally in the same era. Sanding old woodwork is what makes lead dangerous, because it puts it into the air. If your building predates that and you are planning to sand woodwork back, get the paint tested first. This is not a job to guess at, and it is the one place in this book where I would rather you did nothing than proceed uncertain.

The accent wall, properly examined

I dismissed this in one paragraph on page 20. It is common enough to deserve the full argument, and there is a version that works.

WHAT GOES WRONG

- **It shortens the room.** A darker surface is read by the eye as nearer. Paint one wall dark and three pale, and the room appears shorter in that direction. People almost always paint the far wall, and the far wall is the one whose distance they were hoping to increase.
- **It divides rather than transforms.** The room now has two characters and a hard line between them, and the line is the thing you see.
- **It is often the window wall**, which is the worst choice available: you have put your darkest surface immediately around your only light source, so the contrast between the bright window and the dark wall is at its most severe and the room reads as gloomy.
- **The junctions get worse, not better.** Now there are two colours meeting at two corners, plus white woodwork, plus a white ceiling. More edges, not fewer.

THE VERSION THAT WORKS

Not an accent wall — an **accent volume**. Take the colour round an entire part of the room that is architecturally separate: an alcove and the shelves in it, a chimney breast including its returns, the inside of a bookcase, a bay, a small connected room seen through a doorway.

The difference is that you are colouring a *thing* rather than a surface. An alcove painted deep green is an alcove. The far wall painted deep green is a wall that has been painted a different colour from the other three.

> **THE TEST BEFORE YOU PAINT ONE WALL**
>
> *Ask whether the surface you are about to colour is a thing or a side. Paint things. Leave sides alone.*

And if what you actually want is for the room to feel different — the thing an accent wall promises — the answer is on page 62. One colour on all four walls and the ceiling changes a room far more than one wall in five ever will, and takes about the same amount of paint.

Sheen, which is half the decision

Two tins of the identical colour in different finishes are two different colours on the wall. Sheen is not a detail at the end of the process; it changes what you see.

Sheen is how much light a finish reflects directly back at you rather than scattering it. A flat finish scatters almost everything, so the colour looks deep, soft and even. A gloss finish bounces a good deal straight back, so the colour looks lighter, harder and more variable depending on where you stand.

THE TRADE YOU ARE MAKING, IN ONE LINE

> **THE SHEEN TRADE**
>
> *More sheen is more washable and more durable. Less sheen is more beautiful and hides more. Choose by how much the surface gets touched.*

THE FIVE LEVELS

FINISH	LOOKS	HIDES FLAWS	WIPES CLEAN
Flat / matt	Deepest colour, velvety, no reflection at all	Best	Poorly — can burnish if scrubbed
Matt emulsion	Soft, very slight sheen	Very well	Gently
Eggshell	Low sheen, slightly luminous	Moderately	Well
Satin	Noticeable sheen, colour lifts	Poorly	Very well
Gloss	Mirror-like, shows every ripple	Not at all	Best

THE ONE THAT CATCHES PEOPLE OUT

A colour in satin or gloss will read **lighter** than the same colour in matt, because more light is coming straight back to your eye. If you test in matt and buy in satin you will not get the colour you chose. Test in the finish you intend to use.

And a practical warning about deep colours in matt: they are the most beautiful finish in this table and the least repairable. A scuff cannot simply be wiped, and a touch-up patch will often show unless you re-coat the whole wall. Lovely in a sitting room. Not in a hallway with a bicycle in it.

Which sheen, where

The whole of the last page as a table. This is the one to photograph before you go to the shop.

SURFACE	USE	WHY
Sitting room and bedroom walls	**Matt**	Deepest colour, hides plaster, rarely touched
Ceilings, everywhere	**Flat or matt**	Any sheen overhead catches the light and shows every roller line
Hallway and stair walls	**Matt emulsion or eggshell**	Hands, bags, bicycles. Needs to survive wiping
Kitchen walls	**Eggshell or satin**	Grease and steam. Must wash
Bathroom walls	**Eggshell or a bathroom-specific matt**	Moisture. A flat finish will not survive it
Skirting, architrave, doors	**Eggshell or satin**	Kicked, knocked, cleaned. Needs a hard film
Windowsills	**Satin or gloss**	Hardest wear and most moisture in the room
Radiators	**Eggshell or satin**, radiator-grade	Ordinary paint yellows with heat
A room with bad plaster	**Flat, always**	Sheen is what reveals an uneven surface

THE RULE UNDER THE TABLE

Work out how often a hand touches the surface. Never touched: matt. Touched weekly: eggshell. Touched daily or wet: satin. That single question answers nine of these ten rows without the table.

ONE HONEST EFFICIENCY

You do not need five tins. For most flats, **two** is genuinely enough: matt for walls and ceilings, eggshell for all woodwork. Add a satin only if you have a wet room or a hallway that takes real punishment. The five-level table exists so you know what you are choosing between, not so you buy all of it.

A USEFUL STORY

The most copied French colour is a mistake

There is a grey that the design world has been copying for two hundred years, and restoration has now established that it was never the original colour at all.

It is called *gris Trianon* — Trianon grey. It appears as a named court colour in Versailles inventory documents of the 1770s and 1780s, and it is associated with the Temple of Love at the Petit Trianon, the small palace in the grounds of Versailles. It is a soft dove grey that reads almost as cement in poor light and as a pale barley-taupe in good light, and if you have ever seen a photograph of a beautiful French room with grey panelling, you have seen its descendants.

What restoration work at the Trianon has revealed is that the famous grey is a **nineteenth-century repaint**. Underneath it, the original finish was a pale green.

So the colour that the whole world understands as the authentic colour of eighteenth-century French elegance is a Victorian decorator's decision, applied over the real thing, and copied ever since by people who believed they were being faithful.

> **WHY I PUT THIS IN A BOOK ABOUT YOUR FLAT**
>
> *There is no authentic colour to be faithful to. There is only what works in the light you have.*

AND IT IS STILL A VERY GOOD GREY

That is the other half of the point. Knowing it is a repaint does not make it worse. It is a warm grey with enough green in it to stay soft under electric light, which is exactly why it has survived two centuries of copying — it behaves well. The nineteenth-century decorator who chose it knew what they were doing.

If you want a grey that does not go cold at night, look for one with a trace of green rather than blue in it. That is the whole technical content of this famous colour, and it costs nothing to apply.

OLD WALLS

Badigeon à la chaux — limewash

If your building is old and has solid walls, this page may save you a great deal of trouble, and it is the one my father would have wanted in the book.

Limewash is one of the oldest wall finishes there is — lime finishes go back to Greek and Roman building. It is made of three things: slaked lime, water, and natural pigment. That is the whole recipe. It dries to a chalky, matte, faintly variegated surface with a quality of depth that modern paint cannot reproduce, because you are looking slightly *into* it rather than at a film on top.

THE PROPERTY THAT MATTERS MORE THAN THE LOOK

Limewash is **breathable**. It is porous, so moisture in a wall can pass through it and evaporate away.

Old buildings with solid walls and no damp-proof course are designed to work this way. They take up moisture and release it again, constantly, and they stay sound as long as nothing stops them. A modern plastic-based paint forms an impermeable film, which traps that moisture in the wall. The result is damp that appears after redecorating, blown plaster, and paint that lifts off in sheets — and the owner concludes the wall has a damp problem, when what it has is a paint problem.

TWO REAL CAUTIONS

Wet lime is **caustic**. It has a very high pH and it will burn skin and eyes. Gloves and eye protection, every time, and this is not a place to be relaxed about it.

And limewash will not adhere to a wall that is already covered in modern emulsion. It needs a porous surface — bare plaster, lime plaster, brick or stone. Painting it over vinyl emulsion will simply produce dust.

WHO THIS IS ACTUALLY FOR

If you live in a modern building with plasterboard walls, none of this applies to you and ordinary paint is correct. If you live in something old with thick solid walls, it is worth finding out what is already on them before you add another layer, because the wrong finish on an old wall is a slow and expensive mistake.

How many colours a home should have

Fewer than you think, and repeated more than you think. This is the page that makes a flat feel like one home rather than a series of decisions.

THE WORKING SCHEME

1. **One white.** The same white on every ceiling and every piece of woodwork in the flat, unless a room is being drenched in its own colour. One tin, one decision, permanent consistency.
2. **One quiet colour** that carries the circulation — hall, landing, stairs, and any room you have not made a specific decision about. This is the flat's ground note.
3. **Two or three room colours**, each belonging to a room with a distinct character. The bedroom, the sitting room, perhaps a study or dining room.
4. **One deeper accent** that appears in small quantities across several rooms — a door, an alcove, a bookcase interior. This is the thread that stitches the flat together.

Five or six colours for a whole home. Most flats I have worked in had eleven or twelve, all chosen separately, none of them wrong, and the whole never adding up.

> ### WHY REPETITION MATTERS MORE THAN VARIETY
>
> *A colour used once is a decoration. The same colour used three times in three rooms is a scheme.*

THE DOORWAY TEST

Stand in any doorway where you can see into two rooms at once, which in most flats is the hall. Everything visible from that spot has to agree, because you will see it together several times a day.

This is where the undertone rule from page 50 does its real work: not within a room, but across a threshold. Two rooms that are lovely on their own and disagree at the doorway is the commonest whole-flat error there is, and it is invisible until you go and stand there.

And the practical benefit: one white and one circulation colour means you own two large tins that cover nine-tenths of the surfaces in the flat. Touching up becomes trivial, and it costs less.

The floor has already voted

The largest continuous surface in your home is the one you almost certainly cannot change. Every colour decision above it is a response to it, whether you meant it to be or not.

A floor is typically a quarter of the visible surface of a room, it runs under everything, and it is lit from above all day, which means it is bouncing its own colour onto the bottom of everything in the room. A warm honey oak floor is putting a warm cast on your walls continuously.

READ THE FLOOR FIRST

FLOOR	HAS DECIDED	WORK WITH
Honey or golden oak	warm, quite strongly	warm whites, greige, olive and moss greens, warm browns
Mid brown, walnut	warm, moderately	almost anything warm; very forgiving
Grey or limed timber	cool	cool whites, blue-greys, sage
Red-toned timber or terracotta	warm, very strongly	creams, olive, deep green; avoid pink-beige entirely
Grey tile or concrete	cool	cool or neutral; add warmth in textiles instead
Mid-grey carpet	usually cool, check it	run the paper test on the carpet — many read violet

IF YOU ARE FIGHTING THE FLOOR

You will lose. A cool grey wall above an orange-toned floor is a fight that happens in every room of the flat, all day, and no amount of styling settles it. The honest options are to work with the floor's temperature, to cover a good deal of it with a rug in your chosen temperature, or to change the floor — which is expensive and is the only place in this book where I would say the expensive answer is often correct.

> ### THE FLOOR RUNS THROUGH
>
> *One continuous floor through connected rooms makes a small flat read as one home. A change of flooring at every threshold chops it into cupboards.*

This is mine and it is about layout as much as colour. If you are ever in a position to choose flooring for more than one room, choose the same one and run it through. It is the single most effective thing you can do to make a small flat feel generous.

Matching is a trap

The instinct, once you have chosen a wall colour, is to find a cushion in the same colour. Resist it. Matching is what makes a room look like it came in a box.

Two things prevent an exact match from ever working. The first is that the same colour in two different materials is not the same colour — paint on plaster and dye in wool reflect light completely differently, so a perfect match on paper reads as a near-miss in the room, and a near-miss is worse than a difference. The second is that a room where everything agrees exactly has nothing for the eye to do.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

- **Stay in the family, change the depth.** If the walls are a soft green, the cushions can be a much deeper green or a much paler one. Same undertone, different value. This always works.
- **Repeat the colour in a different material.** The wall colour appearing again in a ceramic, a book spine, a painting — small, and in something with a different surface. The eye enjoys finding it.
- **Let one thing disagree on purpose.** A room that is entirely harmonious is slightly dead. One object in a colour that has no relationship to the scheme is what stops it feeling assembled.

THE ONE THING THAT GENUINELY SHOULD MATCH

Whites. If you have white woodwork, white ceilings and white curtains, those *should* be the same white or obviously different whites, never nearly-the-same whites. Near-misses in white read as dirt. This is the exception to everything on this page.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My grandmother would not sell a client a fabric that matched their wall. She said a room should look as though it had been arrived at over years, not delivered on a Tuesday. She had been making curtains for thirty years by then and could afford to say so.

Colour when you cannot paint

Part Six is written entirely for rented rooms. This page is the colour half of it, because everything above assumes a paintbrush you may not be allowed to pick up.

FIRST, CHECK WHETHER YOU ACTUALLY CANNOT

A great many tenancies permit redecoration with written permission, and a landlord who has a white magnolia flat is often perfectly happy for you to improve it at your own cost if you agree to return it to neutral. It is worth one email. The worst answer is no, which is where you are already.

IF THE ANSWER IS NO, THE ORDER CHANGES

Without paint, the largest colour surfaces available to you are, in order of area:

1. **Curtains.** Floor to near-ceiling, across a whole wall, in a colour you chose. This is by a wide margin the biggest colour decision available to a tenant, and Part Four covers how to hang them so they read as architecture rather than as fabric.
2. **A large rug.** The second largest surface, and the one that can override an unpleasant floor's temperature. Bigger than feels sensible — page 97.
3. **The bed, in a bedroom.** A bed dressed in one considered colour is most of the visual field in a small bedroom.
4. **Bookcases and their contents**, which are a wall of colour you already own.
5. **Large art or a hanging textile.** One big thing beats six small ones.

THE WHITE-WALL STRATEGY

If you are stuck with landlord white, stop treating it as a background to improve and start treating it as a gallery wall. White walls are genuinely excellent behind strong colour and strong texture — it is only as a whole scheme that they fail. Go deeper and warmer in everything you can control, and let the walls be the quiet part.

ONE THING WORTH KNOWING

Magnolia and builder's white are usually a cheap vinyl matt, which marks easily and cleans badly. If you are allowed to repaint before you leave, budget for it — a flat returned in fresh white is often the difference between getting a deposit back and arguing about it.

MISTAKES TO AVOID

The six colour errors I saw most often

ONE · CHOOSING THE COLOUR BEFORE FIXING THE LIGHT

The error this whole book is ordered around. You choose for a light you are about to change, and then you have chosen wrong. Bulbs first, always — it is an afternoon and it decides everything.

TWO · TESTING ON THE WALL INSTEAD OF ON PAPER

A patch painted on an existing wall is judged against that wall, and the old colour around it biases everything you see. It also means you cannot move it to the dark corner, which is the position that matters most.

THREE · TWO WHITES THAT ARE NEARLY THE SAME

Ceiling in one white, woodwork in another, walls in a third, none of them chosen together. The eye cannot read the difference as a decision so it reads it as dirt. One white through the whole flat solves it permanently.

FOUR · THE MID-TONE COMPROMISE

Page 59. Choosing something halfway between pale and deep because it feels like the sensible option gets you the disadvantages of both. Commit in one direction.

FIVE · IGNORING WHAT IS OUTSIDE THE WINDOW

A large tree throws green light into a room from spring to autumn. A red brick wall a few metres away throws warm light in all year. Both will shift a wall colour more than the compass direction does, and neither shows up on any paint card.

SIX · BUYING THE PAINT BEFORE THE SHEETS HAVE BEEN UP TWO DAYS

Because the shop is open now and the weekend is free. This is how almost every repainted room happens. The two days cost nothing and they are the entire method.

> **WHAT ALL SIX HAVE IN COMMON**
>
> *Not one of them is a mistake of taste. Every one is a mistake of sequence — deciding something before the thing it depends on was settled.*

TROUBLESHOOTING

“I painted it and I hate it”

Before you repaint, work out which of these it is. Three of the five are not solved by a different colour, and repainting would waste a weekend.

IT LOOKS MUCH DARKER THAN THE SAMPLE

Expected, and usually not a colour problem. A whole room reads deeper than a sample because light bounces between the walls, each bounce deepening it. Give it a week before you judge — your eye adapts considerably. If it is still too much, the fix is often lighting, not paint: the room may simply have gone dark, which is page 58.

IT LOOKED FINE BY DAY AND IS HORRIBLE AT NIGHT

A bulb problem, not a paint problem. You have almost certainly got mixed colour temperatures or bulbs above 3000 K. Change every bulb in the room to 2700 K, with a CRI of 90 or above, and look again the following evening. This fixes it far more often than repainting does.

IT HAS GONE A COMPLETELY DIFFERENT COLOUR FROM THE SAMPLE

Check three things in order: whether the finish differs from what you tested (satin reads lighter than matt), whether it has had two full coats, and whether the wall underneath was a strong colour showing through. A deep colour over a dark wall can need three coats before it is itself.

IT IS FINE BUT IT FIGHTS THE FLOOR OR THE SOFA

An undertone clash, page 50. Nothing is wrong with the colour and repainting in the same family will not help. Either change the smaller thing, or put a rug between them in a colour that belongs to both.

IT IS SIMPLY FLAT AND LIFELESS

Usually not colour at all. Check the four textures on page 10 and the three lighting heights on page 28. A correct colour in a one-texture room lit from the ceiling will always look dead, and painting it a second colour will not change that.

BEFORE YOU REPAINT ANYTHING

Live with it for two weeks. Colour adaptation is real and substantial — a room that feels overwhelming on day one often feels correct by day ten. I have talked more people out of repainting than into it, and almost none of them came back.

The order of painting a room

Not a decorating manual — there are good ones and this is not trying to be one. But the sequence saves a day and almost nobody is told it.

1. **Empty the room, or as near as you can get.** Everything into the middle, covered. The time you spend here you get back twice in not working around things.
2. **Fill, sand, and wash the walls.** Fill every hole including the ones you are about to make again. Sugar soap or a cloth and warm water on anything greasy, especially above a radiator and around light switches, because paint does not stick to grease.
3. **Ceiling first.** Always. It spatters, and everything below it will be painted afterwards.
4. **Walls second.**
5. **Woodwork last.** Skirting, architrave, doors, windows. Woodwork paint is slower, more precise, and the thing you most want to avoid rushing — so it goes when nothing else is waiting on it.
6. **Two coats of everything.** Including the thing you think looks fine after one. A single coat on a wall reads patchy in raking light for as long as you live there.

THE TWO THINGS WORTH SPENDING MONEY ON

- **A decent brush** for the woodwork and the cutting-in. A cheap brush sheds bristles into the wet paint and leaves a visibly worse edge, and you will be looking at that edge every day.
- **Enough paint.** Running out two-thirds of the way through a wall and finishing from a second tin mixed at a different time is how you get a visible join. Buy the whole quantity at once, and if it is a mixed colour, check the tins are from the same batch.

VENTILATION, AND THE ONE REAL HAZARD

Keep windows open and the room aired while you paint and for a day after. If the building predates the late 1970s and you intend to *sand* old paintwork rather than just paint over it, stop and read page 63 first — sanding is what makes old lead paint dangerous.

A WORKED EXAMPLE

One room, from start to finish

This is a constructed example, written to show the method applied end to end. It is not a real client.

THE ROOM

A sitting room of about sixteen square metres in a 1930s flat. One window facing north-east, used mostly in the evenings. Honey oak floorboards. A mid-grey sofa. Landlord white walls, a brilliant white ceiling, white woodwork, and one ceiling pendant with a 4000 K bulb in it. The owner described it as "fine but depressing" and wanted to paint it a pale grey.

THE AUDIT

- **Light:** one source, one height, cool bulb. Error one, plus the wrong colour temperature.
- **Height:** pictures centred at about 122 cm, curtain pole 4 cm above the frame, curtains 6 cm off the floor. Error two, comprehensively.
- **Texture:** fabric sofa, fabric curtain, fabric cushions, painted surfaces. Two families. Error three.
- **Ceiling:** brilliant white, never considered. Error four.
- **Orientation:** north-east, used in the evening — so, per page 26, decorate it as a north room.

WHAT WAS DONE, IN ORDER

1. Every bulb changed to 2700 K, CRI 90. Two lamps added — one at 105 cm on a side table, one on the floor behind a chair. The pendant now stays off in the evening.
2. Curtain pole moved to 12 cm below the ceiling and widened so the curtains stack on the wall. Curtains re-hung to the floor. Pictures re-hung to 145 cm.
3. Only then, colour. The proposed pale grey was tested and abandoned: it went violet under the new warm bulbs and fought the honey floor. A soft warm white was chosen for the walls, the same white at quarter strength for the ceiling, and eggshell in the same white for the woodwork.
4. A wool rug in a deep olive, an oak stool, and a large unglazed pot. Four textures.

THE POINT OF THE EXAMPLE

The owner asked for a colour. Colour was the fourth thing done, it was not the colour requested, and the largest single change in the room was two lamps and a packet of bulbs.

WORKSHEET

The paint schedule for a whole home

One sheet for the flat, not one per room. That is the point of it — page 69.

THE SCHEME

THE ONE WHITE (ALL CEILINGS + WOODWORK)

WARM OR COOL, FOR THE WHOLE FLAT

THE CIRCULATION COLOUR (HALL, LANDING, STAIRS)

THE DEEPER ACCENT (DOORS, ALCOVES, SHELVES)

ROOM BY ROOM

ROOM	FACES	WALL COLOUR	CEILING	WOODWORK	SHEEN

THE WHOLE-FLAT CHECKS

- [ ] Six colours or fewer across the entire home
- [ ] One white on every ceiling and every piece of woodwork
- [ ] Every colour is on the same side, warm or cool
- [ ] I stood in the hall doorway and everything visible agrees
- [ ] The accent colour appears in at least three places
- [ ] Every colour was tested on paper, in its room, at four hours
- [ ] Bulbs were changed to 2700 K before any colour was chosen

WHAT NOT TO BUY

Paint and colour

A COLOUR FAN DECK

Two thousand chips makes the decision harder, not easier, and every one of them is printed ink viewed under shop light. You need three candidates and two sheets of paper. The fan is a merchandising object.

“ONE COAT” PAINT

It is thicker, it costs more, and it still wants two coats to look even in raking light. You are paying a premium for a claim you will not act on.

PAINT-AND-PRIMER-IN-ONE, FOR A NORMAL REPAINT

Genuinely useful on bare plaster, new plasterboard or a drastic colour change. Painting a similar colour over sound existing paint, which is most repaints, does not need it.

PEEL-AND-STICK WALLPAPER AS A CURE FOR RENTED WHITE

Sold directly at tenants and it is a recurring purchase dressed as a solution. It is expensive per square metre, it is difficult to hang without visible seams, it frequently does not survive removal without taking paint with it, and it solves a problem that curtains and a rug solve better and cheaper. Page 72.

A COLOUR CONSULTATION THAT ARRIVES WITHOUT SEEING YOUR ROOM

Anybody choosing your colours from photographs is guessing, because a photograph has an automatic white balance and has already destroyed the information about your light. If you pay for advice, pay for someone who stands in the room at the hour you use it.

TESTER POTS IN MORE THAN THREE COLOURS

Buying eight is a symptom of not having narrowed the decision. Do the orientation table on page 55, get to three, and test those properly.

WHAT TO BUY INSTEAD

Three sample pots. Four large sheets of paper. One good brush. Enough paint for two coats, in one batch. That is the entire shopping list for a room, and it is less than most people spend on the things above.

THE QUIET PART

Who profits from the colour of the year

Every autumn, several large paint companies announce a colour of the year. It is reported as news. It is worth looking at what it is for.

A colour of the year does two things at once. It gives magazines and shops something to write about and arrange displays around, which is ordinary commerce and nobody's business but theirs. And it establishes, by implication, that there is a colour which is *current* — which necessarily means the colour on your walls is last year's.

That is the whole mechanism. Paint does not wear out. A well-painted wall in a room nobody kicks will look perfectly good in fifteen years. So an industry selling a product that does not expire has to supply a reason to replace it, and taste is the only reason available.

Nobody decided this in a room somewhere. It is quieter and sadder than that.

There is no money in telling you that the soft warm white you chose three years ago, for the north-facing room you still live in, is still exactly the right colour for it. There is a great deal of money in a calendar that quietly makes every room in the country a year out of date each October. Not one person has to intend it for that to be how the whole thing works.

> **THE TEST THAT SURVIVES ANY TREND**
>
> *A colour chosen for the direction your window faces cannot go out of fashion, because your window will not move.*

WHAT THIS IS NOT

It is not an argument that the paint companies make bad paint. They make very good paint, the colours in their ranges are carefully developed, and the LRV figure on the card is one of the most useful pieces of information in this whole subject. Use the product. Ignore the calendar.

And if you like this year's colour — genuinely like it, in your own room, at dusk, under your own lamps — then paint your room with it. Liking something is a perfectly good reason. Being told it is current is not.

QUESTIONS I AM ASKED

Eight short answers

CAN I PAINT OVER WALLPAPER?

Sometimes, if it is sound, well stuck and not textured or vinyl. Test a small area first — paint wets the paste and can lift a seam. If any edge is loose, it will get worse. Stripping is more work and the right answer more often.

DO I NEED TO PRIME?

Bare plaster, new plasterboard, bare wood or a drastic colour change: yes. Sound existing paint in a similar colour: no.

HOW MUCH PAINT WILL I NEED?

Measure the walls and check the tin, because coverage varies by brand and colour. Then buy somewhat more than the tin claims. Deep colours and porous surfaces both drink more, and running out mid-wall is the one thing you cannot recover from neatly.

IS EXPENSIVE PAINT WORTH IT?

Often, for a deep colour, where the pigment load genuinely shows in depth and coverage and may save you a coat. Much less so for a white ceiling. Spend on the colour that people will look at and economise on the ones they will not.

CAN I USE EXTERIOR PAINT INSIDE?

No. It is formulated for weather and flexibility rather than for scrubbing and low odour, and some exterior products are not intended for enclosed spaces. Buy the right one.

WHAT ABOUT A RADIATOR?

Use a radiator-grade paint; ordinary white paint yellows with heat. Paint it cold, and leave it a good while before turning the heating on.

SHOULD THE INSIDE OF MY FRONT DOOR MATCH THE OUTSIDE?

No, and it almost never should. The inside belongs to the hall's scheme, the outside belongs to the street. They are two different rooms.

DOES A DARK CEILING REALLY MAKE A ROOM FEEL LOWER?

It makes it feel *closer*, which in a high room reads as intimate and in a low room reads as oppressive. Page 61. Above roughly two point seven metres it is an option worth having; below that, be careful.

THE HONEST PART

Where I might be wrong

I will not sell you a fantasy, and that is the whole reason you can trust the rest of this. Four places where what I have told you is opinion, or is limited, or where I know good decorators who disagree with me.

THE SMALL PALE ROOM

Page 57 is my most contested position and I have marked it as mine throughout. Plenty of excellent designers hold the opposite view and produce beautiful pale small rooms. What I will defend without hesitation is the narrower claim: *brilliant* white in a small dark room is a mistake. The argument about pale versus deep is a real argument.

THE WHOLE BOOK ASSUMES THE NORTHERN HEMISPHERE

Every orientation rule in Parts Two and Three assumes you are north of the equator. South of it, swap north and south and leave east and west as they are. Near the equator the whole framework weakens, because the sun passes much closer to overhead and the differences between orientations narrow considerably.

LRV BANDS ARE GUIDANCE, NOT A STANDARD

The numbers on page 59 are working ranges I use, not an industry classification. A saturated mid-tone in a well-lit south room can be excellent and would fall squarely in the band I called a trap. Use them to compare candidates, not to rule one out.

SOMETIMES THE EXPENSIVE ANSWER IS THE RIGHT ONE

I have spent this part explaining how to avoid wasting money on paint. But if your floor is fighting every colour in the flat, page 70, the honest answer is that changing the floor is the real fix and no amount of clever colour work substitutes for it. I would rather say so than sell you a workaround that leaves you dissatisfied for ten years.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My father would not let a client thank him for a colour until they had lived with it through one full change of season. He said anybody can be pleased in October.

WORKSHEET

The colour audit

For a room you have already decorated and are not happy with. Run it before you decide to repaint — page 74.

ROOM

WHAT SPECIFICALLY BOTHERS ME

FIRST, RULE OUT THE THINGS THAT ARE NOT COLOUR

- [ ] Every bulb in this room is 2700 K
- [ ] Every bulb in this room is the *same* colour temperature
- [ ] Light arrives at three heights
- [ ] Four texture families are present
- [ ] Nothing is hung below 145 cm to its centre

If any box is unticked, fix that first. More than half the rooms brought to me as colour problems were not colour problems.

THEN THE COLOUR ITSELF

SURFACE	COLOUR	WARM OR COOL?
Walls		
Ceiling		
Woodwork		
Floor		
Largest fabric		
Curtain		

- [ ] Every row above is on the same side, warm or cool
- [ ] There is only one white in this room
- [ ] The wall colour agrees with the floor's temperature

THE ODD ONE OUT — AND IS IT CHEAPER TO CHANGE THAN THE WALLS?

The colour weekend

If you have read this far and want a plan rather than a philosophy, here it is. Two weekends and one week of waiting in between.

WEEKEND ONE — ABOUT TWO HOURS OF ACTUAL WORK

1. **Change every bulb in the room to 2700 K.** Before anything else, so that every judgement afterwards is made in the light you will keep.
2. **Find your orientation** and write it down. Page 23.
3. **Decide warm or cool for the whole flat**, by looking at the floor. Page 70.
4. **Narrow to three candidates** using the table on page 55, and buy three sample pots and four large sheets of paper.
5. **Paint the sheets, two coats**, and tape them up in three positions.

THE WEEK IN BETWEEN

Do nothing. Look at the sheets in passing — morning, midday, dusk, and at night under the lamps. Move them once, halfway through. Let one colour lose.

WEEKEND TWO

1. **Fill, sand, wash.** Every hole, including the ones you will re-drill.
2. **Ceiling, walls, woodwork**, in that order, two coats of each. Page 75.
3. **Re-hang at the right heights** while the walls are empty and you have the ladder out — pictures to 145 cm, the curtain pole as high and as wide as it will go. Part Four.
4. **Put back less than you took out.**

> #### THE ONE THAT IS NOT OPTIONAL
>
> *Change the bulbs on the first morning, before you look at a single colour. Every other step in this plan depends on it.*

And do one room. Not the flat. Finish it, live in it for a month, and you will make much better decisions about the second room than you could possibly make today.

Part Three, in ten lines

ONE

Colour is not a property of paint. It is what happens when that paint meets the light in your room.

TWO

You do not need to know which undertone a room has. You need all of them to be the same one.

THREE

A colour chosen for the direction your window faces cannot go out of fashion, because your window will not move.

AND THE SEVEN THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **Paint the paper, not the wall**, and move it round the room for two days. Four viewings: morning, midday, dusk, lamps only.
- **A chip cannot tell you anything.** Use it to get from fifty colours to three, then stop using it.
- **If two colours survive, take the paler one.** Every colour deepens once it covers a whole room.
- **Commit in one direction.** Pale or deep. The mid-tone buys the costs of both and the benefits of neither.
- **One white for the whole flat.** Two nearly-identical whites read as dirt, not as a decision.
- **Choose the sheen by how often a hand touches the surface.** Never: matt. Weekly: eggshell. Daily or wet: satin.
- **Paint things, not sides.** An alcove, a chimney breast, a bookcase. Never one wall out of four.

NEXT

Part Four is height and proportion — the curtain pole, the picture hook, the rug that is too small. It is the part with the most numbers in it and the fastest visible results, and half of it costs nothing at all.

Change the bulbs. Wait two days. Then choose. That is Part Three.

PART FOUR

Height and Proportion

This is the part with the most numbers in it and the fastest visible results. Almost everything in an ordinary home hangs lower than it should, and correcting that costs a few nail holes and an afternoon. It is the cheapest real change in this book.

Eye height · 87
The curtain pole · 92
Measuring a window · 96
Rugs · 97
The empty corner · 102
The numbers, collected · 103

CHAPTER FOUR

The cheapest correction in this book

Nothing else in decorating gives you this much for this little. A packet of picture hooks, a longer curtain pole, and an afternoon.

You met the error on page 9: almost everything that hangs in an ordinary home hangs lower than it should, because you hang things at the height where it is comfortable to hold them against the wall, and that is a good deal lower than where they needed to go.

What I want to give you in this part is the set of numbers that replaces that instinct. Not because numbers are more tasteful than your eye, but because your eye has been trained by rooms that made the same mistake, and it will keep making it until something external interrupts.

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU CORRECT THE HEIGHTS

- **The room gets taller.** Not metaphorically — the apparent height of the wall changes, because your eye reads the topmost object as the top of the usable space and everything above it as ceiling.
- **The furniture stops looking cheap.** A sofa under art hung at the right height reads as a considered arrangement. The same sofa under art hung twenty centimetres too low reads as a sofa with a picture over it.
- **The window becomes architecture.** This is the largest single effect in the part, and it is what the curtain pages are about.
- **Everything you already own looks better.** Nothing has been bought.

> ### THE HABIT THAT PREVENTS EVERY ERROR IN THIS PART
>
> *Before you put a hole in anything, mark the height with masking tape and leave it up for a day. Walk past it. Sit down and look at it.*

A WORD ON THE NUMBERS

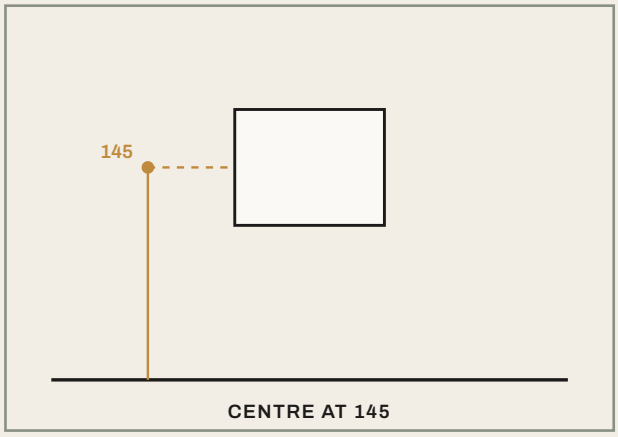
Everything in this part is a working figure from the trade, not a law. Where a number is a genuine standard — the gallery hanging height, for instance — I say so. Where it is what I use and what most decorators use, I say that instead. Rooms differ, and a number that fights your room is wrong for your room.

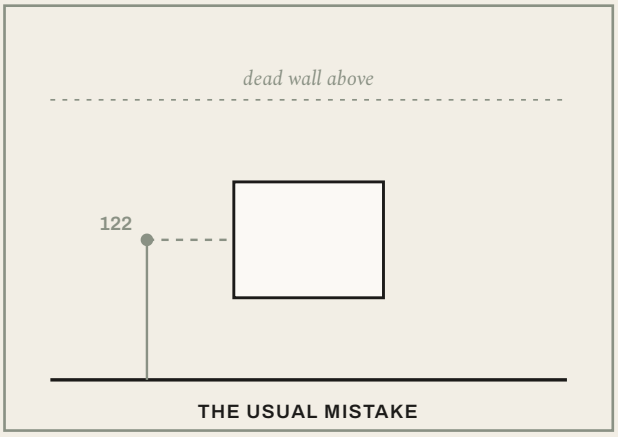
THE ONE NUMBER TO REMEMBER

One hundred and forty-five centimetres

Art hangs with its **centre** at 145 cm — about 57 inches — from the floor. Not the top, not the bottom, not the hook. The centre.

This is the standard hanging height used in galleries and museums, and it is not a matter of taste. It puts the middle of the work at the eye level of an average standing adult. It is a fact about where human eyes are, and it is why gallery walls feel comfortable and most domestic walls do not.





HOW TO FIND THE HOOK POSITION

You want the centre of the picture at 145. The hook goes above that, and where exactly depends on how far the wire drops when it takes the weight.

1. Measure the picture's height. Halve it. Call that **H**.
2. Hang the wire on your finger as if it were the hook, pull it taut, and measure from there down to the top of the frame. Call that **D**.
3. **Hook height = 145 + H − D.**

For a picture 60 cm tall whose wire pulls up to 8 cm below the top of the frame: 145 + 30 − 8 = **167 cm** for the hook. Do the arithmetic on paper rather than in your head at the top of a ladder.

IF YOUR CEILINGS ARE VERY LOW OR VERY HIGH

Under about 2.3 m, drop to roughly 140. Above about 3 m — a Haussmannian room runs 2.80 to 3.20 — you can lift to 150 or so, and larger work will want it. But 145 is right far more often than people expect, including in tall rooms, because eyes do not get higher when ceilings do.

When the wall rule and the furniture disagree

Art hung above a sofa, a bed, a console or a fireplace stops following the room and starts following the furniture. Here is how to resolve it.

THE FURNITURE RULE

Gap between the top of the furniture and the bottom of the frame	15–25 cm · 6–10 in
Width of the art, as a share of the furniture below it	roughly two thirds

Those two numbers do most of the work. The gap is the important one: closer than about 15 cm and the art looks stuck to the sofa; further than about 25 and the two stop being a group and become two separate things on a wall.

WHEN THE TWO RULES CONFLICT

A tall sofa back plus a 15 cm gap can put the picture's centre well above 145. A low bed with a small picture can put it well below. Which wins?

> ### THE RESOLUTION
>
> *Furniture wins. A picture above furniture belongs to that furniture, and the eye reads the pair, not the wall.*

Take the 145 rule as governing anything hung on open wall — a corridor, a stairwell, a blank wall, a chimney breast with nothing under it. Take the furniture rule as governing anything hung above something. Almost all the disagreement disappears once you decide which case you are in.

ABOVE A FIREPLACE

A third case, and the one people get wrong most. A mirror or picture over a mantel follows the mantel, not the room: leave roughly 10 to 15 cm above the shelf. And keep it narrower than the mantel — art wider than the fireplace opening below it makes the fireplace look shrunken.

THE ONE TO BE CAREFUL ABOUT

A television over a fireplace is almost always too high for comfortable viewing, whatever it does for the wall. If the room's main use is watching it, that is a real cost and worth being honest with yourself about before the bracket goes in.

Pairs, rows and gallery walls

Several pictures stop being several pictures and become one object. That is the whole principle, and every rule below follows from it.

> **THE PRINCIPLE**
>
> *A group of pictures is a single shape. Hang the shape at 145, not each picture in it.*

So for a group, the centre of the whole arrangement sits at 145. Individual frames within it will sit higher and lower, and that is correct.

THE SPACING

Gap between frames in a group	5–8 cm · 2–3 in
Same gap, used consistently throughout	yes — this is what makes it read

Consistent spacing is what separates a gallery wall from a wall with a lot of pictures on it. Wider gaps than about 8 cm and the group dissolves into individuals; narrower than about 5 and it reads as cramped.

THREE ARRANGEMENTS THAT WORK

- **A grid.** Identical frames, identical gaps, equal rows and columns. Formal, calm, very easy to get right, and the best answer for a set of related images.
- **A shared line.** Mixed sizes, but all frames aligned along one horizontal — either their tops, their bottoms, or their centres. The shared line is what holds it together.
- **A block.** Mixed sizes filling a rectangle, with the outer edge of the whole arrangement forming a clean rectangle even though the interior is irregular. The hardest of the three and the most rewarding.

THE PAPER METHOD, WHICH REMOVES ALL THE RISK

Cut a piece of paper to the size of every frame. Tape them to the wall and move them around until the arrangement is right. Mark the hook position on each piece of paper while it is still on the wall, then drill through the paper. You will get it right the first time, and the only holes in your wall will be the ones you meant.

Mirrors, and what they are actually for

A mirror reflects what is in front of it. That is the entire mechanism, and almost every mirror mistake comes from forgetting it.

You met the short version on page 20. Here is the working method.

> **BEFORE YOU HANG ONE**
>
> *Stand where the mirror will go and look at what is directly opposite. That is what you are about to put on your wall.*

WHAT IS WORTH REFLECTING

- **A window.** The best reflection there is. A mirror opposite or adjacent to a window puts a second bright rectangle into the room and genuinely increases the light.
- **A lamp or a lit corner.** Especially in a dark room or a hallway.
- **A long view** — down a corridor, through a doorway into another room. Depth is what a mirror is best at.
- **Something you like looking at.** A bookcase, a plant, a good painting.

WHAT IS NOT

A blank wall. The back of a door. A radiator. The kitchen bin. A television, which is a black rectangle for most of the day and a distraction for the rest. And — the one people forget — the ceiling, which is what a mirror hung too high above a fireplace usually shows you.

HEIGHTS

Decorative mirror on open wall — centre	145 cm · 57 in
Over a mantel — above the shelf	10–15 cm · 4–6 in
Over a basin or console — above the surface	15–20 cm · 6–8 in
A full-length mirror — lean it, or fix it	top at 175–185 cm

TWO PRACTICAL POINTS

A large mirror is heavy and heavier than it looks. Fix it into something solid, not into plasterboard alone, and use the fixings rated for the weight — this is one of the few genuinely dangerous things in this book.

And a leaning full-length mirror must be secured to the wall behind it. They tip.

Shelves, and the rail you already own

If your home has a picture rail, you have a hanging system already installed and you are almost certainly not using it.

A picture rail is the moulded strip running round a room at or near the head height of the doors. It exists because plaster walls were once difficult to fix into, so pictures hung from cords or chains dropped from the rail. In older buildings it is still there, painted over, ignored.

WHY IT IS WORTH USING

- **No holes.** Which makes it the single most useful thing in a rented flat with period features — and it is the first thing I look for in one.
- **Everything is adjustable.** Move a picture in thirty seconds, with no filler.
- **The drop itself reads well.** Two visible cords running down to a frame is a handsome, deliberate detail, not a compromise.

Hooks that slip over the rail cost very little. Use two cords rather than one — a single cord makes a triangle and the picture will swing; two parallel drops hang straight and stay put. And the 145 rule still applies: adjust the cord length so the picture's centre lands there, rather than hanging everything from the rail at the same drop.

SHELVES

Lowest shelf of an open unit, above the floor	at least 25–30 cm
Highest shelf you will use daily	no higher than 180 cm
Between shelves, for ordinary books	28–32 cm
A single floating shelf, above a sofa or desk	treat as art — page 88

THE THING ABOUT BOOKCASES

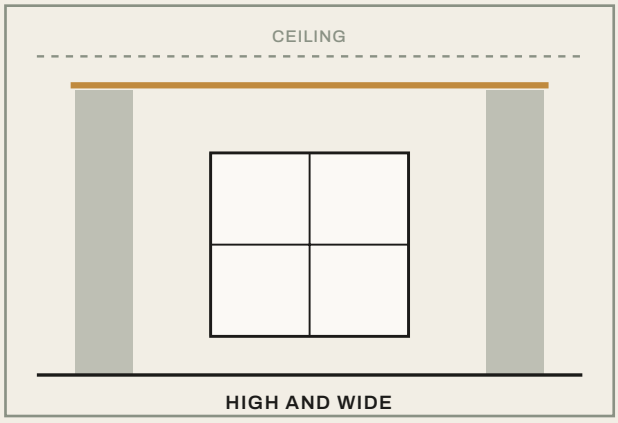
A bookcase that stops two-thirds of the way up a wall leaves an awkward band of empty wall above it and makes the ceiling look lower. A bookcase that runs to the ceiling — or has something on top that closes the gap — reads as architecture. If you are buying one, measure the wall first and buy the tallest that fits.

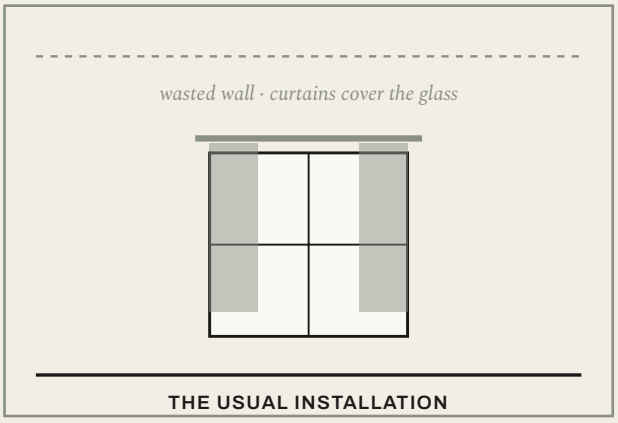
THE LARGEST PRIZE IN THIS PART

The curtain pole

Moving a curtain pole upward and outward changes a room more than any other twenty-minute job in this book. Most people have never considered that it could move at all.

The default installation puts the pole a few centimetres above the window frame and barely wider than it. Both are wrong, and both are wrong in the same direction.





Pole height — above the top of the window frame	15–20 cm · 6–8 in
Or, better, below the ceiling or cornice	8–15 cm · 3–6 in
Pole width — beyond the frame, *each side*	15–25 cm · 6–10 in

WHAT EACH ONE BUYS YOU

Height makes the window taller. The eye reads the whole curtained area as the window, so a pole near the ceiling produces an apparently floor-to-ceiling opening rather than a hole in a wall with fabric above it.

Width gives you back your daylight. Open curtains stack onto the wall instead of onto the glass — which, as page 41 said, is typically a tenth of your window returned to you permanently.

The drop, and the four inches that matter

A curtain goes to the floor. Almost the only exception is a radiator, and even that one is arguable.

A curtain that stops short — at the sill, or a hand's width above the floor — draws a horizontal line partway down the wall, and the eye reads that line as the bottom of the room. The ceiling comes down with it. This is the same mechanism as the pole height working in reverse, and it is the most common single error in the whole of window dressing.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE DROPPED CURTAIN**
>
> *A curtain that stops above the floor makes the ceiling lower. Hung close to the ceiling and dropped to the floor, it makes the window taller than it is.*

THE THREE FINISHES AT THE FLOOR

FINISH	CLEARANCE	CHARACTER
Floating	1 cm above	Crisp, practical, moves freely. The safe default, and best where a curtain is drawn daily.
Kissing	just touching	The most elegant and the hardest to achieve, because floors are rarely level.
Breaking	2–5 cm on the floor	Soft, slightly languid, very forgiving of an uneven floor. My preference in a sitting room.

A deeper puddle than about 5 cm collects dust, trips people and needs arranging every time it is moved. It photographs beautifully and lives badly.

THE RADIATOR QUESTION

A full-length curtain in front of a radiator traps the heat behind it and sends it up the window. Three honest options: stop the curtain at the sill and accept the proportional cost; hang full-length curtains that you draw only when the heating is off; or fit a blind or shutter for warmth and hang the curtains as decorative panels that never close. The third is what I do most often, and it keeps the proportions.

> **MEASURE IN THREE PLACES**
>
> Floors are not level, especially in old buildings. Measure the drop at the left, the centre and the right, and work to the *shortest*. A curtain cut to the longest measurement will drag at one end.

Fullness — how much fabric

This is the number that decides whether a curtain looks expensive, and it has nothing to do with what the fabric cost.

Fullness is the ratio between the total width of fabric and the width of the pole it hangs on. A curtain with little fullness hangs flat and reads as a sheet. A curtain with generous fullness falls in deep, even folds and reads as a curtain.

Bare minimum, will look thin	1.5 × pole width
Standard, and what most ready-made curtains give you	2 ×
Generous — what makes the difference	2.5 ×
For sheers and very light fabric	2.5–3 ×

WHY THIS IS THE HONEST PLACE TO SPEND MONEY

Between a cheap fabric at 2.5 times fullness and an expensive fabric at 1.5, the cheap one looks better every time. Fullness is visible from across the room; fibre content is not. If your budget is fixed, buy more of a plainer cloth rather than less of a finer one.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My grandmother would not make a curtain under two and a half times. If a client could not afford the fabric she would suggest a cheaper cloth rather than less of it, and she would explain why. Forty-one years and she never once lost that argument, because she would hold the two up side by side and let the client see it.

WORKING OUT WHAT TO BUY

1. Measure the **pole**, not the window.
2. Multiply by your fullness — use 2.5 unless there is a reason not to.
3. Divide by the fabric width, and round *up* to whole widths. This gives the number of fabric widths.
4. Multiply the number of widths by the drop, plus an allowance for hems and heading, plus a pattern repeat if the fabric has one.

The worksheet on page 96 does this arithmetic for you, with space for the measurements. If you are having curtains made, take it with you.

Headings, and what each one costs you

The heading is how the curtain attaches to the pole. It decides how the folds fall, how much of the pole you see, and how much fabric you need.

HEADING	FULLNESS	READS AS	NOTE
Pencil pleat	2–2.5×	Soft, gathered, informal	The commonest ready-made. Forgiving. Folds are irregular, which is part of its charm.
Pinch pleat double or triple	2–2.5×	Structured, tailored, formal	The most elegant and the most expensive to make. Folds stay put. Worth it on a long drop.
Wave	2–2.2×	Modern, even, continuous	Needs its own track, not a pole. Very uniform; some find it a little mechanical.
Eyelet	1.5–2×	Casual, deep soft waves	Cheapest to make. The pole runs through, so the pole is very visible — buy a good one.
Tab top or ties	1.5–2×	Rustic, light, informal	Hard to draw — the tabs catch. Best for curtains that stay open.

THE PRACTICAL HIERARCHY

If the curtain is decorative and never drawn, any of them will do and you should choose on looks. If it is drawn every evening, pinch pleat or wave will run smoothly and stay handsome for years; tab top will annoy you within a month.

LINING, WHICH MATTERS MORE THAN THE HEADING

A lined curtain hangs heavier, falls in better folds, blocks more light, insulates the window and lasts far longer, because the lining takes the sun damage instead of the face fabric. An unlined curtain is a panel of cloth. If you are choosing between a better fabric unlined and a plainer fabric lined, take the lining every time. This is one of the four things in this book I will tell you to spend on.

Interlining — a soft layer between face and lining — is a further step again, and it is what gives the heavy, quiet, expensive drape you see in old houses. It roughly doubles the making cost and it is genuinely transformative on a tall window.

WORKSHEET · FROM MÉMÉ SUZANNE'S NOTEBOOK

Measuring a window

One sheet per window. This is the page my grandmother filled in for forty-one years, in the same order, every time.

ROOM / WHICH WINDOW

DATE MEASURED

ONE · THE POLE

	MEASUREMENT
Window frame, outside edge to outside edge	
Return each side (15–25 cm) × 2	
Pole length = frame + both returns	
Pole height above frame (15–20 cm)	
Clearance under ceiling or cornice	

TWO · THE DROP — MEASURE IN THREE PLACES

	LEFT	CENTRE	RIGHT	USE THE SHORTEST
Pole to floor				

☐ Floating — 1 cm above ☐ Kissing ☐ Breaking — add 2–5 cm

THREE · THE FABRIC

	MEASUREMENT
Pole length × fullness (2.5 unless there is a reason)	
÷ fabric width, rounded *up* = number of widths	
Finished drop + hem and heading allowance	
Pattern repeat, if any	
Total fabric = widths × (drop + allowance + repeat)	

HEADING

LINED / INTERLINED

THE MOST EXPENSIVE COMMON MISTAKE

The rug is too small

Nearly every rug in nearly every home is one size too small, and a rug is one of the more expensive things in a room. It is worth getting right once.

It happens for an understandable reason. A rug is bought in a shop, where it is hanging on a rail or stacked in a pile, and at that moment it looks enormous. It arrives home, goes down on the floor, and becomes a mat floating in the middle of the room with all the furniture standing around it on bare boards.

WHAT A RUG IS ACTUALLY DOING

A rug is not floor covering. It is a **boundary**. It draws the edge of a zone and tells your eye that everything standing on it belongs together. That is why a too-small rug is so damaging: instead of grouping the furniture, it puts an object in the middle of the group and pushes everything outward.

> **THE TEST**
>
> *If the furniture is standing around the rug rather than on it, the rug is too small. It is doing the opposite of its job.*

THE THREE LEGITIMATE ARRANGEMENTS

1. **All legs on.** Every piece of seating sits entirely on the rug, with a margin beyond. The most generous and the most expensive, and unbeatable in a large room.
2. **Front legs on.** The front legs of every sofa and chair sit on the rug, the back legs on the floor. The standard answer for most sitting rooms, and it works because the rug still reaches under and connects everything.
3. **Deliberately floating — but sized to the furniture.** A rug entirely inside the seating arrangement, but wide enough that it visibly relates to the sofa rather than looking dropped there. It should be at least as wide as the sofa.

What is not on that list is the common accident: a small rectangle under a coffee table only, touching nothing else in the room.

THE MARGIN

Leave a border of bare floor between the rug and the walls, and keep it roughly even — somewhere between 20 and 45 cm in a normal room. A rug that runs almost to the skirting reads as failed fitted carpet.

Rug sizes, room by room

Working figures. Measure your furniture first and let these narrow the choice, rather than buying a standard size and hoping.

ROOM	THE RULE	COMMON SIZE THAT WORKS
Sitting room front legs on	Wider than the sofa on both sides. Front legs of all seating on the rug.	200 × 300 cm 8 × 10 ft
Sitting room small or all legs on	At least as wide as the sofa; ideally all seating fully on.	170 × 240 cm 6 × 9 ft
Dining room	Extends **60–75 cm beyond the table edge on every side**, so a chair pulled out still has all four legs on the rug.	table + 1.2–1.5 m in both directions
Bedroom one large rug	Starts about a third of the way down the bed and extends at least 50–60 cm beyond it on both sides and the foot.	200 × 300 cm for a double
Bedroom runners instead	A runner down each side, the length of the bed. Cheaper, and warm where your feet land.	70 × 200 cm each
Hallway	Leave an even margin each side. Length to suit; better slightly short than nearly the full length.	80 × 250 cm

THE DINING RULE IS THE STRICT ONE

Sixty to seventy-five centimetres beyond the table on every side is not aesthetic advice. A chair whose back legs drop off the edge of a rug when someone sits down catches, tips, and damages the rug. If you cannot fit the margin, do not put a rug under a dining table.

Before buying, mark the size out on the floor with masking tape and live with it for two days. The same habit as page 86, and it costs nothing.

The heights that have to agree

Furniture is bought one piece at a time, over years, and nobody measures. Then the pieces stand next to each other and quietly disagree.

These are the relationships that matter. Not absolute heights — relationships. A coffee table is not too tall in the abstract; it is too tall *for that sofa*.

RELATIONSHIP	SHOULD BE
Coffee table top vs. sofa seat height	level, or up to 5 cm below
Coffee table distance from the sofa	35–45 cm — close enough to reach
Side table top vs. sofa arm	level, or slightly below
Dining chair seat vs. table top	28–32 cm between them
Bedside table top vs. mattress top	level, or up to 5 cm above
Desk height, seated	72–76 cm
Walkway between furniture	at least 75 cm — 90 for a main route
Between sofa and television	roughly 1.5–2.5 × the screen width

THE THREE THAT CAUSE THE MOST COMPLAINTS

- **The coffee table that is too tall.** Modern sofas have got lower and coffee tables have not. A table well above the seat height means you reach down and then up for a cup, and it blocks the view across the room.
- **The side table that is too low.** If it sits well below the sofa arm you cannot put a glass down without leaning, and a lamp on it will be at the wrong height — page 30.
- **The walkway that is too narrow.** Under about 75 cm people turn sideways without noticing they are doing it, and the room feels cramped for a reason nobody can name.

BEFORE YOU BUY ANYTHING

Take three measurements with you: your sofa seat height, your sofa arm height, and the narrowest walkway in the room. Almost every furniture-buying mistake is prevented by those three numbers, and no showroom will give them to you.

Pull it off the wall

The instinct in a small room is to push every piece of furniture flat against a wall to create space in the middle. It produces the opposite of space.

You met this as myth three on page 19. Here is what to do about it.

A room with all its furniture against the walls has a void in the centre, and a void does not read as generous — it reads as a waiting area. Nothing is happening in the middle of the room, and the middle of the room is what you see first.

THE FLOAT

Pull a sofa off the wall by	5–15 cm · 2–6 in
Which costs you, in usable floor	nothing you were standing on

Five to fifteen centimetres is enough. It is not about creating a walkway behind the sofa — it is that the shadow gap between the furniture and the wall tells your eye the piece is a free-standing object in a room, rather than built into its edge. The room acquires an inside.

THREE MORE MOVES IN THE SAME FAMILY

- **Turn one chair off-axis.** A single armchair at an angle to the grid breaks the sense that everything has been pushed to the perimeter. One is enough; two looks accidental.
- **Let something stand in front of a window.** Not blocking the lower third — page 41 — but a low chair or a small table in front of glass is normal in French apartments and reads as confident. A window is not an altar.
- **Put the sofa across the room rather than along it,** where the proportions allow. A sofa that divides a space defines two zones; a sofa against the long wall defines none.

THE PRINCIPLE UNDERNEATH ALL FOUR

Furniture pressed flat to the walls describes the edges of a room. Furniture pulled inward describes the room itself.

Doors, thresholds and the vertical line

A room has a horizontal rhythm that most people never notice, and once you see it you cannot stop.

Stand in a doorway and look along a wall. There is a line running round the room at the head height of the doors — the top of the door frame, the top of the window frame, the picture rail if there is one, often the top of a fitted cupboard. In a well-proportioned room these align, or nearly do, and the room feels settled without anybody being able to say why.

In most homes something breaks that line: a shelf at an odd height, a wall cupboard, a boxed-in pipe, a television bracket. The line is what your eye was using to organise the wall, and the break is read as disorder.

HOW TO USE IT

- **Align the tops of things, not the bottoms.** Two bookcases of different heights look like an error; two units whose tops align look like a decision, even when they are different widths.
- **Put nothing new above the door line unless it goes all the way up.** A shelf floating just above door height is the single most disruptive thing you can add to a wall. Either keep below the line, or run to the ceiling.
- **Use the line for the curtain pole where you can.** If the pole lands close to the door head, everything in the room agrees at once.

THE THRESHOLD

Where one room meets another, the floor either continues or it changes. A change of flooring at every doorway chops a small flat into a series of cupboards, which is the law on page 70. If you cannot change the floors, you can at least keep the *colour* continuous across the threshold and let one run of skirting carry through.

THE DOORWAY VIEW

Every doorway frames a view. Stand in each one in your home and look at what it frames. In most flats at least one doorway is aimed squarely at the side of a wardrobe or the back of a television. Moving one piece of furniture so that a doorway frames something worth seeing is free and it is the sort of thing decorators are paid for.

THE ONE I AM ASKED ABOUT MOST

Every room needs one empty corner

I have been promising this page since Part One. It is the shortest rule in the book and the one people find hardest to obey.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE EMPTY CORNER**
>
> *Every room needs one corner where nothing happens.*

One corner with no furniture, no lamp, no plant, no stack of anything. Ideally unlit, or lit only by whatever spills into it. Genuinely empty.

WHY

Because a room in which every corner is doing something has nowhere for the eye to rest. Every direction you look, there is an object asking to be considered. It is tiring in a way that is difficult to identify, because nothing in the room is wrong — there is simply no pause in it.

The empty corner is the pause. It is also what makes everything else in the room read as chosen: when three corners are occupied and one is not, the occupied ones look deliberate. When all four are occupied, they look like the places things ended up.

THIS IS ALSO WHY I TOLD YOU TO LEAVE ONE CORNER DARK

Page 32 said to get light into every corner you can, except one. Same rule, seen from the lighting side. A room lit evenly into all four corners is a lit box; a room with three lit corners and one in shadow has depth, because the eye has something to read the light against.

WHAT COUNTS AS EMPTY

Bare floor and bare wall meeting. A single tall plant in an otherwise unused corner is a borderline case and I would allow it — it is one object, it moves, and it does not ask to be considered. A chair with a coat on it, a drying rack, a stack of boxes, a floor lamp and a side table: not empty.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My grandmother called it *le coin qui respire* — the corner that breathes. She said you could tell how a household was doing by whether it still had one.

Part Four, collected

Every figure in this part on one page. The full reference for the whole book is on page 165.

HANGING

Art on open wall — centre height	145 cm · 57 in
Above furniture — gap to frame	15–25 cm · 6–10 in
Above a mantel	10–15 cm · 4–6 in
Art width vs. furniture below	about two thirds
Gap between frames in a group	5–8 cm · 2–3 in
Hook height	145 + half height – wire drop

WINDOWS

Pole above the frame	15–20 cm · 6–8 in
Or below ceiling / cornice	8–15 cm · 3–6 in
Pole beyond the frame, each side	15–25 cm · 6–10 in
Drop — floating	1 cm above the floor
Drop — breaking	2–5 cm on the floor
Fullness — generous	2.5 × pole width

FLOOR AND FURNITURE

Rug — dining, beyond table edge	60–75 cm · 24–30 in
Rug — margin to the wall	20–45 cm
Coffee table vs. sofa seat	level to 5 cm below
Coffee table from the sofa	35–45 cm
Dining seat to table top	28–32 cm
Walkway, minimum	75 cm · 90 for a main route
Float furniture off the wall	5–15 cm · 2–6 in

Part Four, in nine lines

ONE

Art hangs with its centre at one hundred and forty-five centimetres. Not the top, not the hook.

TWO

A curtain that stops above the floor makes the ceiling lower. Hung close to the ceiling and dropped to the floor, it makes the window taller than it is.

THREE

Every room needs one corner where nothing happens.

AND THE SIX THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **Furniture wins over the wall.** Art above a sofa belongs to the sofa: 15 to 25 cm above it, about two thirds of its width.
- **A group of pictures is one shape.** Hang the shape at 145, with the same gap between every frame.
- **Widen the pole before you buy a curtain.** Fifteen to twenty-five centimetres beyond the frame each side gives you back a tenth of your window, permanently.
- **Buy more of a plainer cloth rather than less of a finer one.** Fullness is visible across a room; fibre content is not.
- **If the furniture stands around the rug, the rug is too small.** Front legs on, at minimum.
- **Pull the sofa five to fifteen centimetres off the wall.** It costs you no floor anybody was standing on, and the room acquires an inside.

NEXT

Part Five is texture and material — the fourth family, why linen reads expensive, what to do about the matched set, and the honest page about cushions. It is the last of the four corrections, and it is the one that makes a corrected room feel like a home rather than a diagram.

Raise the pole, widen it, drop the curtain to the floor, and move every picture to 145. One afternoon. That is Part Four.

PART FIVE

Texture and Material

The last of the four corrections, and the one that turns a correctly lit, correctly coloured, correctly proportioned room into somewhere a person lives. It is also where almost all the money in decorating goes, so this part is careful about what is worth buying.

The four families · 107
Why linen reads expensive · 109
The matched set · 114
Upholstery · 118
Patina · 120
The texture audit · 121

CHAPTER FIVE

Why texture comes last, and decides everything

Texture is fifth in the order of operations because it depends on everything above it. It is the first thing anybody notices when they walk in.

That is not a contradiction. The order of operations is about what you *fix* first; it says nothing about what a visitor perceives first. And what a visitor perceives first, before they have registered a single colour or noticed a lamp, is whether the room feels hard or soft, warm or cool, dressed or bare. That reading happens in well under a second and it is almost entirely a reading of surface.

WHY IT HAS TO BE LAST

Because texture is *read by light*. The whole visible difference between velvet and linen is how each one handles a beam: velvet has a pile that absorbs light down its length and catches it across, linen has a slubbed weave that throws tiny highlights and shadows in every direction. Change the light and you have changed the texture, exactly as you changed the colour in Part Three.

So a room lit from one height has, in a real sense, no texture at all. Flat overhead light strikes every surface at the same angle and produces almost no shadow, which is precisely the information your eye uses to tell one material from another. This is why a room can be full of beautiful fabrics and still look like a catalogue page: the light is not letting you feel any of them.

> **WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU SPEND ANYTHING**
>
> *Texture is invisible without raking light. A fifteen-dollar lamp on the floor will do more for the linen you already own than a better linen will.*

WHAT THIS PART IS CAREFUL ABOUT

This is where the money goes. Sofas, rugs, curtains, upholstery — the big purchases all live in this part, and most of them are made once a decade. So I am going to be specific about which of them reward spending and which do not, and page 122 lists what I would not buy at all.

The four families

You met the rule on page 10. Here is the working version, with what each family is actually doing in a room.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE FOURTH TEXTURE**
>
> *A room reads as finished when four textures meet: something woven, something wooden, something ceramic or stone, and something living. Three is a showroom. Four is a home.*

FAMILY	DOES WHAT TO LIGHT	READS AS	WHERE IT USUALLY ALREADY IS
Woven linen, wool, cotton, velvet	Absorbs it. Soft-edged shadow.	Comfort, warmth, quiet — it also deadens sound	Sofa, curtain, rug, cushion, bed
Wooden oak, walnut, pine, rattan	Scatters it along the grain.	Age, warmth, the handmade	Floor, table, frame, shelf, chair
Ceramic or stone clay, marble, plaster, brick	Holds it. Hard-edged shadow.	Weight, permanence, cool to the hand	**Almost always the missing one**
Living plants, branches, flowers	Moves in it.	Irregularity, care, that somebody lives here	One plant, or branches in water

WHY FOUR AND NOT THREE OR FIVE

This is my rule and not a law, so here is the reasoning rather than an assertion. Two families give you no contrast at all. Three is enough for a shop display, where the goods are the point and the room is a backdrop. The fourth is what stops the room reading as arranged — because in a real home, materials accumulate from different sources over different years, and four different families is the minimum that convincingly suggests that history.

Five and six are fine. Nothing goes wrong above four. The rule is a floor, not a ceiling, and the page that matters is the one after next — because the missing family is nearly always the third.

FAMILY ONE

Woven — weight, weave and what each does

Almost every room has too much of this family and too little variety within it. Four soft things in four different colours is still one texture.

THE FIBRES, HONESTLY

FIBRE	STRENGTHS	COSTS
Linen from flax	Slubbed and irregular, so it catches light beautifully. Very strong, and stronger wet than dry. Softens with every wash.	Creases immediately and permanently. Expensive.
Wool	Resilient — it springs back rather than flattening. Naturally soil-resistant. Warm, quiet, long-lived.	Expensive. Can pill. Moths.
Cotton	Cheap, washable, takes colour well, comfortable.	Less resilient than wool — it flattens and wears through at pressure points.
Velvet a weave, not a fibre	The most light-responsive fabric there is; it shifts tone as you move past it.	Shows pressure marks and shading. Cotton velvet crushes; mohair and synthetic velvets resist it.
Jute, sisal, seagrass	Coarse, matte, cheap. Excellent contrast against smooth things.	Rough underfoot. Do not like moisture. Stain badly.

WEIGHT MATTERS MORE THAN FIBRE

A heavy cloth hangs in deep folds and reads as substantial; a light cloth of the same fibre hangs limp and reads as cheap. This is why a thin linen curtain can look worse than a heavy cotton one despite costing three times as much.

When you are choosing fabric, hold a length of it up and let it fall. If it drops into a few deep folds it is heavy enough for curtains. If it clings to itself in many small creases, it is a dress fabric.

CONTRAST WITHIN THE FAMILY

The cure for a four-soft-things room is not fewer soft things. It is soft things that disagree: a smooth linen against a nubbly wool against a coarse jute. Same family, three completely different surfaces. Page 115.

Why linen reads expensive

It is worth understanding, because the reason is not the price — and once you know it you can get most of the effect from cheaper cloth.

Linen is spun from flax. The fibre is not uniform: it varies in thickness along its length, so a linen yarn has thick and thin places, and a woven linen cloth has a surface of small irregularities. That irregularity is called slub, and it is the whole thing.

A slubbed surface catches light at hundreds of slightly different angles. So a linen curtain in raking light is never one flat tone — it is a field of tiny highlights and shadows that shifts as you move. Your eye reads that variability as depth, and reads depth as quality.

A perfectly uniform synthetic of the same colour reflects light identically across its whole surface. It has one tone. Your eye reads one tone as flat, and flat as cheap — not because it knows the price, but because uniformity is what machines produce and irregularity is what natural fibre produces.

> **THE GENERAL PRINCIPLE, WHICH IS WORTH MORE THAN THE LINEN**
>
> *Irregularity reads as expensive. Uniformity reads as manufactured. This is true of cloth, timber, glaze, stone and plaster equally.*

HOW TO GET THE EFFECT WITHOUT THE PRICE

- **A linen blend.** Linen-cotton or linen-viscose keeps most of the slub at a fraction of the cost, and creases less.
- **Any irregular weave.** Slub cotton, basketweave, herringbone, bouclé. It is the surface variation you are buying, not the flax.
- **Raking light.** As on page 106 — the effect is created by the light. Cheap cloth lit from the side beats expensive cloth lit from above.

AND THE HONEST COST OF LINEN

It creases the moment anyone sits on it, and the creases do not fall out. If you want linen you have to want the creased version, because that is the only version there is. People who buy linen and then resent it have bought an idea of linen from a photograph taken before anybody sat down.

FAMILY TWO

Wood — grain, finish and age

My husband is a joiner, so I have been corrected about wood for twenty years. Three things matter and the third is the one nobody mentions.

ONE · SOLID, VENEER, OR NEITHER

- **Solid timber** can be sanded and refinished, sometimes many times. It moves with humidity, which is why solid tabletops are built to allow it. It lasts generations.
- **Veneer** is a thin layer of real timber over a stable board. It looks identical when new, it is more stable than solid, and it can usually be refinished once or not at all. Good veneer on good board is a perfectly honest product.
- **Printed foil or laminate** is a photograph of wood. It cannot be repaired, it chips at the edges, and once chipped it announces exactly what it is. This is the one to avoid in anything you intend to keep.

How to tell: look at an edge and at the end of a leg. Solid shows continuous grain wrapping round. Veneer shows a fine seam. Print shows a repeat — find the same knot twice and you have found a photograph.

TWO · THE FINISH DECIDES THE TEXTURE

Oiled timber is matte, open-pored and warm to touch; it marks, and it can be repaired with more oil. Lacquered timber is sealed and shiny; it resists marks and cannot be locally repaired. Waxed is between the two. An oiled oak table and a lacquered oak table are, texturally, two different materials.

THREE · THE THING NOBODY MENTIONS

Mixing wood tones is not a mistake. Almost every guide tells you to match your woods, and it is the single worst piece of received advice in this family, because it produces exactly the matched-set problem on page 114.

A room with an oak floor, a walnut table and a pine shelf reads as a room that accumulated. A room where every timber matches reads as a showroom set, and it is achievable only by buying everything at once from one place — which is precisely the impression you do not want.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY MATCH

Not the species. The *undertone* — page 50. Warm timbers together, cool timbers together. An orange-toned pine beside a grey-limed oak is the clash people mistake for a species problem.

FAMILY THREE

The missing family

In the great majority of rooms I have worked in, this is the one that was not there. It is also the cheapest of the four to correct.

Ceramic and stone do something no other family does: they are **cool and dense**. They take light and hold it rather than absorbing or scattering it, so their shadows have hard edges. In a room of fabric and timber — both soft-edged, both warm — a single unglazed pot introduces a completely different kind of surface, and the whole room sharpens.

WHAT COUNTS

- **Unglazed or matte-glazed pottery.** A pot, a jug, a bowl, a lamp base. Matte and slightly rough is doing far more work than high-gloss, which reads closer to glass.
- **Plaster.** A limewashed wall is this family — page 68 — which is one reason those walls feel so different from painted ones.
- **Stone and marble.** A worktop, a hearth, a small offcut used as a board or a tray.
- **Terracotta and brick.** Exposed brick counts. So does a single terracotta pot, which is the cheapest entry into this family there is.
- **Concrete and cement** in small quantities.

WHY IT IS THE CHEAPEST FIX IN THE BOOK

Because you need one object, and it can be very small. A single unglazed pot on a shelf changes the count from three families to four. You do not need a stone worktop. Charity shops and garden centres are full of this family for the price of a coffee, and a plain terracotta plant pot — the ordinary kind — is both this family and the container for the next.

> ### THE TEST, FOR ANY ROOM THAT FEELS SOFT AND SLIGHTLY SHAPELESS
>
> *Count the things in the room that are cold to the touch. If the answer is none, you have found what is missing.*

One caution, since it is the family most often bought badly: high-gloss white ceramic reads as bathroom fittings rather than as material. Matte, unglazed, or a glaze with some variation in it — the irregularity rule from page 109 applies here exactly as it does to cloth.

FAMILY FOUR

Something living, honestly

A plant is the only thing in a room that changes shape over months. That is its entire job, and it is a job nothing else can do.

Every other object in your home is fixed. The plant grows, leans towards the window, drops a leaf, needs water. It introduces irregularity that is not designed — which, by the rule on page 109, is exactly what reads as real.

CHOOSE BY THE LIGHT YOU HAVE, NOT BY THE LEAF YOU LIKE

This is the whole of it, and it is why so many people conclude they cannot keep plants. A plant sold as an indoor plant is not therefore suited to a north-facing corner three metres from the window.

- **Bright light, near a south or west window:** most of what is for sale will be happy.
- **Moderate light, a few metres back or a north window:** choose deliberately — pothos, philodendron, spider plant, cast iron plant, dracaena.
- **Genuinely low light, an internal corner:** the tolerant survivors — snake plant, ZZ plant, aspidistra. Expect slow growth and accept it.
- **No natural light at all:** nothing will thrive long-term. Use branches in water and change them, or rotate a plant in and out of a brighter room.

THE CLAIM I WILL NOT REPEAT

You will read that houseplants purify indoor air. The famous experiment behind that claim was run in small sealed chambers, and later analysis of what it implies at realistic room densities suggests the effect is negligible compared with simply opening a window. Have plants because a room with something alive in it is better than a room without. Do not buy them as air filtration.

THE CHEAPEST VERSION, WHICH I USE CONSTANTLY

Branches in a jug of water. Bare in winter, in leaf in spring, replaced whenever you like. They need no light, cost nothing, and satisfy this family completely. My grandmother kept beech or hornbeam in water on the windowsill from October to March and never owned a houseplant in her life.

Metal and glass — the seasoning

These are not a fifth family. They are a seasoning, and the quantity is the whole question.

Metal and glass are both *specular* — they reflect light directly rather than scattering it. That gives them enormous visual weight for their size: one brass lamp draws more attention than a whole wool rug. A little is lively. A lot is a hotel lobby.

THE METALS, AND WHAT EACH SAYS

METAL	READS AS	AGES
Unlacquered brass	warm, old, domestic	Darkens and patinates. The best-ageing metal in a home.
Lacquered brass or "gold"	warm but static	Does not age — the lacquer eventually chips instead.
Blackened or antique steel	quiet, structural	Wears at the edges, handsomely.
Chrome and polished nickel	cool, precise, modern	Stays exactly as it was. Shows every fingerprint.
Copper	warm, soft, culinary	Patinates fastest of all.

SHOULD METALS MATCH?

No — for the same reason woods should not. Two metals in a room is normal and looks considered; one metal everywhere looks specified. What I would do is let one be dominant and the second appear two or three times, so it reads as a decision rather than an oversight.

What genuinely should agree is temperature: warm metals with warm metals, cool with cool. Brass and chrome in the same sightline is the combination that looks accidental, and it is the undertone rule again.

> ### THE QUANTITY RULE
>
> *Metal and glass should be the smallest family in the room by area. If they are not, the room will read as commercial whatever else you do.*

Glass has one additional property worth using: it is the only material that disappears. A glass table in a small room takes up its volume without taking up its visual weight, which is occasionally exactly the right answer — though it is also a fingerprint magnet and it gives you nothing texturally.

THE MOST EXPENSIVE HABIT IN DECORATING

Nothing that came in a set

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE MATCHED SET**
>
> *Nothing that arrived as a set will ever look like it was chosen.*

A three-piece suite. A bedroom set. A dining table with its six matching chairs and the sideboard that goes with them. All bought together, all delivered on the same day.

The problem is not that any individual piece is bad. It is that the set announces its own origin. Every object in it shares one timber, one finish, one proportion, one design language, because it was designed to be sold together — and a room furnished this way tells anyone walking in that all of its decisions were made in a single afternoon by somebody else.

WHAT A ROOM WITHOUT A SET LOOKS LIKE

A sofa from one place. Two armchairs that do not match each other. A coffee table that was somebody's grandmother's. A floor lamp bought years later. None of them agree on species, period or price, and they all agree on temperature and scale — and the room looks as though it was assembled by a person with opinions over a decade, because it was.

HOW TO BREAK A SET YOU ALREADY OWN

You do not have to replace it. You have to interrupt it.

- **Remove one piece.** Take the matching armchair out of the room and put something else in its place. One dissenting object breaks the pattern for the whole set.
- **Change what is on it.** Different cushions on the sofa from the ones it came with. A cloth or a run of books over a matching sideboard.
- **Separate the pieces.** A set reads as a set when it is together. Move the sideboard to the hall and it becomes a piece of furniture again.
- **Add the two families it lacks.** A set is almost always one timber and one fabric. Ceramic and something living will do more than any rearrangement.

WHERE I WOULD SPEND, IF YOU ARE STARTING FROM NOTHING

One good sofa, bought alone. Then everything else acquired slowly and separately, secondhand where possible. A room furnished over three years for the price of one suite will look better than the suite, and every piece in it will be something you chose.

Contrast inside one family

The four-family rule gets you to a room that works. This page is what separates a room that works from a room people remember.

Having all four families is a floor, not a ceiling. The next move is contrast *within* each one — because the eye can distinguish surfaces far more finely than four categories, and a room that only satisfies the minimum still reads a little schematic.

WITHIN THE WOVEN FAMILY

The most common failure, because it is where the volume is. A room with four soft things that are all medium-weight, medium-smooth cotton has one texture repeated four times.

Put a smooth cloth against a coarse one: a fine linen cushion on a nubbly wool sofa, over a jute rug. Three surfaces from one family, and every one of them feels different under a hand. That is a richer room than four different families all of the same smoothness.

WITHIN THE WOODEN FAMILY

Oiled against lacquered. Sawn against planed. A smooth walnut table beside a rattan chair beside a rough-sawn shelf. Page 110 — do not match your woods.

WITHIN CERAMIC AND STONE

Matte against glossy. A rough unglazed terracotta pot next to a smooth glazed bowl is a genuine contrast, and both are cheap.

> **THE REFINEMENT**
>
> *Four families is the minimum. Two surfaces within each family is the difference between a room that works and a room somebody wants to sit down in.*

THE HAND TEST

Walk round the room and actually touch ten things. Not look — touch. If more than about four of them feel substantially the same under your palm, the room is texturally thinner than it looks, and you now know exactly which surfaces to change.

This is the test I use in a room that is bothering me and I cannot say why. It works because your hand has not been trained by photographs, and your eye has.

The curtain is the largest texture in the room

Part Four treated the curtain as proportion. It is also, in most rooms, the single biggest area of fabric you own — larger than the sofa.

Measure it. A pair of curtains at two and a half times fullness across a normal window is several square metres of cloth, hanging vertically, in folds, usually next to your main light source. Nothing else in the room is that much of one material, that well lit, at that angle.

Which means the curtain is doing more texturally than anything else in the room, and it is almost always chosen on colour alone.

WHAT TO CHOOSE IT FOR INSTEAD

- **Weight, first.** Page 108 — hold a length up and let it fall. Deep folds or small creases tells you everything.
- **Surface, second.** A slubbed or irregular weave against a window is the single best-lit texture in your home, because it is side-lit for most of the day. This is where linen genuinely earns its price.
- **Colour, third.** Genuinely third. A curtain in a plain, quiet colour and a beautiful cloth beats a striking colour in a flat one, every time.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

My grandmother chose cloth by holding it against the window of the room it was going in, never in the shop, and never flat — always gathered in her hand, because a curtain is never seen flat. She said a fabric that is only beautiful lying down is a tablecloth.

THE SHEER, WHICH IS THE UNDERRATED ONE

A fine sheer behind a heavier curtain does three jobs at once: it diffuses direct sun into soft light — page 25 — it gives daytime privacy without blocking the view, and texturally it puts a second, completely different surface at the window. A heavy wool curtain over a fine linen sheer is two contrasting textures in the best-lit place in the room, and it is why the arrangement has survived for two centuries.

THE HONEST PAGE

Cushions and throws

This is the category people reach for when a room is not working, and it is almost never the answer — but it is not nothing either, so let me be exact.

WHY IT IS THE WRONG INSTINCT

A cushion is small, soft, and belongs to a family the room already has too much of. If your sitting room is dissatisfying, the cause is on one of the previous four parts' pages — the lighting height, the hanging height, the missing third family — and a cushion addresses none of them. This is the purchase that feels like progress and produces none, which is precisely why it is sold so hard.

WHAT CUSHIONS GENUINELY DO

- **Introduce contrast within the woven family.** Page 115. A coarse wool cushion on a smooth sofa is real texture work.
- **Break a matched set.** Page 114. The cheapest possible interruption.
- **Carry the accent colour** into a third place. Page 69.

THE RULES, SUCH AS THEY ARE

How many on a three-seat sofa	3–5, odd numbers
How many different fabrics among them	2 or 3, never all the same
Insert size, relative to the cover	2–5 cm larger
Feather or down insert vs. polyester	feather, every time

The insert is the one that matters and it is the one nobody thinks about. A polyester insert the same size as the cover gives you a flat, slightly lumpy square. A feather insert two to five centimetres larger fills the corners and can be knocked into shape. Good covers on bad inserts look cheap; plain covers on good inserts look expensive. If you buy anything in this category, buy inserts.

THE ONE THAT COSTS PEOPLE MOST

Cushions bought as a matching set of four, in the fabric the sofa came with. That is the matched-set problem in miniature, bought deliberately, at the exact moment somebody was trying to fix it.

Upholstery — where the money should go

A sofa is the most expensive thing in most sitting rooms and the thing people know least about buying. Four things decide whether it is still good in fifteen years.

ONE · THE FRAME

Kiln-dried hardwood, jointed and glued, is what lasts. Softwood, stapled, or particle board will loosen and there is nothing to be done about it. Ask what the frame is made of; a shop that cannot tell you is telling you.

TWO · WHETHER IT CAN BE RECOVERED

This is the question that decides everything else. A sofa with a good frame can be reupholstered two or three times across fifty years, and each time it becomes a new sofa for a fraction of the price. A sofa built so that the cover cannot come off is a disposable object however much it cost.

> **THE ONE QUESTION TO ASK IN THE SHOP**
>
> *Can this be reupholstered? If the answer is no, you are not buying furniture. You are renting it slowly.*

THREE · THE RUB TEST ON THE FABRIC

Upholstery fabric is tested for abrasion resistance. In Europe the figure is the Martindale count; in the United States it is Wyzenbeek double rubs. Higher is more durable. As working bands:

Light domestic — occasional chair	10,000–15,000 Martindale
General domestic — a normal sofa	15,000–25,000
Heavy domestic — family, daily, pets	25,000+

It is a laboratory abrasion figure, not a guarantee, and it says nothing about staining, fading or how a fabric will pill. But it is published, it is comparable between fabrics, and almost no shopper asks for it.

FOUR · REMOVABLE COVERS

Washable loose covers on a sofa that gets real use is the difference between a piece you keep and a piece you replace. It is the single most practical thing on this page.

Rugs — fibre and pile

Part Four sized the rug. This page is what it should be made of, because a rug is the largest horizontal texture in the room and it is walked on every day.

FIBRE	BEHAVES	HONEST VERDICT
Wool	Resilient — crushed pile springs back. Naturally soil-resistant. Takes dye beautifully.	The best domestic rug fibre there is, and worth the money. Sheds for the first months; this stops.
Cotton	Flat, washable, cheap.	Good in a kitchen or a child's room. Flattens permanently underfoot.
Jute, sisal, seagrass	Coarse, matte, strongly textured.	Excellent contrast and very cheap. Rough underfoot, stains badly, dislikes damp.
Polypropylene	Stain-resistant, cheap, often washable.	Genuinely practical with dogs and small children. Flattens and does not recover, and reads flat because it is uniform — page 109.
Viscose sold as "art silk"	Very lustrous when new.	The one I would avoid. It marks with water, shows every footprint, and deteriorates where it is walked.

PILE, WHICH CHANGES THE TEXTURE MORE THAN THE FIBRE

- **Flatweave** — no pile. Crisp, hard-wearing, reversible, cool. Reads as a graphic rather than as softness.
- **Low pile** — the practical default. Chairs move over it, dirt comes out of it.
- **High pile and shag** — the softest texture available in a room, and the hardest to keep. Chair legs sink into it and it traps everything.

THE UNDERLAY NOBODY BUYS

A rug pad stops the rug creeping, stops it wearing through from the friction underneath, adds noticeably to how it feels underfoot, and prevents the corners curling into a trip hazard. It costs very little relative to the rug and roughly doubles its life. Buy it with the rug, not later.

Patina — the thing you cannot buy

Everything in this part has been about choosing materials. This page is about what happens to them afterwards, which is the part that cannot be bought and is most of what you are actually responding to in rooms you admire.

Patina is what use does to a surface. Brass darkens in the places hands touch it and stays bright elsewhere. Oiled oak deepens in colour and picks up small marks. Linen softens and its creases become permanent and soft rather than sharp. Leather lightens where it is sat on. Stone wears hollow in a doorway over a century.

In every case the material is being changed by its own use, so the marks are a true record of how the object has been lived with. That is why patina reads as authenticity and why no manufactured distressing quite convinces — a factory-applied wear pattern is in the wrong places, because nobody's hand has been there.

> **WHICH IS THE PRACTICAL POINT**
>
> *Choose materials that get better as they are used, not materials that only get worse.*

MATERIALS THAT IMPROVE

Unlacquered brass and copper. Oiled and waxed timber. Linen. Full-grain leather. Wool. Unglazed terracotta. Lime plaster. Stone.

MATERIALS THAT ONLY DETERIORATE

Lacquered and foil-wrapped anything. Chrome. Printed laminate. Polyester velvet. Viscose. High-gloss paint on woodwork that gets touched. Each of these begins at its best possible condition, and every subsequent day is a small loss.

WHAT FOLLOWS FROM THIS, PRACTICALLY

It is a strong argument for buying fewer, better, repairable things, and it is the reason the secondhand version of a good object is frequently preferable to the new one — somebody else has already done the first ten years of the work for you, and the price reflects the opposite.

It is also the honest argument against the aesthetic this book is working in. Rooms that look like this take time as well as decisions, and no amount of correct choosing on a Saturday produces a surface that has been touched for thirty years. That is not a reason not to start. It is a reason to buy things that will still be here in thirty years.

WORKSHEET

The texture audit

By touching, not by looking. Put your hand on five things in this room — page 115.

ROOM _____ DATE _____

ONE · THE FOUR FAMILIES

FAMILY	WHAT IN THIS ROOM	PRESENT?
Woven		
Wooden		
Ceramic or stone		
Living		

Fewer than four is the correction. It is almost always the third.

TWO · THE HAND TEST

OBJECT	FEELS	SAME AS ANYTHING ELSE?
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

THREE · THE CHECKS

- [ ] All four families are present
- [ ] At least two different surfaces within the woven family
- [ ] Something in this room is cold to the touch
- [ ] Metal and glass are the smallest family by area
- [ ] Nothing in this room arrived as a matched set — or one has been interrupted
- [ ] At least one material here will look better in ten years

THE ONE THING TO ADD, AND ROUGHLY WHAT IT COSTS

_____

WHAT NOT TO BUY

Texture and soft furnishing

A MATCHING CUSHION SET

Four identical cushions in the fabric the sofa came with. It is the matched-set problem bought deliberately, usually by somebody trying to fix the room. Page 117.

CUSHION COVERS WITHOUT INSERTS

Or worse, covers with the polyester insert that comes free. The insert is the part that decides whether it looks expensive, and it is the part being economised on. Buy feather inserts two to five centimetres larger than the cover and keep the covers you already have.

VISCOSE RUGS SOLD AS "ART SILK" OR "BANANA SILK"

Beautiful in the shop, and they mark with a drop of water, show every footprint, and deteriorate exactly where people walk. This is the only rug fibre I would tell you to avoid outright.

A SOFA WHOSE COVER CANNOT BE REMOVED OR REPLACED

Page 118. Whatever it costs, it is a disposable object, and a decade from now the choice will be to live with it or throw it away.

FAUX-DISTRESSED ANYTHING

Factory-applied wear is in the wrong places, because no hand has been there. It reads as costume next to a single genuinely worn object. If you want patina, buy the secondhand version of a good thing — page 120.

SCENTED CANDLES AS A DECORATING PURCHASE

Not because there is anything wrong with them, but because they are sold in this aisle as though they were a texture. They are a consumable. They do not change a room and they run out, which is the business model.

WHAT TO BUY INSTEAD, IN ORDER

One unglazed pot, from a charity shop or a garden centre. Feather inserts for the cushions you already own. A rug pad for the rug you already own. And then nothing else in this category until the lighting and the hanging heights are corrected, because a room fails those two before it ever fails on texture.

THE QUIET PART

Who profits from furniture that cannot be repaired

Go and look underneath your sofa. Then look at the back of a chest of drawers. You are looking for the same thing in both places: whether anybody expected this object to be taken apart.

A hardwood frame with proper joints can be reupholstered indefinitely. A stapled softwood frame cannot. A drawer on wooden runners can be repaired by anybody; a drawer in a particle-board carcass whose runners have torn out of the board cannot be repaired by anyone at all, because there is nothing left to fix it to.

The second kind is not badly made. It is precisely made, to a specification, and the specification includes the end.

Nobody decided this in a room somewhere. It is quieter and sadder than that.

There is no money in a sofa that a family recovers twice and hands on. There is a great deal of money in a sofa that is pleasant for six years and impossible to repair in the seventh, and in the replacement, and in the one after that. No one has to intend it. A market that competes on the price of the first purchase will arrive here on its own, because the cost of the second purchase is invisible at the moment of the first.

> **THE TEST THAT COSTS NOTHING**
>
> *Before you buy anything large, ask what would happen if one part of it broke. If the answer is that you would throw the whole thing away, you have learned the price properly.*

WHAT I AM NOT SAYING

I am not saying buy expensive. Some very expensive furniture is built exactly this way, and a secondhand hardwood-framed armchair with a tired cover is usually cheaper than a new flat-pack one and will outlive it by forty years. The division is not price. It is whether the thing was built to be opened.

And if the flat-pack one is what you can afford this year, buy it without apology. Then know what it is, keep it going as long as you can, and spend differently when you are next able to. That is a completely respectable way to furnish a home.

Part Five, in nine lines

ONE

A room reads as finished when four textures meet: something woven, something wooden, something ceramic or stone, and something living.

TWO

Irregularity reads as expensive. Uniformity reads as manufactured.

THREE

Nothing that arrived as a set will ever look like it was chosen.

AND THE SIX THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **Texture is invisible without raking light.** A lamp on the floor does more for the linen you own than better linen would.
- **The missing family is almost always the third.** One unglazed pot, for the price of a coffee, takes a room from three families to four.
- **Do not match your woods or your metals.** Match their temperature instead.
- **Weight before fibre, surface before colour** — in curtains above all, because the curtain is the largest and best-lit texture in the room.
- **Buy the insert, not the cover.** Feather, two to five centimetres larger than the cover.
- **Ask whether it can be reupholstered.** If not, you are renting it slowly.

THAT IS THE FOUR CORRECTIONS

Light, height, texture, colour — in that order, always. Everything in the rest of this book is those four applied to a particular situation — a rented flat where you may not drill, and then a room at a time.

Put your hand on five things in the room. If three of them feel the same, you know what to do next. That is Part Five.

PART SIX

The Rented Room

Everything so far assumed you could change the room. Most people cannot. This part is the whole book again, rewritten for a home where the paint, the floor, the lights and the windows belong to somebody else — and it is the part I am proudest of, because it is where I did most of my work.

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Curtains without a drill · 132
Hanging things without nails · 133
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CHAPTER SIX

What you actually own

A rented flat is not a smaller version of the problem. It is a different problem, and it deserves its own chapter rather than a paragraph of apology at the end.

Here is the difficulty stated plainly. The four corrections in this book are light, height, texture and colour. In a rented home you generally do not own two of them. The colour on the walls is not yours. The fittings in the ceiling are not yours. In many flats the floor is not yours either, and neither is the thing screwed above the window.

So the advice most renters are given is: wait. Wait until you buy something. In the meantime, live in beige and do not make a fuss.

I think that is a small cruelty, and it is also wrong. I spent fourteen years working almost entirely in rented flats, and the correction that does the most in any room — light at three heights, which is all of Part Two — requires no permission from anybody. You plug it in. Height, which is Part Four, needs one removable fixing and sometimes not even that. Texture, which is Part Five, is entirely portable and goes with you to the next flat.

That is three of the four corrections available to a tenant on the first evening.

> **THE RENTER'S ARITHMETIC**
>
> *You do not own the paint. You do own the light, the height of everything hung, and every texture in the room. That is three corrections out of four, and the one you are missing is the one that matters least.*

Colour is the missing one, and Part Three already dealt with it honestly on page 72 — a room can be recoloured entirely in fabric, and in a rented flat that is usually the only sensible route anyway, because fabric moves house and paint does not.

What follows is the practical version. What to ask for, what to do without asking, what genuinely works, and — this part matters — what is sold to renters that does not work and will cost you your deposit.

Read the lease before you despair

Almost every tenant I worked with believed their lease forbade more than it actually did. Nobody had read it. They were living by a rumour.

I am not a lawyer and this book is not legal advice, and tenancy law differs in every country and often in every city. What I can tell you is what I found again and again when a client finally took the document out of the drawer and we read it together at the kitchen table.

WHAT THE DOCUMENT USUALLY ACTUALLY SAYS

- **No alterations without consent** — which is a rule about consent, not a refusal. Consent that is never asked for is never given.
- **Return the property in the same condition, reasonable wear excepted.** That is the real test in most disputes: did you change it, and can it be put back?
- **Nothing whatsoever about lamps, rugs, cushions, plants, mirrors leaning against a wall, or what colour any of it is.** This is the important discovery. The largest corrections in this book are not mentioned in your lease at all, because they are not alterations. They are your belongings.

THE TWO QUESTIONS THAT DECIDE EVERYTHING

1. **Does it make a hole?** Holes are the whole argument. Nearly every dispute I ever saw between a tenant and a landlord over decoration was about a hole or a mark.
2. **If it does, can it be made invisible in an afternoon by somebody competent?** A filled and touched-in screw hole in an ordinary painted wall is the most routine repair there is. A ripped patch of plaster is not.

One thing I do know, because it is French law and I was asked about it constantly: here a room only counts as a habitable main room if it has at least nine square metres of floor with a ceiling of at least 2.20 m, or failing that a volume of at least twenty cubic metres. A "bedroom" that fails those figures is not a bedroom, whatever the advertisement said. Your own country will have its equivalent, and it is worth ten minutes of an evening to find out what it is.

BEFORE YOU DO ANYTHING

If your tenancy came with an inventory or a check-in report — in France the *état des lieux*, elsewhere a schedule of condition — find it and read the section on walls. That single page tells you exactly what you will be measured against when you leave, which is more useful than any opinion of mine.

The five permissions worth asking for

Tenants almost never ask. Landlords are almost never asked. I have watched a polite two-sentence email get a whole flat repainted at the owner's expense.

Ask for these five, in this order of likelihood. Ask for them in writing, keep the reply, and ask for one at a time rather than presenting a list that reads like a renovation.

1. **To change the light fittings, keeping the originals.** The most likely yes of the five, because it costs the owner nothing and the flat is improved. Say that you will store the originals and reinstate them.
2. **To put up a curtain pole.** Two brackets, four screws. Frame it as improving the property, because it does — a pole stays behind and the next tenant inherits it.
3. **To hang pictures with proper fixings.** Offer the number. "About six screw holes, filled and touched in when I leave." A number is reassuring; "some pictures" is not.
4. **To repaint, at your own expense, in a colour you name.** Attach the colour. Many owners say yes to this if you promise white-back at the end; many more say yes and never ask for white-back, because a freshly painted flat lets faster.
5. **To replace the floor covering.** The least likely, and usually not worth spending your credit on. A large rug does most of it. See page 136.

THE EMAIL THAT WORKS

COPY THIS

Dear —, I would like to make one small improvement at my own cost: replacing the ceiling fitting in the sitting room with a plain fabric shade. I will keep the original fitting and put it back at the end of the tenancy, and there will be no change to the wiring. May I go ahead?

Three things make it work: it is one thing, not five; it is at your expense; and it is reversible, and says so. Every refusal I ever saw was a refusal of risk, not of decoration.

Light, which needs nobody's permission

This is the page that changes a rented flat, and it is the reason Part Two came second in this book and not last.

The single overhead fitting is the defining feature of rented housing everywhere in the world. It is there because it is cheap to install and impossible to break. It produces exactly the light described on page 29: one source, at the worst possible height, with nothing to soften it. Every rented flat I ever walked into was suffering it.

And every one of them could be corrected the same evening, by a tenant, with no tools, no permission and nothing screwed to anything.

THE PLAN, UNCHANGED FROM PART TWO

Table height — a lamp at roughly seated eye level	2 sources
Floor level — one light low, in a corner, behind something	1 source
Overhead — off, most of the time	0 sources

THE RENTER'S COMPLICATIONS, AND THEIR ANSWERS

- **There are no sockets where the lamps should go.** Then the flat is telling you to use a floor lamp that can stand behind a chair, and an extension lead run along the skirting and taped down. I have never once regretted an extension lead. I have often regretted a lamp placed where the socket was.
- **No switch by the door, so you walk into darkness.** A plug-in remote socket, or bulbs that come on to a timer at dusk. This costs very little and it is the difference between using the plan and abandoning it in week two.
- **Nowhere to put a table lamp at all.** A clamp lamp on a shelf edge, a bookcase or a door frame. It is the trade's own solution and it is not ugly if the fitting is plain.

Three lamps and a fortnight of switching the big light off will do more for a rented room than any amount of paint you are not allowed to use.

The bulb is the only free renovation

If you do one thing in this part, do this one. It takes ten minutes, it costs less than lunch, it is entirely reversible, and it changes the colour of every surface you own.

Landlords buy bulbs in packs. Nobody selects them. They arrive in the flat as a consequence of a hardware shop having a special offer, and they are almost always the same: cool, bright, cheap, and poor at showing colour.

Go round the flat tonight and read what is written on the bulbs. You are looking for two numbers, both explained on pages 34 and 36.

Colour temperature, for every room you sit in	2700 K
Colour rendering, the number after CRI or R_a	90+
Brightness, in lumens, for a table lamp beside a chair	400–600 lm

WHY THIS IS THE RENTER'S CORRECTION ABOVE ALL OTHERS

Because you cannot change the colour of the walls, and the bulb changes the colour of the walls. A landlord white under a 4000 K bulb is the grey-blue that everybody complains about. The same wall under 2700 K at CRI 90 is a warm, quiet, entirely acceptable white. The paint did not move. The light did.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE RENTED BULB**
>
> *In a flat you may not paint, the bulb is the paint.*

THE BOX

Put the landlord's bulbs in a box, label it, and keep it at the back of a cupboard for the whole tenancy. On the last day they go back in. This is the same box that will hold the original light shades, the original curtain, and anything else you swapped — and it is the single most useful object in a rented home. Page 142 is about that box.

The ceiling light you may not remove

Sometimes you are refused, or there is no fitting to change — a bare bulb on a flex, or a sealed plastic dish, or a row of spotlights you cannot reach.

Take them in order of how much they can be helped.

A BARE BULB ON A FLEX

The easiest of all, because the flex will take any shade with a standard ring and the whole operation is reversible in a minute. Buy a plain paper or fabric drum, hang it, keep the packaging. If you want the light to fall down onto a table rather than sideways into everyone's eyes, choose one closed at the top; if the room needs bounce off the ceiling, choose one open at both ends. Page 38 explains which does what.

A SEALED DISH OR A PLASTIC BOWL

You cannot improve its shape, so improve its behaviour. A warm, high-rendering bulb inside it is the whole correction. Then dim it — a bulb you can dim from a remote or a phone costs little and needs no electrician, because the dimming happens inside the bulb rather than in the wall. That single change turns a hard overhead light into a background wash that you can leave on at a quarter and stop resenting.

A ROW OF DOWNLIGHTS YOU CANNOT CHANGE

These are the hardest, and honesty is better than cleverness: you will not make them flattering. Warm, dimmable replacements where the fitting allows it, then use the lamps and leave the row off. Downlights light floors. You do not live on the floor.

THE SAFETY LINE

Never put a fabric or paper shade over a bulb that runs hot, and never exceed the wattage printed inside the fitting. With modern LED bulbs this is rarely an issue because they run cool, but a halogen or an old incandescent in a close-fitting shade is a genuine fire risk, not a decorating question. If anything here means touching wiring rather than unscrewing a bulb, it is an electrician's job and your landlord's bill.

Curtains without a drill

Part Four called the curtain pole the largest prize in the room. In a rented flat it is also the hardest, and I am going to be straight with you about what works.

WHAT IS USUALLY ALREADY THERE

Look above the window before you buy anything. Most rented flats have either a track screwed to the ceiling, a pole at frame height, or a plain batten. A track can be re-hung with longer curtains. A pole at frame height cannot be moved without holes — but it can be lengthened at the ends, and page 92 explains why width often matters more than height.

TENSION RODS — THE HONEST ASSESSMENT

A tension rod is held up by friction alone, inside the window reveal. It works for one job: a light unlined curtain or a café panel across a narrow window. It fails, and falls, with lined curtains, with a wide span, and with any fabric that is pulled hard twice a day. I have seen a rod in a reveal hold for years and I have seen one come down in a week. Weight and width decide it.

Tension rod, sensible span	under 120 cm
Tension rod, sensible curtain	unlined only

THE COMPROMISE I USED MOST OFTEN

Two screws. That is what a proper pole costs you — two brackets, four small screws, in solid plaster or a timber frame, filled with a fingertip of filler on the day you leave. It is the best value in holes anywhere in this book, and it is the permission most worth asking for on page 128.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

"A curtain hung too low says the room is rented. A curtain hung high says nothing at all — and saying nothing is the goal."

Hanging things without nails

Adhesive fixings are the renter's great modern convenience and the renter's great modern disaster, and the difference between the two is entirely in the preparation.

WHAT THEY WILL ACTUALLY CARRY

Read the packet, believe the packet, and then halve it. A set of the largest picture-hanging strips is typically rated at around seven kilograms — but that rating assumes a smooth, clean, sealed, fully cured painted surface at room temperature, which is a description of very few rented walls. My own working rule after a number of expensive lessons:

Adhesive strips, what I will trust them with	half the rating
Anything with glass, over a bed or a cot	a screw, or nothing

WHERE THEY ALWAYS FAIL

- **Textured or embossed wallpaper.** The adhesive touches perhaps a third of the surface.
- **Limewash, distemper and chalky old paint.** The strip holds perfectly. The paint lets go of the wall, and takes a patch with it.
- **Fresh paint.** Emulsion needs time to cure properly — a week is the usual instruction, and longer is better. A strip on week-old paint will pull it off.
- **Bathrooms and kitchens.** Steam and heat defeat adhesive. Every time.

THE FIVE MINUTES THAT DECIDE IT

1. Wipe the spot with rubbing alcohol, not a household spray — sprays leave a film that is precisely what the adhesive cannot grip.
2. Press for thirty seconds, hard, with your thumb.
3. Wait an hour before hanging anything on it.
4. To remove: pull the tab *straight down*, slowly, flat against the wall, until it stretches free. Pulling outwards is what takes the plaster with it.

And the fixing nobody thinks of: if your building is older, look for a picture rail near the ceiling. If there is one, you can hang almost anything at any height, on cord, for the price of two hooks, and you will not make a single hole.

The wall you may not paint

Landlord white is not a colour. It is the absence of a decision, chosen because it is cheap by the drum and can be patched by anybody.

You cannot change it. You can stop it being the loudest thing in the room, and there are exactly four ways, in order of how well they work.

ONE · CHANGE THE LIGHT ON IT

Page 130. A warm bulb at high rendering recolours every wall in the flat for the price of a sandwich, and it is the only one of the four that is free and invisible. Do this before you consider any of the others.

TWO · COVER THE RIGHT AMOUNT OF IT

Not a gallery of small frames — page 89 explains why a scatter of small things makes a wall look busier and emptier at once. One large piece, hung at 145 cm to its centre, takes more white off the wall than fifteen postcards and costs one fixing instead of fifteen.

THREE · PUT FABRIC ON IT

A quilt, a rug, a length of linen on a slim pole, a curtain along a whole wall rather than just a window. This is the oldest wall treatment there is and it does three things at once: it colours, it textures, and it quiets the room acoustically, which nobody expects and everybody notices.

FOUR · LEAN THINGS AGAINST IT

A large mirror on the floor, a picture ledge, a leaning frame. No fixings at all, and the diagonal of a leaning object is more interesting than the flat of a hung one.

> **DO NOT SKIP THIS**
>
> Anything large and leaning must be secured to the wall or to the furniture behind it, with a strap or a hook, even though it looks stable. Falling mirrors and toppling furniture injure small children every year. This is the one place in the book where I will not offer you a no-fixings option: one screw into a wall, or do not lean it.

THE HONEST PAGE

Peel-and-stick, and what it does to a deposit

Removable wallpaper is sold to renters as the answer to this entire part of the book. I have used it, I have removed it, and I have twice watched it take a wall with it.

WHAT IT GENUINELY DOES WELL

On a smooth, sound, slightly sheened surface it is excellent, and there are three places I recommend it without hesitation: the back of a bookcase, the inside of a cupboard door, and a small panel behind a desk. In all three it is small, it is on a surface nobody inspects, and if it fails you have lost an afternoon rather than a deposit.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

- **Flat, matt, cheap emulsion** — which is what a landlord's wall almost always is. Matt paint is porous and mechanically weak at the surface. The adhesive often ends up stronger than the paint's grip on the plaster, and the paper takes the paint off in sheets.
- **Textured walls or lining paper** — it will not seat, and the edges lift within a month.
- **Anywhere warm or damp** — above a radiator, in a kitchen, in a bathroom. It curls.
- **Left up for years** — the longer it stays, the harder it comes off. The claim of removability quietly assumes you remove it reasonably soon.

> ### THE TEST PATCH, WHICH IS NOT OPTIONAL
>
> *Put one piece, the size of a postcard, somewhere hidden — behind a door, low in a cupboard, behind the wardrobe. Leave it two weeks, in the season you are actually in. Then take it off and look at the wall. That piece of paper is the cheapest insurance policy in this book.*

If the test patch lifts even a fleck of paint, the answer for your flat is no, and you have learned it for the price of one postcard instead of one room. Go back to page 134 and use fabric instead. Fabric has never taken a wall off in the history of decorating.

A floor you did not choose

The two rented floors are grey laminate and beige carpet, and they are the same problem in two costumes: a large, flat, uniform surface with no texture and no interest, laid by somebody buying by the square metre.

Page 70 said the floor has already voted. In a rented flat it voted without you, and the correction is the same as it was there: do not fight it, cover the part of it that matters.

THE RUG IS THE FLOOR NOW

All of the sizing from page 98 applies unchanged, and the mistake is the same — too small. In a rented sitting room, the rug should be large enough that the front legs of every seat stand on it. That single rule turns a collection of furniture stranded on somebody else's laminate into a room.

Sitting-room rug, the minimum that works	front legs on
Clear walking width left around it	60–70 cm

A RUG ON CARPET, WHICH EVERYBODY ASKS ABOUT

Yes, and it is one of the most useful things a tenant can do — it is how you get texture onto a floor that has none. Two conditions. Use a pad made for laying rug over carpet, not the ordinary sort for hard floors, or it will creep and ruck within a week. And choose a rug with some weight and a low, dense pile; a thin flat-weave over a soft carpet feels like walking on a dropped tea towel.

ON STICK-DOWN VINYL PLANKS

I understand the temptation and I will still say no. On a rented floor they can bond far harder than the packet suggests, the seams trap damp, and lifting them off a landlord's vinyl or a varnished board can take the surface with it. A rug is reversible. That is worth more than a better-looking floor for the eighteen months you will live there.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR, SINCE THE RUG IS DOING SO MUCH

Wool if you can afford it, because it takes weight and recovers; a flat wool or a wool-and-jute blend if you cannot. Avoid the very thin printed sort entirely — it reads as a picture of a rug, and it will curl at every corner within a month. And buy the pad. A rug without a pad wears out from underneath, slides, and feels cheap underfoot however much it cost.

The kitchen you cannot change

Nobody rents a kitchen they chose. The doors are laminate, the worktop is a pattern pretending to be stone, and there is one fluorescent-looking fitting in the middle of the ceiling.

Five corrections, none of them structural, in the order I would do them.

1. **Light the worktop, not the room.** A plug-in strip or a pair of small lamps under the wall cupboards is the single biggest change available here. You currently work in your own shadow, because the only light is behind you. This is not decoration; it is the difference between a kitchen that is pleasant to cook in and one that is not.

2. **Change the handles, keep the originals.** Most cupboard handles are two screws. A plain metal handle on a poor door reads as a plain door; a shiny moulded handle reads as a cheap one. Twenty minutes, entirely reversible, and the originals go in the box on page 142.

3. **Clear the worktop to two things.** A rented kitchen is usually small and always looks worse cluttered. Everything that is not used daily goes into a cupboard. This costs nothing and it is the largest visual improvement on the list.

4. **Add the missing family.** Page 111. A kitchen is laminate, steel and glass — hard, smooth, cold. A wooden board left standing, a ceramic jug, a stone mortar, a linen cloth on the rail: the four families arrive on one worktop for very little money, and the room stops reading as a fitted unit.

5. **Something growing.** Herbs if the window faces anywhere but north, and see page 112 for what to do if it does.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

"A rented kitchen cannot be made beautiful. It can be made kind to cook in, and that is nearly the same thing by seven in the evening."

AND WHAT I WOULD NOT BOTHER WITH

Stick-on tile film over the splashback, adhesive worktop wrap, and anything that promises to make laminate look like marble. All three fail in the same place — at the edges, near heat and water — and all three can leave a residue that costs you far more at the end of the tenancy than the cupboard doors were ever worth.

The bathroom you cannot change

The smallest room, the worst light, and the one place where the corrections cost almost nothing because there is so little surface to correct.

THE LIGHT, WHICH IS THE WHOLE PROBLEM

A bathroom is nearly always lit from directly overhead, which puts every face into the shadow pattern that makes people believe they look tired. The professional answer is light *beside* the mirror at roughly face height, not above it, so that both sides of the face are lit. In a rented bathroom you often cannot add a fitting, so the two things you can do are:

- Change the bulb to 2700–3000 K at CRI 90 or better. A bathroom under a cheap cool bulb is the origin of a great deal of unnecessary unhappiness at eight in the morning.
- If there is a socket, a small lamp on the windowsill or a shelf, on in the evening. A bathroom lit low at night is a different room.

THE SAFETY LINE

Electricity and water are governed by real rules, and they differ by country — in many places sockets are not permitted in a bathroom at all, and fittings must carry a moisture rating. Whatever you plug in, do not improvise around this. Nothing in this book is worth a shock.

THE OTHER FOUR, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

A heavier shower curtain, hung high and long, is the largest piece of fabric in the room and behaves exactly like a curtain elsewhere — page 116. Two good towels of the same colour instead of six of different ones. A plant that likes low light and damp air, which is a short and forgiving list. And nothing on any surface except what is used every day, because in a room this small, clutter is the decoration.

THE THREE-MINUTE VERSION

Change the bulb. Take everything off the surfaces except what you use daily. Hang two towels of the same colour. That is a bathroom corrected, and it costs the price of one bulb.

Furniture that moves with you

A tenant buys furniture twice: once for this flat, and once again when it does not fit the next one. The second purchase is avoidable, and avoiding it is how a renter ends up with good things.

THE THREE QUESTIONS BEFORE ANYTHING LARGE IS BOUGHT

1. **Will it go through a standard door and round a standard turn?** Measure the narrowest point of the route, not the room — the front door, the stairwell, the turn at the top. A sofa that fits the room and not the stair is a sofa you will sell at a loss.
2. **Does it depend on this wall?** Anything built to fit one alcove is bought for one flat. Freestanding beats fitted for anybody who moves.
3. **Can it be repaired, and would I still want it in ten years?** Page 118 and page 123, unchanged. This is more important for a renter than for anybody, because your furniture is the only part of your home that is actually yours.

WHAT IS WORTH SPENDING ON, IN A RENTED FLAT

Lamps — they go everywhere, forever	spend
One good chair, one good table	spend
Rug, linen, ceramics — portable texture	spend
Anything fitted, cut down, or sized to this room	do not

THE SIZE RULE FOR PEOPLE WHO MOVE

Buy slightly smaller than this flat allows. Rooms shrink more often than they grow, a two-seat sofa fits nearly everywhere, and a three-seat sofa is the piece I saw abandoned on more landings than any other object in Lyon.

WHERE TO BUY IT

Secondhand, for anything made of solid wood or with a frame worth having. A renter's budget goes furthest in the market for good old furniture, because the things that survived forty years are by definition the things built to. Page 120 is about what that does to how a room looks; this page is only about what it does to what you can afford.

Storage, without building anything

Rented flats are short of cupboards, and the shortage does more visible damage than any colour on any wall, because a room with nowhere to put things is a room that is always covered in things.

I put this in Part Six rather than in a chapter of its own because it is almost entirely a renter's problem. People who own their homes build a cupboard. You cannot, so you must be cleverer.

THE FOUR PLACES A FLAT IS HIDING

- **The top thirty centimetres of every wall.** Nothing is ever up there. A shelf at 200 cm, running the length of a wall, holds everything you own but rarely use, and reads as architecture rather than storage. Page 91.
- **Under the bed.** Flat boxes, lidded, on the floor — and if the bed is too low, bed risers are cheap and invisible under a valance.
- **Behind a curtain.** A rail across an alcove with a linen curtain in front of it is a wardrobe, costs almost nothing, comes down in ten minutes and is what half of Paris does.
- **The back of every door.** Over-door hooks make no holes and take coats out of the room entirely.

THE RULE THAT KEEPS IT FROM LOOKING LIKE A STOREROOM

> ### COLETTE'S RULE OF VISIBLE STORAGE
>
> *Visible storage must be one material and one colour, or it stops being storage and becomes clutter with a lid on.*

Six identical boxes read as a system. Six different boxes read as a mess, even if they hold exactly the same things. This is the cheapest tidying in the book: not buying more storage, but making the storage you already own match.

TWO CAUTIONS

- **A high shelf must be fixed into something structural** — that is a screw, not an adhesive strip, and it is one of the few places in this part where I will tell you to spend a permission on it. A shelf that comes down at 200 cm is not a decorating mistake.
- **Do not store anything in the room you actually live in** if there is any alternative. Storage in a sitting room is the reason that sitting room never feels calm, whatever colour the walls are.

THE QUIET PART

Who profits from a temporary home

Ask why a renter is told to wait, and who is standing at the other end of the waiting.

There is an entire category of furniture that exists because people believe their home is temporary. It is light, it is cheap, it is designed to be assembled once, and it is very difficult to repair — the fixings are one-way, the material at the joint is often compressed board that cannot take a screw twice, and the covers are not made to be replaced. That is not a moral failing on anybody's part. It is a product designed honestly for a customer who has said, in effect, that they only need it for now.

But look at what happens over a decade of renting. You buy the temporary thing. It half survives one move. You buy another. Over ten years and four flats, a person can quite easily spend more on furniture that was never meant to last than they would have spent on a few things that were — and end up at the end of it owning nothing.

Meanwhile the walls stay landlord white, because the tenant has been told that changing anything is not their place. Magnolia and off-white are not chosen for beauty. They are chosen because they can be patched by any decorator from any tin, which is a perfectly rational decision for a person who owns twelve flats and a slightly sad one for the person living in this one.

> **SAY THIS PLAINLY**
>
> This is not a conspiracy. Nobody sat in a room and decided that renters should live badly. It is what happens when one party buys for turnover and the other buys for eighteen months, and nobody in the chain is buying for ten years. I am only pointing out that you can step out of that pattern on your own, this week, without anybody's permission.

Buy few things, buy them to last, and let them move house with you. The flat is temporary. You are not.

THE FAIR OBJECTION, WHICH I WILL ANSWER

Somebody will say: cheap furniture is how a person on very little money furnishes a flat at all, and a lecture about buying well is a lecture from somebody with savings. That is true, and I mean it. So let me be precise about what I am actually asking: not that you spend more in total, but that when you do buy, you buy fewer things and buy the ones that will move house. Three lamps and one good chair, bought over two years, cost less than a room of new furniture bought in one afternoon.

Day one, and the last day

Everything in this part depends on being able to put the flat back exactly as you found it. That is a practice, and it starts on the day you get the keys.

DAY ONE, BEFORE A SINGLE BOX IS UNPACKED

1. **Photograph every wall, every floor, and every existing mark**, with the date on the file. Not a general view — go close on the chips, the scuffs, the stained corner of the carpet. This takes fifteen minutes and it is the only evidence that will exist.
2. **Photograph every light fitting before you touch it**, so that reinstating them at the end is a matter of copying a picture.
3. **Find out what the walls are painted with.** Ask, or look in the cupboard under the sink where half-used tins live. A tin of the landlord's own paint is worth more to you at the end of the tenancy than anything you will buy.
4. **Start the box.** Page 130. One box, labelled, at the back of a cupboard, for every original thing you remove: bulbs, shades, handles, the shower curtain, the plastic dish from the ceiling.

THE LAST DAY, WHICH IS NOW ONE AFTERNOON

Take down what you put up. Fill the screw holes with a fingertip of filler, let it dry, sand it flat with a piece of fine paper, and touch in with the landlord's paint using a small brush and a dabbing motion rather than a stroke. Put the box back where it came from. Photograph the walls again.

> ### COLETTE'S RULE OF THE FILLED HOLE
>
> *A hole you can fill is not damage. Take the photographs on day one, keep the originals in a box, and every correction in this part costs you nothing when you leave.*

I have handed back a great many flats this way, and the honest truth is that the ones I had corrected came back cleaner and better documented than the ones I had not.

WORKSHEET

The rented room

One room. Fill the left column tonight, the right column this month.

ROOM _____ DATE _____

ONE · FREE, TONIGHT, NO PERMISSION

CORRECTION	DONE	COST
Bulbs read and replaced — 2700 K, CRI 90		
Big light off, three lamps on		
Worktop or surfaces cleared to two things		
Fourth texture family added		
Everything that is here by accident, removed		

TWO · REVERSIBLE, THIS MONTH

CORRECTION	HOW FIXED	COST
Rug, front legs on		
One large thing on the largest wall		
Curtains longer, higher, wider		
Storage matched to one material		
A second light source, low, in a corner		

THREE · THE RECORD

- [ ] Day-one photographs taken and stored somewhere I will still have them
- [ ] The box exists, is labelled, and holds every original I removed
- [ ] I know what the walls are painted with
- [ ] Permission asked for, in writing, for: _____

WHAT THIS FLAT WILL NEVER BE, AND WHAT I AM DOING ANYWAY

Everything in the first table costs less than a takeaway and goes with you. Nothing in either table makes a hole that cannot be filled.

Part Six, in nine lines

ONE

You do not own the paint. You own the light, the height of everything hung, and every texture in the room — three corrections out of four.

TWO

In a flat you may not paint, the bulb is the paint.

THREE

A hole you can fill is not damage. Photographs on day one, originals in a box, and nothing here costs you a deposit.

AND THE SIX THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **Read the lease, then ask.** Most refusals are refusals of risk. One thing at a time, at your expense, reversible, in writing.
- **Halve every adhesive rating**, and never trust one over a bed. Wipe with alcohol, press thirty seconds, remove by pulling straight down.
- **Test-patch removable wallpaper** on a postcard of hidden wall for two weeks before you commit a room to it.
- **The rug is the floor now** — front legs on, and a proper pad if it is going over carpet.
- **Buy slightly smaller than this flat allows.** Rooms shrink more often than they grow.
- **Visible storage must be one material and one colour**, or it is clutter with a lid on.

AND THE ONE THAT IS NOT PRACTICAL AT ALL

Stop treating the flat as a waiting room. A home that is corrected properly for eighteen months is eighteen months of living well, and the lamps, the linen and the rug all come with you to the next one.

The flat is temporary. The way you see a room is not, and neither is anything worth buying.

PART SEVEN

Room by Room

The four corrections applied to particular rooms, and to the awkward ones nobody writes about — the long one, the one with five doors, the one you never use. Nothing new is introduced here. It is the same book, with the furniture moved.

The order, applied · 146
The sitting room · 147
The bedroom · 149
The dining table · 151
The awkward rooms · 157
One room, one evening · 163

CHAPTER SEVEN

The order, applied to any room

Every room in this part is corrected in the same order, and the order is the reason this works. Doing the right things in the wrong sequence is how people spend a great deal of money and change nothing.

1. **Empty what does not belong.** Before anything is assessed, take out everything that is in the room by accident rather than by decision. Half of what is wrong with most rooms is not a fault of design; it is three objects that ended up there.
2. **Light.** Three heights, warm, dimmable, big light off. Part Two. This costs least, changes most, and must come first because every other judgement you are about to make is a judgement made under this light.
3. **Height.** Curtains up, pictures to 145 cm, furniture off the walls. Part Four. An afternoon, and usually free.
4. **Texture.** Count the four families, add the missing one. Part Five.
5. **Colour.** Last, always. Part Three. By the time you arrive here, half the rooms that thought they needed painting no longer do — which is the whole argument of this book and the reason I have made you wait four steps to hold a brush.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE ORDER**
>
> *Light, height, texture, colour — in that order, in every room, every time. Anyone who sells you the last one first is selling, not correcting.*

HOW TO READ THE PAGES THAT FOLLOW

Each room gets the same treatment: the fault I found most often, then the corrections in the order above, then the numbers. Numbers given earlier are repeated here rather than cross- referenced, and all of them are collected on page 165.

WHAT EACH STEP USUALLY COSTS

Empty — an hour and a box	nothing
Light — bulbs, and lamps you may already own	least
Height — an afternoon, a drill, some filler	little
Texture — one missing family, often one object	some
Colour — paint, time, and disruption	most

The sitting room, and its four faults

This is the room I was called to most, and the complaint was always the same sentence: *it does not feel finished.* It was almost never the room they thought it was.

FAULT ONE · EVERYTHING IS PUSHED TO THE WALLS

The commonest arrangement in the world, and it comes from a reasonable instinct — to keep the middle clear. But a ring of furniture round an empty carpet is not a room; it is a waiting area. Pull the seating in. Even five or ten centimetres off the wall changes how the room photographs and how it feels, and this is page 100 in action.

FAULT TWO · THE SEATS ARE TOO FAR APART TO TALK

People buy the largest furniture the room will hold and then arrange it at the edges of the space, and the result is a room in which two people must raise their voices slightly. Nobody ever names this, and everybody feels it.

Furthest comfortable distance between two seats facing each other	2.4 m

FAULT THREE · ONE LIGHT, IN THE CEILING

Part Two, all of it. Three lamps, three heights, warm, and the overhead off. If you do only this, most people will tell you the room has been painted.

FAULT FOUR · THE RUG IS TOO SMALL

The most expensive of the four to fix and the most common of all — page 97. A rug that floats in the middle with every leg off it makes the furniture look temporary.

Not finished, in nine cases out of ten, means: lit from one place, arranged round the edges, and standing on a rug that is one size too small.

THE ORDER TO FIX THEM IN

Light first, because it is free and it changes how you judge the other three. Then pull the furniture in, which is also free. Then look again — genuinely look, in the evening, with the lamps on and the overhead off. About half the sitting rooms I was called to needed nothing further, and the rug was a decision for the following month rather than an emergency.

The sitting room, in numbers

These are the figures I worked to. They are not laws of physics; they are the distances at which a room stops being slightly uncomfortable in a way nobody can name.

Sofa to coffee table	35–45 cm
Coffee table height, against the seat cushion	level or just below
Walking route through the room, clear width	75–90 cm
Between a seat and a side table, so a cup can be set down	within arm's reach
Rug — front legs of every seat standing on it	minimum
Television centre, seated eye height	about 100 cm

TWO THAT NOBODY GIVES YOU

Side table top, against the arm of the chair beside it	level, ±5 cm
Floor lamp, bottom of the shade, against seated eye level	105–120 cm

A side table taller than the arm it serves is the reason people put cups on the floor. A floor lamp whose shade sits above seated eye level is the reason a room that is fully lit still feels glary.

THE TELEVISION, SINCE SOMEBODY HAS TO SAY IT

It is usually hung too high, because it was hung above a fireplace or a radiator rather than at the height of the people watching it. A screen mounted above a mantelpiece asks everyone in the room to sit with their chin up for two hours. If it cannot be lowered, at least stop treating it as the thing the room faces: turn the seating to face the seating, and let the screen be watched at an angle.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

"A sitting room is furniture arranged around a conversation. If it is arranged around an appliance, that is what you will have."

One more, which costs nothing: give the room somewhere to put a cup down within reach of every seat. A guest with nowhere to set a glass never relaxes, and they will never tell you why.

The bedroom is lit for lying down

Every other room is lit for standing or sitting. The bedroom is the only room in the house you use with your head on a pillow, and almost nobody lights it that way.

Lie down on the bed tonight with the lights as they are and look straight up. If you are looking directly into a bulb, you have found the fault, and it is the one that makes people call their own bedroom restless without knowing why.

THE THREE SOURCES, BEDROOM VERSION

- **Beside the bed, one each side**, with the bottom of the shade at about the height of your eyes when you are sitting up. Higher and it shines in your face; lower and you cannot read.
- **Low, across the room** — a lamp on the floor or a low chest, which is the light you leave on while the room is being used for anything other than sleeping.
- **Overhead, off.** Or fitted with the dimmest warm bulb in the flat, for finding things.

Bedside table top, against the mattress top	within 5–8 cm
Bedside lamp, bottom of shade above mattress	50–60 cm
Colour temperature, bedroom, everywhere	2700 K or warmer

THE SWITCH THAT MATTERS MORE THAN THE LAMP

You must be able to turn the light off without getting up, and on without finding it in the dark. A bedside lamp with a switch on the flex halfway down the wall is a lamp that will be left on or left off. This is a two-euro problem that ruins a fifty-euro lamp, and a plug-in switch at the pillow solves it.

And curtains: this is the one room where the question is not only how they look. Lined or interlined, hung wide enough to clear the glass entirely when open, and long enough that light does not run out along the floor.

THE TWO LIGHTS NOBODY COUNTS

The standby lamp on a television or a charger, and the screen of a telephone at one in the morning. Both are small, both are cold in colour, and both are in a room you have just carefully warmed. Turn the first to the wall or cover it; charge the second in another room. It is not decorating, but it is the last two per cent of a bedroom that is genuinely dark.

The bed wall, and what goes on it

The bed is the largest object you own and it sets the proportion of the room single-handed. Nearly every bedroom fault is a fault of what is above it or beside it.

WHERE THE BED GOES

Against the longest uninterrupted wall, ideally with a view of the door and never with the head under a window if it can be avoided — not for any mystical reason, but because a window above a bed is cold, draughty, and impossible to curtain properly. Leave room to walk both sides if the room allows it; if it does not, accept one side against a wall rather than leaving a corridor of 30 cm that nobody can use.

Clear space each side of a double bed, where possible	60–70 cm
Space at the foot, to walk past	75 cm
Rug, extending beyond the sides of the bed	45–60 cm

ABOVE THE BED

The rule from page 87 changes here, because the bed governs. Anything hung above a bed is centred on the bed, not on the wall, and its width should be somewhere between half and two thirds of the bed's width. Hang it so there is a hand's span or a little more between the bottom of the frame and the top of the headboard — close enough that the two read as one composition.

THE ONE GENUINE SAFETY RULE IN THIS BOOK

Whatever hangs above a bed should be light, and should be fixed properly — a screw into something solid, not an adhesive strip. If the only fixing available is adhesive, hang nothing there. A mirror above a sleeping person is not worth one night's worry.

If the bed has no headboard, the wall behind it is doing that job, and it is the single best place in a rented flat for a large piece of fabric — page 134.

The dining table, and the light above it

There is exactly one light in a home that everybody agrees should hang from the ceiling, and it is this one. It is also, in my experience, the most reliably hung wrong.

A pendant over a table is the only overhead light that works, and the reason is on page 29: it is low enough to be below eye level, so it lights the table and the hands and the food without lighting the tops of everybody's heads. It only works at the right height, and the right height is lower than people dare.

Bottom of the shade above the table top	75–90 cm
Shade width, against the table width	one third to one half
Chair pulled out, clear space behind	90 cm
Table edge to wall, to walk past a seated person	100 cm

THE THREE MISTAKES

- **Too high.** At 120 cm above the table it has become an ordinary ceiling light and lost every advantage it had.
- **Not centred on the table.** It must be centred on the table, not on the room, and if the table cannot go under the existing fitting, the answer is a hook in the ceiling and a length of flex swagged across — an old, honest, entirely respectable solution.
- **Not dimmable.** A table light at full strength is a kitchen. At a third it is a dinner.

If the shade is open at the bottom, the bulb will be visible to seated guests: use a frosted or opal bulb, or one of the shades that carries a small diffuser. A bare filament at eye level across a dinner table is the one fashionable lighting choice I have never been able to forgive.

IF A PENDANT IS IMPOSSIBLE

Then light the table from the sides at about the same height instead: two lamps on a sideboard, or wall lights, or — the oldest answer and still the best one — candles, which sit exactly where a pendant would and put the light precisely where the food is. A table lit low is the one piece of theatre in this book that I recommend without any reservation at all.

The kitchen, as a room

A kitchen is designed by people who think about workflow and bought by people who think about doors, and it is finished by nobody at all.

LIGHT, WHICH IS TWO JOBS AND NOT ONE

A kitchen needs task light on the surfaces — under the wall cupboards, over the hob, on the sink — and it needs a soft light for the hours when nobody is cooking. Almost every kitchen has the first badly and the second not at all. Under-cupboard light is the correction that people thank me for most, because standing in your own shadow while chopping is a genuine daily irritation that everyone has stopped noticing.

Task light on worktops	3000 K, CRI 90+
The evening light — a lamp or a dimmed pendant	2700 K
Worktop height, standard	90–92 cm
Gap between facing runs, for two people	120 cm

TEXTURE, WHICH IS THE WHOLE OF THE REST

A fitted kitchen is one material repeated forty times. That is why it reads as a showroom rather than a room, and the correction is on page 111 — wood, ceramic, stone, linen, something growing. A wooden board standing against the wall, a stone mortar, a ceramic jug of utensils, a linen cloth over the rail. This is not styling. It is the same four families you would count in a sitting room.

COLOUR, IF IT IS YOURS TO CHANGE

The inside of a kitchen window reveal, the wall above the tiles, and the ceiling. Those three surfaces take colour without touching a single cupboard door, and they are usually the only unfitted surfaces left.

THE ONE THING A KITCHEN NEEDS THAT IT NEVER HAS

Somewhere to sit. Even a single stool changes what a kitchen is for: somebody can keep you company while you cook, which is the whole reason people gather there. If the kitchen is too small for a chair, a stool that tucks fully under the worktop is worth more than any other object you could put in that space.

The first three metres

The entrance is the room nobody decorates and everybody judges — including you, four times a day, in the second before you take your coat off.

It is also, in most flats, the worst-lit space in the home: no window, one overhead fitting, and a wall of coats. Three corrections, and it is usually the cheapest room in the book to fix.

ONE · A LIGHT THAT IS NOT OVERHEAD

A small lamp on any surface, or a wall light if one exists. If there is genuinely nowhere, a shelf at 110 cm with a lamp on it creates the surface and the light in one move. An entrance lit at head height instead of from the ceiling is the difference between arriving somewhere and arriving in a corridor.

TWO · A PLACE FOR THE FOUR THINGS

Keys, post, shoes, coat. If the hall does not hold those four, they will be held by the kitchen table for the rest of your life. A bowl, a hook, a basket, a shelf.

Coat hooks, adult height	165–175 cm
Second row, for children	110 cm
Shelf for keys and post	100–110 cm

THREE · A MIRROR, AND WHERE

Not opposite the front door, where it will only ever reflect the door. On the wall you pass, so that it reflects the room beyond and lengthens the hall — page 90. Hang it so that the top is above the head of the tallest person who lives there, or it will cut them off at the forehead every morning for years.

Three metres, one lamp, one hook, one mirror. No room in this book returns so much for so little.

IF THERE IS NO HALL AT ALL

Many flats open straight into the sitting room, and the correction is to build the first three metres anyway: a rug at the door, a hook on the wall beside it, a small table or shelf with a lamp and a bowl. Those four objects, standing together, create an entrance where the architecture did not provide one — and they stop the sitting room being the place where coats live.

The bathroom, quickly

Small, hard, bright and reflective — every quality that makes a room unforgiving. It is also the fastest room in the house to correct, because there is so little of it.

THE LIGHT, WHICH IS THE WHOLE COMPLAINT

Light from directly overhead falls into the eye sockets and under the chin, and produces the face that makes people say they look terrible in this bathroom. They do not. They are lit badly.

The correction is light *beside* the mirror at about face height rather than above it, so that both sides of the face receive light. Where that is not possible, warm the bulb and add a second small source anywhere else in the room — two poor lights are dramatically kinder than one.

Mirror lights, either side, centre at	about 160 cm
Bathroom colour temperature	2700–3000 K
Colour rendering, where you will look at your face	CRI 90+

THE SAFETY LINE, AGAIN

Bathroom electrics are regulated, and the rules differ by country: what may be installed, and how close to water, is not a matter of taste. Anything beyond changing a bulb belongs to a qualified electrician.

AND THE REST, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

The shower curtain is the largest textile in the room and behaves like any other curtain — weight first, length second, colour last. Towels: fewer, and matching, because six mismatched towels in a small room are six decorative decisions you did not make on purpose. A plant that tolerates low light and damp air. And a stool or a small chair if there is any room at all, which turns a functional cubicle into somewhere you might sit and read.

THE MIRROR, WHILE WE ARE HERE

Bigger than you think, and as wide as the basin below it if the wall allows. A small mirror centred over a wide basin is the single commonest proportion error in a bathroom, and it makes an already small room read as a cupboard.

The desk, and which way it faces

More homes contain a desk now than at any point in my working life, and almost every one I have seen was placed by where the socket was.

THE WINDOW GOES TO THE SIDE

There are three places a desk can face, and only one of them is right.

- **Facing the window** — you look into bright sky all day, and anything on the desk sits against glare. Tiring within an hour.
- **Back to the window** — the light falls over your shoulder onto the screen, which is now a mirror, and on a call your face is a silhouette.
- **Window to the side** — daylight across the surface, nothing behind the screen, no reflection in it. This is the answer, and it has been the answer since people wrote with ink.

If you write or draw by hand, put the window on the side opposite your writing hand, so your hand does not cast a shadow across its own work. That is the oldest rule in this book and it comes from the workrooms of the Croix-Rousse.

Desk height, standard	72–75 cm
Top of the screen, against your eyes	at or just below
Screen distance	about an arm
Task lamp, from the side, never behind the screen	3000 K

AND ONE THING THAT IS NOT ERGONOMIC AT ALL

A desk in a room you live in must be able to stop being a desk at six o'clock. A lamp you switch off, a lid you close, a basket the papers go into. Otherwise the work is the last thing you see every evening, and the room never becomes a home again.

One room that does four jobs

A studio is not a small flat. It is a sitting room, a bedroom, a kitchen and an office asked to occupy the same floor at the same time, and the mistake everybody makes is trying to make it look like one thing.

DO NOT BLUR IT. DIVIDE IT.

The instinct is to keep everything matching and low and pale so the room reads as one space. It does — as one undifferentiated space, which is why studios feel like waiting rooms. Divide it instead, with the four tools you already have:

1. **Light.** The strongest divider there is, and the only one that takes no floor. Each zone gets its own light and its own switch. When the bed corner is lit and the desk is dark, the room *is* a bedroom; at nine in the morning it reverses. One room, four rooms, no walls moved.
2. **The floor.** A rug under the sitting area and bare floor elsewhere draws the line more clearly than any screen.
3. **A back.** The back of a sofa, a low bookcase, an open shelf unit — anything with a back to it makes a boundary at waist height without blocking the light.
4. **Fabric.** A curtain on a ceiling track across the bed is the oldest studio solution in Europe, costs very little, and disappears in the day.

THE ONE RULE I WOULD NOT BREAK

> ### FOR ONE-ROOM HOMES
>
> *The bed should not also be the sofa. If there is any way at all to have a real bed and a separate seat, take it — even if both are small. A home where you must dismantle where you sleep in order to sit down is a home that is never at rest.*

And storage, more than anywhere: page 140, and the rule that visible storage must be one material and one colour. In a studio, everything is visible from everywhere.

THE AWKWARD ROOMS

The long, narrow one

The corridor room: twice as long as it is wide, one window at the far end, and furniture down both long walls because there is nowhere else to put it.

That last decision is what makes it a corridor. A room lined on both long sides has announced its own proportion, and everything that follows exaggerates it.

FOUR CORRECTIONS, IN ORDER

1. **Break the length into two rooms.** Not physically — by use. Sitting at one end, table or desk at the other. Two centres are read by the eye as two spaces, and two short spaces are better proportioned than one long one.
2. **Turn something across the width.** A sofa with its back to the middle of the room, a rug running across rather than along, a bench at right angles. Every horizontal line that crosses the room cuts the length.
3. **Light both ends.** The tunnel effect is mostly a lighting fault: a bright window at the far end and darkness at the near end makes the room read as longer than it is. A lamp at the dark end collapses the distance immediately.
4. **Put something substantial at the far end.** A large picture, a tall cupboard, a heavier colour on that one wall — the end wall is the one place where an accent wall is genuinely doing work rather than decorating, because it stops the eye.

WHAT NOT TO DO

Do not run a long thin rug down the middle. It is the commonest attempt and it is the one thing guaranteed to make a long room longer, for the same reason a runner makes a hallway read as a hallway.

A narrow room is cured across, never along.

IF THE WINDOW IS ON A LONG WALL INSTEAD

Then you are luckier than you think, and the room is easier: put the main seating facing that wall rather than down the length, so that the room is used across its short dimension. A room is as wide as the way you sit in it.

THE AWKWARD ROOMS

The one with five doors

Old flats were divided and redivided, and the result is a room with a door to the hall, a door to the kitchen, a pair of glazed doors, a cupboard and a radiator — and about two metres of usable wall.

MEASURE THE SWINGS FIRST

Before deciding anything, open every door fully and mark on the floor where it lands. The room you actually have is what is left. People try to furnish the plan and then spend two years edging round a door.

THEN USE WHAT IS LEFT PROPERLY

- **The one good wall gets the one large thing.** Sofa, bed, or cupboard — whichever is the largest object. Do not divide your only wall between two medium objects.
- **Float the rest.** With no walls left, the furniture must stand in the room, and it needs a rug under it to explain why it is there.
- **Quiet the doors.** Five doors in five different finishes are five loud objects. Painting doors and architraves the same colour as the walls — page 63 — makes them recede, and it is the single most effective thing available in a room like this.
- **Use the leaf.** The back of a door is a wall you are not using: hooks, a narrow shelf, a mirror.

IF A DOOR IS NEVER USED

Say so out loud, and then commit. A door that is never opened can be curtained over or have a piece of furniture in front of it, and you have bought yourself a wall — provided it is not a fire escape route or the only way out of a room, which is a real consideration and not a decorative one.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

“Count the doors before you fall in love with the sofa.”

THE AWKWARD ROOMS

Open plan, without walls

A wall was removed to make one big room, and what was gained in light was lost in definition. The complaint is always the same: it is lovely, but it feels like a hall.

The correction is not to put the wall back. It is to give each part of the room the three things a room has — its own floor, its own light, and a back.

Its own floor	a rug, sized properly
Its own light	own lamps, own switch
A back	sofa, shelf or bench

THE LIGHTING IS THE WHOLE THING

In an open-plan room the lighting must be able to do what a wall used to do: switch a part of the room off. If the kitchen end and the sitting end share one circuit, you will always be sitting in kitchen light, which is bright, high and working. Separate switching — even if it is only lamps on plugs — is what lets the room become an evening room at seven.

THE SEAM BETWEEN COOKING AND SITTING

The hardest part of open plan is that the kitchen is always on show, including the washing up. Two practical answers, both better than pretending: let the sitting area face away from the kitchen, so that the back of the sofa is the boundary; and make the light in the kitchen end switchable down to almost nothing, so that after dinner the whole zone simply goes dark and stops existing.

Sound matters here more than in any other room, and it is the reason open-plan spaces feel tiring. Hard floor, hard surfaces, high ceiling and no doors make an echo. Rug, curtains, a full bookcase and upholstery are the cure, and they are the same four things Part Five asked for anyway.

THE AWKWARD ROOMS

The low one and the tall one

Two opposite faults with the same cure in reverse: decide where you want the eye to go, and put a strong horizontal line there.

THE LOW CEILING

Anything under about 2.4 metres feels low, and the usual response — paint everything white — does very little. What works:

- **Curtains from the ceiling, not from the frame.** The largest single gain available, and page 92 explains it. A curtain that starts at the ceiling tells the eye the wall is as tall as the fabric.
- **Light upwards.** An uplight or a shade open at the top puts light on the ceiling and dissolves it. A downlight does the exact opposite and presses the ceiling down.
- **Keep the furniture low**, and the top edge of everything at a consistent height, so there is one horizontal line rather than five.
- **Do not use a deep colour on the ceiling** here, whatever page 61 permits elsewhere — that is for rooms with height to give away.

THE VERY TALL ROOM

Less common, and almost nobody admits it is a problem, but a room of four metres with everything at knee height feels like a cathedral with a sofa in it. I grew up in one.

- **Bring the light down.** A pendant hung low over a table, lamps at head height. Light is what sets the height of a room at night: light only the lower three metres and the room is three metres tall after dark.
- **Draw a line at about 2.1 m.** A picture rail, a shelf, the top of tall curtains, a change of colour. Above it becomes ceiling; below it becomes room.
- **Use the height for one thing only** — a tall cupboard, a long curtain, one very large picture — rather than filling the whole wall.

The child’s room, honestly

This is the room where the most money is spent on the things that matter least, and I say that as somebody who was paid to supply them.

WHAT IS GENUINELY WORTH IT

1. **Darkness.** Lined or blackout curtains, hung wide enough to cover the glass entirely. This is the one purchase in the room that changes a household’s life, and it is not decorative at all.
2. **A low, warm light for the night.** Not the ceiling light. A small dim lamp at floor or bedside level, 2700 K or warmer, that can be left on or found in the dark.
3. **Storage a child can actually use.** Low, open, and one material — page 140. Things get put away at the height the child can reach, and nowhere else.
4. **A surface to work at, lit from the side.** Page 155, at a smaller height.

THE SAFETY RULES, WHICH ARE NOT DECORATING

- Every tall piece of furniture — chest of drawers, bookcase, wardrobe — must be anchored to the wall. Toppling furniture injures and kills small children. This is not optional and it is not a matter of taste.
- Looped blind and curtain cords are a strangulation hazard. Use cordless blinds, or fit the tensioner and cleat that keep cords out of reach, and keep the cot away from the window.
- Nothing heavy or glazed hangs over a bed.

WHAT IS NOT WORTH IT

The theme. A room decorated as a jungle, a rocket or a castle is a room that will be outgrown in three years and repainted twice. Put the theme in the things that are easy to change — the bedding, the posters, the toys, a cheap rug — and let the room itself be a plain, warm, well-lit room that will still work when the child is fifteen.

The room you do not use

Almost every home has one: the dining room nobody dines in, the spare room that is a cupboard with a bed in it, the front room kept for visitors who come twice a year.

It is not a decorating problem. It is a problem of not having given the room a job, and no amount of paint fixes a room that has not been told what it is for.

THE QUESTION, ASKED OUT LOUD

What happens in here every week? Not on special occasions — every week. If the honest answer is nothing, the room is currently a storage unit that you are heating, and you have two choices: give it a weekly job, or admit it is storage and make it good storage.

IF YOU GIVE IT A JOB

Pick one, and let the room be unapologetically that: the room where the ironing and the sewing happen, the room with the piano, the room where somebody works, the room where the children make a mess so the sitting room stays clean. Then apply the order of operations on page 146 to that job. A room with a purpose gets used, and a room that gets used gets corrected naturally over time.

IF IT IS A GUEST ROOM

A guest needs six things, and I have stayed in a great many houses that supplied none of them:

- A light beside the bed with a switch that can be found in the dark.
- Somewhere to put a suitcase that is not the floor or the bed.
- One empty drawer or one empty shelf, and four hangers.
- A hook on the back of the door.
- A mirror they can see themselves in, and somewhere to set a glass of water.
- Curtains that actually make the room dark.

Six things, most of which cost nothing, and they are worth more than any amount of decoration in a room somebody sleeps in twice a year.

WORKSHEET

One room, one evening

Work in the order on page 146. Do not skip to colour.

ROOM _____ DATE _____

ONE · THE FIVE STEPS

STEP	WHAT I DID	COST
Empty		
Light		
Height		
Texture		
Colour		

TWO · THE CHECKS FOR THIS ROOM

- [ ] Light comes from three heights, and the overhead is off
- [ ] Nothing is hung above 150 cm to its centre without a reason
- [ ] Every seat has somewhere to set a cup down
- [ ] The rug is big enough that the front legs stand on it
- [ ] All four texture families are present
- [ ] Every route through the room is at least 75 cm wide

THE ONE FAULT STILL UNFIXED, AND WHAT IT WILL TAKE

Part Seven, in nine lines

ONE

Light, height, texture, colour — in that order, in every room, every time.

TWO

A narrow room is cured across, never along.

THREE

A room that has not been given a job cannot be fixed by decorating it.

AND THE SIX THAT DO NOT NEED THEIR OWN PAGE

- **"It does not feel finished"** almost always means: lit from one place, furniture round the edges, rug one size too small.
- **The bedroom is the only room used lying down.** Lie on the bed and look up before you light it.
- **The dining pendant hangs 75–90 cm above the table**, centred on the table and not on the room, and it must dim.
- **The desk takes the window on its side** — never facing it, never with its back to it.
- **Open plan needs its own floor, its own light and a back** for each part, and separate switching above all.
- **In a child's room, buy darkness and anchor the furniture.** The theme goes on the bedding, where it can be outgrown cheaply.

THAT IS THE BOOK

What remains is reference: every number collected in one place, the audit that tells you which room to start on, and the list of things I would not buy again.

We do not decorate a room, ma chère. We correct it — one room, in one evening, in that order.

REFERENCE

The Measurements

Every number in this book, collected in one place, in the order you will need them. This is the part to photograph before you go to a shop, and the part to open when you are standing on a chair with a pencil in your mouth.

Light · 167
Windows and curtains · 169
Hanging things · 171
Rugs · 173
Room by room · 175
The ten that matter most · 180

How to use this list

These are working figures, not laws. I give them because a number you can act on tonight is worth more than a principle you have to interpret.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW BEFORE YOU USE ANY OF THEM

1. **A range means a range.** Where I write 15–25 cm, anywhere in that band is right, and the choice between them is usually decided by what else is on the wall. Where I give a single number — 145 cm for the centre of a picture — it is single because the eye genuinely notices when it is wrong.

2. **The room wins the argument.** If a figure here fights something obvious in front of you — a beam, a radiator, a window that starts at hip height — the room is right and the number is wrong. Page 88 is about exactly that conflict.

3. **Measure twice, in the room, at the time of day you use it.** Almost every mistake I ever made in fourteen years was made by measuring once, in the morning, from the doorway.

METRIC AND IMPERIAL

Both are given throughout. Where the imperial figure is a round number and the metric is not — 57 inches, 145 centimetres — that is because the convention came from a country that measures in inches, and I have not tidied it into a rounder metric number that would be slightly wrong.

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

"My grandmother wrote the drop of every window she ever measured, and never once wrote the reason. Forty-one years of numbers and no arguments. I have tried to give you both."

TWO HABITS WORTH MORE THAN ANY FIGURE HERE

- **Write it down in the room.** Not on your telephone as you walk away — on paper, standing where you measured. Every wrong curtain I ever ordered was ordered from a number I was sure I remembered.
- **Mark it before you commit to it.** Masking tape on the wall for the pole, newspaper on the floor for the rug, a pencil cross for the picture hook. Live with it for a day. It costs nothing and it has saved me more money than any other habit in this book.

ONE

Light

HOW MANY, AND WHERE

Separate light sources in any room anybody sits in, minimum	3
A sitting room, comfortably	4–6
Of which on the ceiling	1, off in the evening
Of which below 60 cm from the floor	at least 1

LAMP HEIGHTS

Bottom of the shade, beside a chair or sofa	100–115 cm · 40–45 in
Which means a table lamp of about	45–60 cm · 18–24 in
Bottom of the shade, on a desk or console you stand at	125–135 cm · 49–53 in
Floor lamp, shade bottom against seated eye level	105–120 cm

SHADES

Shade height, as a share of the whole lamp	about one third
Shade width at the bottom, against the base	roughly twice
A shade must hide, from every seat	the bulb and the fitting

SOURCES BY ROOM, AS A STARTING POINT

Sitting room	4–6
Bedroom	3 — two beside the bed, one low
Kitchen	2 — task, and one soft
Hall or entrance	1, but not overhead

ONE, CONTINUED

What is written on the box

COLOUR TEMPERATURE

Every room you sit in, and every bedroom	2700 K
Kitchen and bathroom task light	2700–3000 K
A desk, where you need to stay awake	3000 K
Anything above this, anywhere in a home	no

COLOUR RENDERING — CRI OR R_A

Everywhere, as a minimum	90+
Where you look at your own face, or at fabric	95 if you can find it
If the box does not print it at all	assume it is low

BRIGHTNESS, IN LUMENS

Table lamp beside a chair	400–600 lm
Floor lamp, general	600–900 lm
Bedside, for reading	300–450 lm
Under-cupboard task light, per metre of worktop	300–400 lm

Watts tell you what a bulb costs to run, not how bright it is. Lumens are the brightness. The two were the same thing for a century and have not been for fifteen years, and the habit is the single commonest reason people buy a bulb that disappoints them.

TWO

Windows and curtains

WHERE THE POLE GOES

Above the top of the window frame	15–20 cm · 6–8 in
Or, better, below the ceiling or cornice	8–15 cm · 3–6 in
Beyond the frame, each side	15–25 cm · 6–10 in

THE DROP

Floating — the safe choice, and what I usually did	1 cm above the floor
Breaking — fabric resting on the boards	2–5 cm on the floor
Sill length, only where a radiator or a worktop forces it	1 cm below the sill
Any curtain that stops between the sill and the floor	never

FULLNESS — FABRIC WIDTH AGAINST POLE WIDTH

Bare minimum, will look thin	1.5 ×
Standard, and what most ready-made curtains give you	2 ×
Generous — what makes the difference	2.5 ×
Sheers and very light fabric	2.5–3 ×

IN A RENTED FLAT

Tension rod, sensible span	under 120 cm
Tension rod, sensible curtain	unlined only

TWO, CONTINUED

Measuring a window, in order

This is my grandmother's sequence, unchanged. Write every figure down before you calculate anything, because the arithmetic is where the mistakes live.

1. **Decide where the pole goes first**, and mark it on the wall in pencil. Every other figure depends on it, and almost everybody measures the window instead.
2. **Measure the pole width**, bracket to bracket, once the pole position is marked — not the window.
3. **Measure the drop from the ring to the floor**, not from the pole. The curtain hangs from the bottom of the ring, and the difference is four or five centimetres, which is exactly the amount that looks wrong.
4. **Measure the drop in three places** — left, middle, right. Floors are not level. Work to the shortest.
5. **Multiply the pole width by your fullness** to get the fabric width you need, then divide by the number of curtain panels.
6. **Add the hem allowances** the maker asks for, and add them again if you are unsure. Fabric can be shortened. It cannot be lengthened.

THE ONE THAT CATCHES EVERYBODY

Ready-made curtains are sold by the width of the *fabric*, not the width of the window. A pair labelled 168 cm wide means each panel is 168 cm of cloth — which on a 200 cm pole gives you 336 over 200, about 1.7 ×, and that is why so many bought curtains look thin. Check the label, then check your arithmetic.

Full working, with a diagram, is on page 96.

THE ARITHMETIC, WORKED ONCE

A window 120 cm wide. The pole goes 20 cm beyond each side, so the pole is 160 cm. At 2.5 × fullness that is 400 cm of fabric, over two panels: 200 cm of cloth in each. The ring sits 7 cm below the pole and the floor is 242 cm down from it, so the drop is 241 cm to float one centimetre clear. Write those four numbers — 160, 2.5, 200, 241 — and you can order curtains from anybody in the world.

THREE

Hanging things

HEIGHT

Centre of a picture on an open wall	145 cm · 57 in
Where the hook goes	145 + half height – wire drop
Above furniture — gap to the bottom of the frame	15–25 cm · 6–10 in
Above a mantelpiece	10–15 cm · 4–6 in
Above a bed — centred on the bed, not the wall	a hand's span above the headboard

SIZE AND SPACING

Art width against the furniture below it	about two thirds
Art width above a bed, against the bed	one half to two thirds
Gap between frames in a group	5–8 cm · 2–3 in
That gap, used identically throughout the group	yes — this is what makes it read

MIRRORS

Decorative mirror on an open wall — centre	145 cm · 57 in
Over a mantel — above the shelf	10–15 cm · 4–6 in
Over a basin or console — above the surface	15–20 cm · 6–8 in
Full-length mirror — top edge	175–185 cm

THREE, CONTINUED

Shelves, and what will hold

SHELVES

Lowest shelf of an open unit, above the floor	at least 25–30 cm
Highest shelf you will use daily	no higher than 180 cm
Between shelves, for ordinary books	28–32 cm
A storage shelf near the ceiling	about 200 cm
A single floating shelf above a sofa or desk	treat as art — page 88

FIXINGS, HONESTLY

Adhesive strips, what I will actually trust them with	half the printed rating
Anything glazed, above a bed or a cot	a screw, or nothing
A shelf that will carry weight	into something structural
Paint curing time before anything is stuck to it	a week, and longer is better

KNOW WHAT YOUR WALL IS BEFORE YOU DRILL

Solid masonry, plasterboard on studs, and old lath and plaster all take completely different fixings, and a fixing meant for one of them will fail in the others. Tap the wall: a dull thud is solid, a hollow drum is plasterboard. And check for cables and pipes before any hole — they run vertically and horizontally from sockets and switches, which is exactly where people hang pictures.

ROUGH GUIDANCE ON WHAT A WALL WILL CARRY

Solid masonry, with the right plug	almost anything domestic
Plasterboard, into a stud	shelves, mirrors, poles
Plasterboard, between studs, with a proper anchor	pictures, light shelves
Old lath and plaster	find the timber, or ask

FOUR

Rugs

The most expensive common mistake in a home is a rug one size too small, so these are the figures I would defend hardest.

SITTING ROOM

Minimum that works — front legs of every seat	standing on it
Better — all legs of everything	on it
Margin left between the rug and the wall	20–45 cm
Clear walking width around it	60–70 cm

DINING AND BEDROOM

Dining — beyond the table edge, all round	60–75 cm · 24–30 in
Which is the distance a chair travels when pulled out	and the whole reason for it
Bedroom — beyond the sides of the bed	45–60 cm
Or two runners, one each side	60–80 cm wide

UNDER IT

A pad, on any floor	always
Over carpet, the pad must be	made for carpet

And the rule that saves the most money: measure the rug you want on the floor in masking tape before you buy it. Ten minutes, no cost, and it has stopped me buying the wrong size more times than I would like to admit.

FIVE

Clearances and routes

Nobody notices these until they are wrong, and then they notice them every day for years without ever naming what is irritating them.

GETTING ABOUT

Walkway, minimum	75 cm
Main route through a room	90 cm
Between a wall and the edge of a table people sit at	100 cm
Behind a dining chair, pulled out	90 cm
Between two facing kitchen runs, for two people	120 cm
Each side of a double bed, where possible	60–70 cm
At the foot of a bed, to walk past	75 cm

SITTING

Furthest comfortable distance between facing seats	2.4 m
Sofa to coffee table	35–45 cm
Coffee table height, against the seat cushion	level to 5 cm below
Side table top, against the chair arm beside it	level, ±5 cm
Dining seat to table top	28–32 cm
Float furniture off the wall by	5–15 cm · 2–6 in

SIX

Room by room

BEDROOM

Bedside table top, against the mattress top	within 5–8 cm
Bedside lamp, bottom of the shade above the mattress	50–60 cm
Colour temperature, everywhere in the room	2700 K or warmer

DINING

Pendant, bottom of the shade above the table top	75–90 cm
Shade width, against the table width	one third to one half
Centred on	the table, never the room

KITCHEN

Worktop height, standard	90–92 cm
Task light on the worktop	3000 K, CRI 90+

BATHROOM AND ENTRANCE

Mirror lights, either side, centre at	about 160 cm
Coat hooks, adult	165–175 cm
Second row, for children	110 cm
Shelf for keys and post	100–110 cm

DESK

Desk height, standard	72–75 cm
Top of the screen, against your eyes	at or just below
The window	on your side, never in front or behind

SEVEN

Fabric and upholstery

RUB COUNTS — WHAT THE LABEL MEANS

Light domestic — an occasional chair	10,000–15,000 Martindale
General domestic — a normal sofa	15,000–25,000
Heavy domestic — family, daily use, pets	25,000+
The question that matters more than any of them	can this be reupholstered?

CUSHIONS

How many on a three-seat sofa	3–5, odd numbers
How many different fabrics among them	2 or 3, never all the same
Insert size, against the cover	2–5 cm larger
Feather or down against polyester	feather, every time

CURTAIN FABRIC, BY WEIGHT

Sheers and voiles — light, for privacy only	no warmth, no dark
Unlined linen or cotton — the everyday curtain	hangs well from 2.5 ×
Lined — what makes a curtain look bought properly	worth the money
Interlined — heavy, warm, dark	bedrooms and cold rooms

RUG FIBRE, IN ONE LINE EACH

Wool — takes weight, recovers, lasts	the answer, if affordable
Jute and sisal — texture, cheap, rough underfoot	good under a table
Cotton flat-weave — washable, thin	kitchens and children
Very thin printed synthetic	avoid entirely

EIGHT

Metric and imperial

For the numbers in this book that you are most likely to need in the other system, while standing in a shop that only sells one of them.

WHAT	METRIC	IMPERIAL
Centre of a picture	145 cm	57 in
Pole above the window frame	15–20 cm	6–8 in
Pole beyond the frame, each side	15–25 cm	6–10 in
Gap above furniture to a frame	15–25 cm	6–10 in
Gap between frames in a group	5–8 cm	2–3 in
Lamp shade bottom, beside a chair	100–115 cm	40–45 in
Pendant above a dining table	75–90 cm	30–35 in
Rug beyond a dining table edge	60–75 cm	24–30 in
Walkway, minimum	75 cm	30 in
Main route through a room	90 cm	36 in
Float furniture off the wall	5–15 cm	2–6 in
Worktop height	90–92 cm	36 in
Desk height	72–75 cm	28–30 in

IF YOU NEED TO CONVERT SOMETHING THAT IS NOT HERE

Centimetres to inches	divide by 2.54
Inches to centimetres	multiply by 2.54
A rough conversion, good enough for a shop	10 cm is about 4 in

NINE

What to take to the shop

Every disappointing purchase I have ever made was made without one of these six things in my pocket. Photograph this page.

1. **The measurements of the space it is going into**, written down — not the room, the space. Width, depth, height, and the distance to the nearest thing it must not touch.
2. **The narrowest point of the route home.** Door, stair, turn, lift. A sofa that fits the room and not the stairwell is the most expensive mistake in this book.
3. **A photograph of the room, taken in the evening with the lamps on.** Not in daylight. You will use the thing at night.
4. **A sample of whatever it has to live beside** — a cushion cover, a paint card, a photograph of the floor. Colour is a relationship, not a property, and you cannot hold it in your memory for the length of a bus ride.
5. **A tape measure.** Shop labels round generously.
6. **The question, written down: can this be repaired?** Ask it out loud, of a person, in the shop. The answer, and the face they make while giving it, tells you most of what you need to know.

> ### AND ONE RULE FOR THE SHOP ITSELF
>
> *Never judge a colour or a fabric under shop lighting. Take the sample outside, or to the door, or home. Page 35 explains why every shop you buy from is lit to flatter what it sells.*

AND TWO THINGS TO DO ON THE DAY IT ARRIVES

1. **Open it and look at it before the delivery leaves.** Damage found in the first five minutes is the shop's problem. Damage found next week is an argument.
2. **Put it where it is going before you fill it.** A bookcase is very heavy once it holds books, and a sofa cannot be turned round in a doorway once the room is rearranged round it.

WORKSHEET

My numbers

The figures that are true of your home and nobody else's. Fill it once; use it for years.

HOME _____ DATE _____

ONE · THE HOUSE ITSELF

MEASUREMENT	MINE
Ceiling height, main rooms	
Narrowest point of the route in — door, stair, turn	
Wall colour, name and finish	
Floor — what it is, and its undertone	

TWO · WINDOW BY WINDOW

WINDOW	POLE WIDTH	DROP	FULLNESS
1			
2			
3			
4			

THREE · THE THREE I ALWAYS FORGET

- [ ] Bulbs in this house: _____
- [ ] Rug sizes I need, room by room
- [ ] Which walls are solid and which are hollow

The ten that matter most

If you remember nothing else from this part, remember these. They account for most of what is wrong in most homes.

One. Centre of a picture	145 cm
Two. Light sources per room, minimum	3, at 3 heights
Three. Bulb colour, everywhere you sit	2700 K, CRI 90+
Four. Curtain pole, above the frame	15–20 cm
Five. Curtain fullness	2.5 × the pole
Six. Curtain drop	to the floor, always
Seven. Rug — front legs of every seat	on it
Eight. Pendant above a table	75–90 cm
Nine. Walkway	75 cm, 90 for a main route
Ten. Float furniture off the wall	5–15 cm

Eight of those ten cost nothing at all. That is not an accident; it is the argument of this whole book put into numbers.

AND THE FIVE THAT DO COST SOMETHING

In the order I would spend, if the money arrived slowly: the right-sized rug, one lined curtain on the best window, one good chair that can be reupholstered, one large piece of art, and a proper shade for the lamp you already own. Everything else on the previous list is a bulb, a tape measure and an evening.

REFERENCE

The Room Audit

Ten minutes, one room, a pencil. At the end of it you will know which of the four things is wrong, in what order to fix them, and which part of this book to open. If you only ever use one page of this book, I would like it to be this one.

How it works · 182
The audit, part one · 183
The audit, part two · 184
The audit, part three · 185
What your answers mean · 186
The whole home · 187

How the audit works

This is the thing I actually did, in a client's home, in the first ten minutes, before I said a word about what anything cost.

THE RULES

1. **Do it in the evening, with the lights you normally use.** Not in daylight, not with everything switched on for the occasion. The room as you actually live in it.
2. **Sit down where you normally sit.** Most faults in a room are only visible from the chair, and every photograph of a room is taken standing up, which is why rooms photograph better than they feel.
3. **Answer yes or no. Do not answer "sort of."** If you are hesitating, the answer is no.
4. **Do not fix anything while you audit.** Write it down and move on. The order matters more than the speed, and the order comes at the end.

WHAT YOU WILL HAVE AT THE END

Four scores out of six — light, height, texture, colour — and a page number. The lowest score is where you start, and it is nearly always light, which is fortunate, because light is the cheapest of the four to correct.

> ### BEFORE YOU BEGIN
>
> *Nothing on these pages asks what you own, what you spent, or what your taste is. Every question is about what is physically true of the room. That is deliberate. Your taste was never the problem.*

The three audit pages that follow are meant to be written on. If this is a file rather than a printed book, print these four pages on their own — they are the ones worth having on paper.

IF YOU SHARE THE HOME

Do the audit separately and compare the sheets. It is the only way I know to have this conversation without it becoming a conversation about taste — two people who disagree about a colour will nearly always agree that a room has one light source and a rug that is too small. Fix what you agree on first. It is usually most of it.

THE AUDIT · PART ONE

Light

ROOM

DATE AND TIME

SITTING WHERE YOU NORMALLY SIT, IN THE EVENING

- [ ] There are at least three separate light sources switched on in this room
- [ ] They are at different heights — not all on tables, not all overhead
- [ ] At least one of them is below sixty centimetres from the floor
- [ ] The ceiling light is off, and the room is still comfortable to be in
- [ ] I cannot see a bare bulb or a bright fitting from where I am sitting
- [ ] A solid object in this room casts a soft shadow, not a hard one, and not none at all

AND WHAT IS WRITTEN ON THE BULBS

FITTING	KELVIN	CRI
1		
2		
3		
4		

SCORE, OUT OF SIX

DAYLIGHT — WHICH WAY DOES THE WINDOW FACE?

Fewer than four ticks: turn to Part Two, page 21, and do nothing else until it is fixed. It is the cheapest correction in the book and it changes how you will judge the other three.

THE ONE THING I NOTICED SITTING HERE THAT IS NOT ON THIS LIST

THE AUDIT · PART TWO

Height and proportion

STAND IN THE DOORWAY AND LOOK, THEN MEASURE TWO THINGS

- [ ] Every picture and mirror has its centre at about 145 cm
- [ ] The curtain pole is above the window frame, not on it, and wider than the glass
- [ ] The curtains reach the floor
- [ ] No piece of furniture is pushed flat against the wall behind it
- [ ] The rug is large enough that the front legs of every seat stand on it
- [ ] There is one empty corner, or one clear surface, that is doing nothing

THE TWO MEASUREMENTS

WHAT	SHOULD BE	MINE
Centre of the largest picture, from the floor	145 cm	
Bottom of the curtain, from the floor	0–1 cm	
Pole, above the window frame	15–20 cm	
Narrowest walking route in the room	75 cm+	

SCORE, OUT OF SIX

Fewer than four: Part Four, page 85. Most of it is free, and the whole of it can be done in one afternoon with a pencil, a tape and a drill.

AND THE HEIGHTS THAT MUST AGREE WITH EACH OTHER

- [ ] The tops of the tall things in this room sit at roughly one height, not five
- [ ] The lamp shades are all at about the same height as each other
- [ ] Nothing tall stands directly in front of a window

THE AUDIT · PART THREE

Texture, and then colour

TEXTURE — BY TOUCHING, NOT BY LOOKING

- [ ] Something woven — curtain, rug, upholstery, cushion
- [ ] Something wooden, with visible grain
- [ ] Something ceramic, stone or plaster
- [ ] Something living
- [ ] At least two genuinely different surfaces within the woven family
- [ ] Nothing in this room arrived as a matched set — or a set has been interrupted

SCORE, OUT OF SIX — AND THE MISSING FAMILY IS

COLOUR — LAST, AND ONLY NOW

- [ ] I know the name and the finish of the paint on these walls
- [ ] The wall colour and the floor do not fight — their undertones agree
- [ ] The colour was tested on this wall, in this light, before it went on
- [ ] No more than three or four colours run through the whole home
- [ ] The woodwork is either the same as the wall or deliberately different
- [ ] Looking at it now, with the lamps on, I still like it

SCORE, OUT OF SIX

Do not act on a low colour score until light, height and texture are all above four. Half the rooms I was called to repaint did not need repainting.

What your answers mean

Write your four scores in a row. The lowest is where you begin, and if two are equal, begin with whichever comes first in the order light, height, texture, colour.

LOWEST SCORE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHERE TO GO
Light	The commonest, and the cheapest to fix	Part Two · 21
Height	Everything is hung and placed too low	Part Four · 85
Texture	The room reads as a showroom	Part Five · 105
Colour	Only now is this worth money	Part Three · 45

READING THE WHOLE ROW

- **All four at five or six.** The room is correct. If you still do not like it, the problem is not in this book — it is that the room is not being used for anything you enjoy, and page 162 is the honest page about that.
- **Light low, everything else high.** The best possible result, because one evening and three lamps will move every other score with it.
- **Colour high, everything else low.** The signature of a room that has been decorated rather than corrected: repainted more than once, still not right. Leave the paint entirely alone for a month and work the other three.
- **Everything at two or three.** Do not be discouraged — this is the most common result of all, and it is also the most rewarding, because the first evening's work will be visible from the door.

> ### THE ORDER, ONE LAST TIME
>
> *Light, height, texture, colour. Never colour first. Anyone who sells you the last one first is selling, not correcting.*

DO IT AGAIN IN A MONTH

Keep the first sheet. Re-audit the same room four weeks later and put the two side by side — it is the only honest measure of whether what you did actually worked, and it is far more reliable than how you feel about the room on any particular evening.

WORKSHEET

The whole home

One line per room. Audit each one, then read the column, not the row — it will tell you what is wrong with the whole house.

ROOM	LIGHT	HEIGHT	TEXTURE	COLOUR	START WITH

READING THE COLUMNS

- [ ] If the light column is low everywhere, buy bulbs for the whole house in one go
- [ ] If the height column is low everywhere, give the house one afternoon and a drill
- [ ] If one room is far worse than the rest, it is the room with no job — page 162

THE ONE ROOM I AM STARTING WITH, AND THE ONE THING I WILL DO FIRST

If a room scores five or six on everything and you still avoid it, that is not a decorating fault, and no further correction will fix it. Go to page 162.

The first evening

You have the scores. Here is what to do tonight, in the two hours after dinner, before you have bought anything at all.

1. **Take out what does not belong.** Everything in the room by accident rather than by decision, into a box, into another room. Twenty minutes.
2. **Turn the big light off and see what is left.** If there is not enough, move a lamp in from another room rather than buying one. Nearly every home already owns more lamps than it uses.
3. **Read the bulbs.** Write down what you need. That is tomorrow's shopping and it will cost less than dinner.
4. **Pull the largest piece of furniture off the wall** by a hand's width. Sit down again and look.
5. **Put your hand on five things** and name the missing texture family.
6. **Write one sentence** in the space below: what you will do next, and when. Not a plan for the room — one sentence.

NEXT

FROM THE NOTEBOOK

"Nobody ever corrected a room by reading about it. Two hours, one room, tonight — and tomorrow you will walk in and feel the difference before you can name it."

AND TOMORROW

Buy the bulbs. That is the whole of tomorrow. It is the only purchase in this book that changes every room in the house at once, and it costs less than a takeaway. Everything else can wait for the weekend, and most of it can wait for the month.

REFERENCE

What Not to Buy

The three shorter lists from earlier in the book, collected, with two more that had nowhere else to go. Fourteen years of watching money leave people's hands for things that did not work. It is the least charming part of this book and possibly the most useful.

Why this list exists · 190
Lighting · 191
Paint and colour · 192
Textiles · 193
Furniture · 194
What to buy instead · 196

Why this list exists

I was, for fourteen years, a person who sold things to people for their homes. I want to be honest about what that does to advice.

A decorator is paid either by the hour or by the thing. If by the thing, then every problem in your home has a solution that can be delivered in a van, and that is not corruption — it is just what the work rewards. I noticed it in myself. A client would describe a room that felt wrong and I would find myself reaching for a catalogue before I had sat down in it.

So this list is my correction to my own trade. It is every category of purchase where I saw money spent that did not improve a room, or that improved it for six months and then became a thing to get rid of.

THE FOUR TESTS BEHIND EVERY ENTRY

1. **Does it solve the fault, or does it decorate over it?** A darker cushion does not fix a room lit from one place.
2. **Will it still be here in ten years, and will I still want it?**
3. **Can it be repaired, recovered, or refinished by an ordinary person?**
4. **Does it move house?** If you rent, this is the first test, not the last.

A FAIR WARNING ABOUT THIS SECTION

These are my opinions, formed by what I saw in one city over fourteen years, and a person with a different climate, a different housing stock or a different budget may reasonably disagree with half of it. Where something is a matter of fact I say so; where it is a matter of taste I have tried to say that too. Page 201 is a whole page of things I might be wrong about.

HOW TO READ THE ENTRIES

Where an entry ends with a page number, the argument for it is made properly somewhere earlier in the book and you should go and read it before you accept my verdict. Where it does not, it is a judgement I formed on the job and have not made a case for at length — treat those with more suspicion, not less.

ONE

Lighting

- **Cool white bulbs, anywhere in a home.** Above 3000 K a room turns grey-blue and every warm colour in it dies. This is the single most damaging cheap purchase in decorating.
- **Any bulb that does not print its colour rendering.** If the box will not tell you the CRI, it is because the number is not good. Page 34.
- **A brighter ceiling light, bought to fix a dark room.** The room is not short of light. It is short of light in the right places. Page 32.
- **Downlights, added to a room you live in.** They light floors. You do not live on the floor, and they will put every face in the room into shadow.
- **Bare-filament bulbs at eye level over a table.** Fashionable, and genuinely unpleasant to sit under for two hours.
- **A lamp chosen for the base alone.** The shade does the work — it is what decides where the light goes and whether you can see the bulb. Page 38.
- **Colour-changing smart bulbs, for the colour.** The dimming is worth having. The sixteen million colours will be used twice, and the ones you will actually leave on are the two that a plain warm bulb already gives you.
- **Battery candles with a flicker.** I am aware this is a matter of taste. I have never once seen them improve a room.

> **SPEND THE MONEY HERE INSTEAD**
>
> *One more lamp, at a lower height, with a proper shade and a warm, high-rendering bulb in it. That purchase has never disappointed anybody I advised.*

THE TWO EXCEPTIONS I WOULD MAKE

Cooler light is right in exactly two places in a home: a task light where fine work happens, and a mirror where somebody applies make-up they will wear in daylight. Both are task lighting, both are switched on for minutes rather than hours, and neither is the light the room sits in.

TWO

Paint and colour

- **Paint chosen from a chip, a screen, or a photograph.** A colour is a relationship with the light in your room, and the chip has none of that information. Page 48.
- **The colour of the year.** It is a marketing calendar, it is announced by people who sell paint, and by the time a room is finished in it the following one has been announced. Page 79.
- **Five tester pots of nearly the same white.** Two sheets of lining paper with two candidates on them will tell you more than five pots dabbed straight onto the wall.
- **Cheap white emulsion, bought by the drum, for a room you will live in.** It is porous, it marks, it cannot be cleaned, and it is the exact surface that makes adhesive fixings take the wall off. Page 135.
- **A feature wall, chosen because the room needs something.** A wall that is different for no structural reason reads as an unfinished decision. Page 64.
- **Chalk paint for furniture that was already a good finish.** It is excellent on the right piece and it is a one-way journey on the wrong one.
- **Any colour tested only in daylight**, for a room you use in the evening.
- **Enough paint for two coats.** Buy enough for three. The third coat is the one nobody plans for and everybody needs, and a second tin mixed later may not match.

And the one thing in this category worth more than it costs: a small pot of the wall colour, kept, labelled with the date and the room. Every mark on that wall for the next ten years is then a two-minute job instead of a repaint.

THREE THINGS WORTH PAYING MORE FOR

- **Coverage.** A good paint covers in two coats what a cheap one does not cover in four, and the labour is the expensive part.
- **A washable finish in a hall or a kitchen.** Matt in a corridor is a decision you will regret with a cloth in your hand.
- **Brushes.** My father owned four and cleaned them for thirty years. A cheap brush sheds into the wall and no paint recovers from that.

THREE

Textiles and soft furnishing

- **Curtains that stop at the sill** when the floor was available. The single most common curtain error, and it costs nothing to avoid at the point of buying. Page 93.
- **Curtains at 1.5 × fullness.** They will look thin for as long as you own them, and no amount of steaming fixes it. Page 94.
- **A cushion set.** Four cushions in one pattern, sold together, is the matched-set problem bought deliberately. Page 117.
- **Polyester cushion inserts.** They flatten in a season and never recover, and they read as flat because they are uniform. Feather, every time, two to five centimetres larger than the cover.
- **A rug bought to the size of the gap between the furniture.** Measure the size that puts the front legs on it, then buy that. Page 97.
- **A very thin printed rug.** It reads as a picture of a rug, and it curls at every corner within a month.
- **A sofa whose covers cannot be removed or replaced.** You are renting it slowly. Page 118.
- **Blackout blinds for a bedroom, instead of lined curtains.** The blind handles the light and nothing else; the curtain handles light, cold, sound and the proportion of the whole wall.

> **SPEND THE MONEY HERE INSTEAD**
>
> *One properly full, properly long, lined curtain on the room's best window. It is the largest and best-lit texture in the room and it changes the proportion of the wall at the same time.*

ON BUYING TEXTILES SECONDHAND

Linen and wool are worth buying used and improve with age; foam and polyester are not and do not. Check a secondhand curtain for sun-rot by holding it to the light and pulling gently at the leading edge — the side that faced the window will go first, and if it parts under your thumb the whole pair is finished whatever the price.

FOUR

Furniture

- **Anything whose joints are one-way.** If the fixings cannot be undone and done up again, the piece is finished the first time it is moved badly. Ask the question in the shop and watch the face. Page 123.
- **A matched suite — sofa, chair, footstool, all one fabric.** It will never look chosen. Page 114.
- **A three-seat sofa for a flat you might leave.** It is the piece I saw abandoned on more landings than any other object. Page 139.
- **Anything built to fit one alcove**, if you rent.
- **A coffee table taller than the sofa seat.** Level or just below, always — a tall table in front of a low sofa makes the whole arrangement look like a waiting room.
- **Storage bought in mixed materials and colours.** Six identical boxes read as a system; six different ones read as clutter with lids on. Page 140.
- **A bed frame with no under-bed clearance**, in a small home. That is the cheapest storage you will ever own and you are giving it away.
- **Furniture bought on the same afternoon as the rest of the room.** A room furnished in one transaction looks furnished in one transaction, whatever it cost.

The honest counter-argument, which I owe you: cheap furniture is how a person on very little money furnishes a home at all, and I am not going to pretend otherwise. The request is not that you spend more in total. It is that when you do buy, you buy fewer things and buy the ones that will still be here in ten years. Page 141.

THE SIX SECONDS THAT TELL YOU MOST, IN THE SHOP

1. **Lift one corner.** Weight is not everything, but a chair that is suspiciously light is usually stapled softwood and compressed board.
2. **Push the top corner sideways.** Any sway in a cabinet or a bookcase now is a wobble forever.
3. **Look underneath.** This is where the truth is kept: the frame, the joints, the staples, and whether anybody expected you to look.

FIVE

The things sold to renters

A whole category of product exists because tenants have been told they may not change anything. Some of it is excellent. Much of it is a deposit waiting to be lost.

- **Removable wallpaper, on a whole wall, untested.** On flat landlord emulsion it can take the paint off in sheets. One postcard-sized test patch, two weeks, in a hidden place, before you commit a room. Page 135.
- **Stick-down vinyl floor planks.** They bond harder than the packet suggests, the seams trap damp, and lifting them can take the landlord's surface with them. A rug is reversible. Page 136.
- **Adhesive tile film and worktop wrap.** They fail at the edges, near heat and water, which in a kitchen is everywhere.
- **Adhesive hooks trusted to their printed rating.** Halve it, and never hang anything glazed above a bed on one. Page 133.
- **A tension rod carrying lined curtains.** It is held up by friction. It will come down, and usually at night. Page 132.
- **Peel-and-stick anything in a bathroom.** Steam defeats adhesive. Every time.
- **"Temporary" furniture, bought four flats in a row.** The arithmetic of that decade is on page 141 and it is not kind.

> **THE RENTER'S ONE-LINE RULE**
>
> *Buy the thing that moves house with you, not the thing that sticks to somebody else's wall.*

AND THE THREE THAT GENUINELY WORK

Adhesive strips, used honestly and well under their rating, on sound modern paint. Removable wallpaper on the back of a bookcase or inside a cupboard door, where failure costs an afternoon. And a clamp lamp — it needs no surface, no socket in the right place and no permission, and it is the single most useful object a tenant can own.

The ten things to buy instead

Every entry in the last five pages was a refusal. This page is the whole of what I would actually spend money on, in the order I would spend it.

1. **Bulbs for the whole house.** 2700 K, CRI 90 or better. Costs less than a dinner and recolours every wall you own.
2. **A third lamp, low.** Floor level, in a corner, behind something. The light almost nobody has.
3. **A dimmer, or bulbs that dim.** Brightness you can take away is worth more than brightness you can add.
4. **A curtain pole, long enough.** Two brackets and four screws, and it changes the proportion of the whole wall.
5. **One properly full, properly long curtain** on the best window in the house.
6. **The right-sized rug**, and a pad under it. The most expensive item here and the one most worth waiting and saving for.
7. **One large piece of art**, hung at 145 cm, instead of fifteen small ones.
8. **One unglazed ceramic or stone object.** Often the missing fourth texture, and often the price of a coffee.
9. **One good chair that can be reupholstered.** Secondhand, if that is what the money allows — it usually buys better.
10. **A tin of your own wall colour, labelled and kept.** The cheapest insurance in the house.

Nine of those ten will move house with you. That is not a coincidence either.

WHAT THE WHOLE LIST COSTS

Items one to three — bulbs, a lamp, a dimmer — come to less than a single cushion from a good shop, and between them they do more than anything else on the page. Items four to ten can be bought over a year, in that order, and every one of them moves house with you. There is no step on this list that has to wait for the step after it.

WHERE TO START

Thirty days

One home, one month, and almost no money. This is the order I would work in if I walked into your flat tomorrow.

WEEK ONE — LIGHT, AND NOTHING ELSE

- **Tonight.** The audit on page 183, for the room you use most.
- **Day two.** Read every bulb in the house and write a list.
- **Day three.** Buy them. 2700 K, CRI 90+. Change them all in one evening.
- **Day four to seven.** Move lamps you already own until the main room has three sources at three heights, and leave the ceiling light off all week.

WEEK TWO — HEIGHT, AND AN AFTERNOON

- Every picture and mirror re-hung to 145 cm at its centre.
- Every piece of furniture pulled off its wall by a hand's width.
- One curtain pole raised and widened, if you are allowed to. If not, page 132.

WEEK THREE — TEXTURE, ONE OBJECT AT A TIME

- Count the four families in each room and name what is missing.
- Buy the one cheapest thing that supplies it — usually ceramic or stone, usually small.
- Break one matched set.

WEEK FOUR — AND ONLY NOW, COLOUR

- Re-do the audit. Compare the two scores.
- If colour is still the lowest, test two candidates properly, on lining paper, over a weekend — page 47.
- If it is not, spend the paint money on the rug instead.

Three of those four weeks cost almost nothing. That is the book.

GLOSSARY

The French words

Every French word used in this book, and why I kept it rather than translating it away.

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
la Croix-Rousse	The hill above Lyon where the silk weavers worked, and where I grew up. Its flats have four-metre ceilings and north windows because they were built for looms, not for people.
canut	A Lyon silk weaver. The trade that built those rooms, and the reason this book begins with light.
couturière d'ameublement	A soft furnishings seamstress — curtains, blinds, cushions, loose covers. My grandmother's trade for forty-one years.
cahier	A notebook. Hers held the measurements of every window she ever made for, and it is the reason this book exists.
peintre en bâtiment	A house painter — the trade, not the artist. My father.
menuisier-ébéniste	Joiner and cabinetmaker. My husband, and the reason I know which furniture can be repaired.
badigeon à la chaux	Limewash. A lime-based finish that sinks into the wall rather than sitting on it, and moves with an old building instead of trapping damp in it. Page 68.
le cinquième mur	The fifth wall — the ceiling. The only surface in most homes that nobody has ever made a decision about. Page 61.
état des lieux	The inventory and condition report made at the start and end of a French tenancy. Elsewhere, a schedule of condition. Page 127.
ma chère	My dear. What I call you throughout, and what Mémé called every client she ever corrected.

And if you would like to say any of them out loud: the accent in *couturière* falls at the end, the *ch* in *ma chère* is the soft sound in "shoe", and nobody in Lyon will mind in the slightest how you pronounce any of it.

GLOSSARY

The words of the trade

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Kelvin (K)	The colour of a light, not its brightness. Lower is warmer. 2700 K is the warm light of an old bulb; 4000 K is an office.
Lumens (lm)	How bright a bulb actually is. Watts tell you what it costs to run, which stopped meaning brightness fifteen years ago.
CRI, or R_a	Colour rendering — how honestly a light shows colour, on a scale to 100. Below 80, reds go brown and skin goes grey.
LRV	Light reflectance value — how much light a paint colour throws back, from 0 (black) to 100 (pure white). The number that tells you what a colour will do to a dark room.
Undertone	The bias hiding inside a colour — the green, pink or yellow in a white. The reason two whites can fight. Page 50.
Sheen	How much light a paint finish bounces: matt, eggshell, satin, gloss. Half the decision, and the half nobody makes on purpose. Page 65.
Drop	The finished length of a curtain, measured from the bottom of the ring rather than from the pole.
Fullness	How much wider the fabric is than the pole. 2.5 × is generous; 1.5 × looks thin forever.
Heading	How a curtain is gathered at the top — pencil pleat, pinch pleat, eyelet, tab. It decides the fullness you must buy. Page 95.
Interlining	A soft layer between curtain and lining. Warmth, weight, darkness, and the reason expensive curtains hang the way they do.
Martindale	A standardised rub test for upholstery fabric. The higher the count, the longer it survives. Page 118.
Slub	The thick irregular places in a linen thread. The irregularity that makes linen read as expensive. Page 109.
Reveal	The depth of wall at the side of a window opening. Where a tension rod goes, and a surface nobody ever paints.
Patina	What age does to a good material and cannot do to a bad one. Page 120.

THE HONEST PART

Where the numbers come from

You have been given about a hundred figures. You are owed an account of where each kind of them came from, because they are not all the same kind of thing.

FOUR SORTS OF NUMBER, AND HOW MUCH TO TRUST THEM

1. **Measured standards.** Kelvin, lumens, CRI and Martindale are defined by international test standards and printed on the packaging by law or convention. These are facts. If a box gives you one, believe it.
2. **Trade conventions.** The centre of a picture at 145 cm — 57 inches — is the hanging height used by galleries and museums, and it is a convention rather than a law of nature. It is a convention that has been tested on millions of visitors, which is why I give it as a single number.
3. **Ergonomic ranges.** Worktop heights, desk heights, seat-to-table distances, walking clearances. These come from furniture and building practice, they vary a little between countries, and a person much taller or shorter than average should adjust them without guilt.
4. **My own working figures.** Fullness at 2.5 ×. Three sources at three heights. Halving an adhesive rating. Pulling a sofa 5–15 cm off the wall. These are fourteen years of one person's practice in one city, and they are the ones a reasonable professional might argue with.

TWO CLAIMS I HAVE DELIBERATELY SOFTENED

- **Houseplants and air quality.** The famous experiments were done in sealed chambers. At the densities of an ordinary room the effect is negligible, and I say so on page 112 rather than repeat the claim.
- **Colour and mood.** There is real research, and there is a great deal of confident decorating folklore built on top of it. Where I say a dark room feels enclosing I am describing what people reported to me, not a measured psychological effect.

WHAT I DID NOT VERIFY

Prices, because they differ everywhere and date within a year — where I mention cost it is an order of magnitude, never a quotation. Product names, because I would rather teach you to read a label than send you to a shelf that has changed. And local building and electrical regulations, which differ by country and are the one place in this book where you must ask somebody qualified where you live.

THE HONEST PART

What I might be wrong about

A book that never says this is a book that is selling something. Here are the six positions in these two hundred pages that I hold least firmly.

1. **That a small room should not be painted pale.** It is my most unpopular position — page 57 — and it is drawn from small rooms in old European buildings with poor light. In a small, bright, modern room, pale may well be right and I may be arguing from my own climate.
2. **That the overhead light should be off.** True of every home I worked in. Not necessarily true of a room with a very high ceiling and a beautiful fitting, or of anyone whose eyes need more light than mine do. Light is also an accessibility question, and atmosphere must lose that argument every time.
3. **That matched sets are always wrong.** Held firmly, but it is a position about how rooms read, not a fact about furniture, and there are households where the calm of a matched set is worth more than the interest of a broken one.
4. **That you should buy fewer, better things.** Good advice with savings behind it and a lecture without them. Page 141 is my attempt to be fair about this and I am not sure I succeeded.
5. **That every room needs something living.** Not every household can keep a plant alive, and a dead plant is worse than no plant. Take stone or dried branches instead and lose nothing.
6. **The rug sizes.** They come from rooms of a certain size. In a very small flat, a rug that puts every leg on it may not exist, and front legs on is not a compromise there — it is the answer.

Everything else in this book I would defend at a table with anybody in the trade.

HOW TO DISAGREE WITH THIS BOOK USEFULLY

Do the thing first, live with it for a fortnight, and then disagree. Almost every correction here looks wrong on the first evening — a picture at 145 cm looks too high, a sofa off the wall looks like it has been pushed, a dark room looks alarming at lunchtime. Two weeks is how long it takes an eye to stop arguing. If you still dislike it then, you are right and I am wrong, and it is your home.

LAST WORDS

The cahier

I have the notebook in front of me as I write this. It is cloth-bound, the corners are gone, and it is full of numbers in a hand I would know anywhere.

There is nothing beautiful in it. Page after page of windows: the drop, the width, the fullness, the colour mixed to go with it, and the name of the family. *Madame Rivière, salon, deux fenêtres, 2m40.* No opinions. No photographs. Forty-one years of one woman measuring other people's rooms and writing down what was true of them.

When I was young I thought it was a record of work. I understand now that it is a record of attention. She could not afford any of those rooms. She was never going to live in one of them. And she looked at each one properly anyway, and wrote down what it needed, and went home.

That is the whole of what I have tried to give you. Not a style — styles belong to other people and go out of fashion while you are still paying for them. Attention. The ability to walk into a room, including your own, and see what is actually happening in it instead of what you feel about it.

You will not need this book for very long. That is the point of it. In a year you will hang a picture without measuring, and know from the doorway that a room is lit from one place, and stop yourself in a shop because you have remembered to ask whether the thing can be repaired. Then the book goes on a shelf and you get on with your life, which is what a home is actually for.

She made me promise to write it down before it was lost. It is written down. Thank you for reading it.

> **AND THE LAST LAW, WHICH IS THE FIRST ONE**
>
> *We do not decorate a room, ma chère. We correct it.*

The notebook is going to my daughter, who does not want it yet and will. There is no rule in it that has not been in this book somewhere, and there is nothing in it about style at all. Only windows, and the light that came through them, and who lived there.

If you would like more

This book is the whole method. What follows is only where to find the rest of it, and how to tell me when I am wrong.

THE FILMS

Everything in this book began as something I said out loud on **Chez Colette**. If you have arrived here from there, you already know the voice. If you have not, the channel is the same method in twenty-minute pieces — one room, one fault, one correction at a time — and it costs nothing.

TELL ME WHAT HAPPENED

I would genuinely rather have one photograph of a corrected room than a hundred compliments. If you do the audit on page 183 and fix the thing it points at, tell me. The corrections readers send me are where the next edition of this book will come from — particularly from homes unlike mine: different climates, different light, different housing.

TWO REQUESTS

1. **Print pages 183 to 187**, even if you read the rest of this on a screen. The audit only works with a pencil.
2. **Do one thing tonight.** Not the whole plan. One thing. Turn the ceiling light off and put a lamp on the floor in the corner. Then sit down where you always sit and look at the room you have lived in for years.

Your taste was never the problem. Nobody ever showed you what to look at. Now somebody has.

— Colette Dubois, Lyon

ONE LAST PRACTICAL THING

This is a file, and files get lost. Save a copy somewhere you will still have it in five years, and print the audit pages now while you are thinking of it. I would rather you had four sheets of paper and a pencil than two hundred pages you never opened again.

A SUPPLEMENT

The Christmas Pages

Once a year, fifty new objects arrive in a room in a single weekend, most of them out of boxes, many of them lit. These pages apply the whole method to that weekend: the light first, then the height, then the materials and the colour, and the short list of things not worth the money.

The four errors of a Christmas room · 205
Lights, and the number on the box · 208
Mirrors and black windows · 211
The tree, the garland and the wreath · 212
Hanging it without a drill · 215
Nothing that came in a box of fifty · 217
The réveillon table · 219
What not to buy for Christmas · 221
The Christmas numbers, and the audit · 226

BEFORE YOU OPEN A SINGLE BOX

The four errors of a Christmas room

A room you have spent a year correcting can be undone in one December afternoon, and it is almost always undone in the same four ways.

Christmas is the one time of year when nearly everybody decorates, and most people do it the way they would never furnish a room: everything at once, out of boxes, in the order the boxes come down from the cupboard. Nothing in the method changes for the season. What changes is the speed, and speed is where the errors come from.

1. **Adding before clearing.** The decorations go on top of everything that was already there, so the room gains fifty objects and loses none. The tree takes the floor of a chair that is still in the room, somewhere. Page 207.
2. **Cold light.** A strand of "bright white" lights on the tree and the ceiling light on as well, so the one season built around warm light is lit like a shop. Pages 208 to 210.
3. **One height.** Everything that glows is on the tree, at the height of the tree, and the rest of the room is dark below and above it. The room looks like a display rather than a place to sit. Page 210.
4. **The box set.** Fifty baubles of one size and one finish, a garland that matches them, a wreath that matches the garland. It is the matched three-piece suite of page 114, bought new every few years. Page 217.

THE ORDER STILL HOLDS

The order of operations on page 15 — clear, light, height, texture, colour — is exactly the order to decorate in. Clear the surfaces. Plan the light, including the lights on the tree. Decide the heights: the tree, the mantel, the table, the window. Then the materials. Then, last, the colour, which is the part most people start with and the part that matters least.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF DECEMBER**
>
> *Christmas is decorated in the same order as the rest of the year, only faster. Light before baubles, always.*

These pages assume a sitting room, a table and a front door. A studio has all three in one room, which makes every page here more important, not less.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY TRUE

A French Christmas, honestly

There is no single French way to decorate for Christmas, and anyone who sells you one is selling you a catalogue. There are a few habits that are real, and they are worth knowing because they are restrained.

Most French homes have a real tree, and most of those trees are a Nordmann fir, chosen because it keeps its needles. Many families in the south set out a crèche with small clay figures from Provence. The big meal is on the evening of the twenty-fourth, and the decorations tend to stay up into early January, until the galette des rois closes the season. None of that is a style. It is a calendar, and a calendar is more useful to you than a colour scheme.

THE EIGHTH OF DECEMBER, IN LYON

Every year on the evening of the eighth, Lyon puts candles in its windows: small glasses, one after another along the sills, so the whole hill glitters from the river. It began in 1852, when the city lit its windows for the new statue of the Virgin on Fourvière. In the Croix-Rousse, Mémé set ours out at dusk on the sill of the tall weavers' windows, a hand's width apart, and would not let anyone switch on the ceiling light until they had burned down. It is still the most beautiful lighting I have ever seen in a room, and it cost a few centimes.

THE WORDS YOU WILL MEET

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
le réveillon	The long dinner on Christmas Eve, and again on New Year's Eve. The table on page 219 is laid for it.
les lumignons	The little candles in glasses that Lyon sets on its window sills on the eighth of December.
la crèche, les santons	The nativity scene, and the small painted clay figures, from Provence, that fill it.
le gui	Mistletoe. In France it is kissed under at midnight on New Year's Eve, not at Christmas.
la galette des rois	The almond cake of early January, with a small figure hidden inside. Whoever finds it wears the paper crown.

STAGE ONE

Clear before you decorate

A tree is a piece of furniture two metres tall that arrives for five weeks. It has to take the place of something, and the something has to go somewhere.

The commonest Christmas room I walked into had a tree squeezed between the sofa and the window, a chair pushed against the bookcase to make space for it, and every surface carrying its usual objects plus a candle, a figure and a bowl of something. Nothing was wrong with any of the decorations. There was simply nowhere for the eye to rest, and the tree itself was lost.

THE SWAP BOX

Take one empty box down with the decorations. Every time a decoration comes out of its box, one ordinary object from the same room goes into the empty one: the bowl on the side table leaves when the candles arrive, the picture on the mantel shelf leaves when the garland goes up. The swap box goes into the cupboard the decorations came from, and in January the two swap back. The room ends December holding roughly what it held in November, which is the whole point.

WHAT TO MOVE FOR THE SEASON

- **One piece of furniture,** usually a chair or a small table, to make the tree's floor. Better out of the room for five weeks than wedged into it.
- **Half of what is on every surface.** A shelf that held seven things holds three and a candle.
- **The everyday objects in the tree's background.** A tree reads against a plain wall or a window. It disappears against a full bookcase.

THE WALKWAY

Before the tree goes in, walk the routes through the room with a full basket in your arms — door to sofa, sofa to window, door to table. A tree that you brush past every time you cross the room will be shedding needles on the floor by the twentieth and knocked over by the twenty-fifth. The clearances on page 174 apply in December as they do in June.

And the empty corner of page 102? It may lend itself to the tree for five weeks. That is a loan, not a gift. It comes back on the day the tree goes out.

STAGE TWO · LIGHT

Christmas lights, and the number on the box

The kelvin number on page 34 is printed on boxes of fairy lights too, and in December it matters more than at any other time of year, because for five weeks the tree is the brightest thing in the room.



FOR THE TREE AND THE WINDOW

Strands sold as **warm white** usually sit somewhere between 2700 and 3000 kelvin; strands sold as **extra warm**, **amber** or **candle** sit nearer 2200, which is the colour of a flame. Either belongs in a sitting room. **Cool white**, **bright white** and anything called daylight is the light of a shop window, and on a dark green tree it turns the needles blue-grey. If the box gives no number at all, look at the photograph on it under the shop's own cold light: if the lit bulbs look white rather than gold, they are cool.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE STRANDS**
>
> *One colour of light in a room. Every strand from the same batch, and every strand matched to the bulbs in the lamps.*

WHY THE BATCH MATTERS

"Warm white" is not a fixed colour. Two strands with the same words on the box, from different makers or different years, can differ by several hundred kelvin, and side by side on one tree the difference is obvious: one half of the tree pinkish, the other half lemon. Buy all the strands for one tree at once, from one shelf, and when one fails, replace the set rather than the strand. Test every strand in the shop if they let you, and on the floor at home before it goes anywhere near a branch.

TWO SETTINGS TO SWITCH OFF

Most strands come with eight modes, of which seven flash, fade or chase. Find the steady one and leave it there. And the colour-changing kind, which cycles through red, blue and green, does to a room what a television does: it is the only thing anybody can look at.

Lighting the tree

A tree lit from the outside looks like a cone wearing a necklace. A tree lit from the inside looks like it is glowing, and the difference is only the direction you wind the strand.

HOW MANY

A common working rule is a hundred small bulbs for every thirty centimetres, every foot, of tree height. That is generous, and it is the number for a tree that is meant to glow from across a dark room. For a softer tree, sixty or seventy a foot is plenty. Fewer than that and the strand reads as a line of dots rather than as light.

A tree of 150 cm · 5 ft	300–500 bulbs
A tree of 180 cm · 6 ft	400–600 bulbs
A tree of 210 cm · 7 ft	500–700 bulbs

HOW, IN SIX STEPS

1. **Test every strand on the floor,** plugged in, before it touches the tree. A dead strand found halfway up is an hour lost.
2. **Start at the bottom, at the trunk,** with the plug end, so the lead runs straight down to the socket and nobody sees it.
3. **Work branch by branch, not round and round.** Run the strand out along a branch to its tip and back again to the trunk, then on to the next branch. It takes three times as long as spiralling the outside and it is the whole difference.
4. **Push some bulbs deep, near the trunk.** Light from inside the tree lights the needles from behind, and that is what makes a tree glow rather than twinkle.
5. **Light it before anything else goes on.** Step back to the doorway, half close your eyes, and look for dark patches. Fix them now; you cannot once the baubles are on.
6. **Plug it into a timer.** On at dusk, off when you go to bed. It saves you the crawl behind the tree every evening and the worry every night.

READ THE SMALL PRINT ON THE PLUG

Strands can be joined end to end only up to the number the maker allows, and that number is printed on the label or the plug. Never more. And a strand made for indoors stays indoors.

THE THREE HEIGHTS, IN DECEMBER

The other lights of December

The tree is one light source at one height. The room still needs the other two, and in December it needs them more, because the tree makes everything around it look darker.

Page 28 sets out the three heights every room has to be lit from: overhead, table height and floor level. At Christmas most rooms collapse to one — the tree — with the ceiling light switched on beside it when somebody needs to see. That is the worst of both: the tree loses its glow under the ceiling light, and the moment the ceiling light goes off the room is a dark box with a bright cone in one corner.

DECEMBER, HEIGHT BY HEIGHT

Overhead	off, all season
The tree, and the mantel or shelf garland	middle and high
Table lamps, as every other month	table height
Candles on the table, the low lamp in the corner	low

Light the room first and the tree second. The tree should be the brightest single thing in the room, but not the only thing; a lamp on the far side of the room from it keeps the room readable and makes the tree look brighter rather than dimmer, because the eye is no longer straining against the dark around it.

CANDLES

- **Unscented on the table,** always. A scented candle at dinner competes with the food and wins.
- **One scent per room, if any.** Three different scented candles in one room is a department store.
- **Several flames together,** at different heights, read as light. One candle alone reads as a gesture.
- **Battery candles with a timer** wherever a flame would be near greenery, curtains, a child or a cat. The good ones are hard to tell from the real thing at three metres.

NEVER

A real candle on a tree, real or artificial. Nor a flame within thirty centimetres, a foot, of anything that can burn — a garland, a ribbon, a curtain, a card on a shelf. Greenery dries out in a heated room faster than anyone expects.

Mirrors and black windows

In December there are two mirrors in every room: the one on the wall, and the window, which turns into one the moment it is dark outside and lit inside.

Page 90 says that a mirror reflects whatever is in front of it, and that this is the entire mechanism. In December the useful version of that is simple. A mirror that can see candles or a lit tree doubles them for nothing. A mirror that can see the back of the tree, the tangle of leads behind it and the box the baubles came in doubles those too.

THE MIRROR ON THE WALL

- **Over a mantel,** a row of candles on the shelf below the mirror is the oldest trick in the French sitting room. The tall mirror and panel above a fireplace, the trumeau, was made for a room lit by flame, and this is what it was for.
- **From your seat,** sit where you will sit on Christmas Eve and look at the mirror. If it shows you the tree, it is working. If it shows you the ceiling or the door, move the candles rather than the mirror.
- **Behind the tree,** never. A mirror there shows the bare inner side of the tree and the trunk, and the leads running down it.

THE BLACK WINDOW

After dark, with the room lit and the street unlit, a window is a dark mirror. Stand in the doorway and look at the glass. A tree placed beside a window, a little forward of it, appears twice in the evening — once in the room and once, softer, in the glass — and it is seen from the street as well. A tree placed in front of a window, with its back to the glass, shows the street its leads and shows you its reflection from behind. Beside, not in front.

> ### COLETTE'S RULE OF THE SECOND TREE
>
> *Before you fix the tree's place, turn off the ceiling light and look for its reflection. A tree you can see twice is a tree in the right place.*

The same is true of the black window behind a dining table. Candles on a table in front of an uncurtained window at night are doubled in the glass, and many people leave the curtains open on Christmas Eve for exactly that reason. If the window looks out onto a lit neighbour or a bright street, close them; the reflection is gone and only the view remains.

STAGE THREE · HEIGHT

The right tree for the room

A tree is measured twice, once for height and once for width, and almost every tree that looks wrong in a room failed the second measurement, not the first.

HEIGHT

Measure the ceiling. Take off the stand, which lifts the tree ten to fifteen centimetres, and the topper, if there is one. What is left is the tallest tree the room can take, and the tree looks best a little short of it: a tree touching the ceiling looks wedged in, a tree with a hand of air above its top looks placed.

Ceiling 240 cm · 8 ft, with a topper	tree of about 195–210 cm
Ceiling 260 cm and more	tree of about 210–225 cm

WIDTH, WHICH IS THE ONE THAT MATTERS

A tree sold as a standard shape is usually about two thirds as wide at the base as it is tall, so a tree of two metres is about 130 cm across the bottom — well over four feet, and wider than most armchairs. In a small sitting room, that is the floor of a chair and its walkway. Ask for a slim or narrow tree, which is often closer to half its height across, or choose a shorter tree and stand it on something.

Standard tree, base width	about two thirds of its height
Slim tree, base width	about half its height
Clear floor around it, on the open sides	a walkway, 60–90 cm

WHERE IT STANDS

- **Away from heat.** At least a metre, three feet, from a radiator, a stove or a fire. A real tree beside a radiator is dry within a week.
- **Seen from the door,** so it is the first thing anybody sees coming in, and not in the walkway they use to come in.
- **Beside a window rather than in front of it,** for the reason on the previous page.
- **Near a socket,** so the lead never crosses a walkway. A lead taped across the floor is a lead somebody will trip on in the dark.

Take a tape measure to buy the tree. The ones in the yard always look smaller than they are, because the sky is a very high ceiling.

Keeping a real tree, and choosing a false one

A real tree drops its needles for one reason, and it is almost never the tree's fault. It ran out of water.

THE REAL ONE

1. **Choose by touch.** Run a branch through a closed hand. A fresh tree gives up a few needles; a tree that has been cut too long rains them. The Nordmann fir, the usual French tree, holds its needles far longer than most spruces, and that is why it is the usual French tree.
2. **Saw a fresh cut,** one or two centimetres off the base, just before it goes into water. A cut trunk seals itself with sap within hours, and a sealed trunk cannot drink.
3. **Use a stand that holds water,** plenty of it: a common rule is about a litre for every two and a half centimetres, every inch, of trunk diameter.
4. **Check the water every day,** especially in the first week, when a fresh tree can drink a surprising amount. If the level ever falls below the base of the trunk, it seals again.
5. **Keep it away from heat,** as on the previous page.

THIERRY AND THE SAW

My husband will not let a tree into the flat until he has taken his own saw to the bottom of it on the landing, with the stand already full and waiting by the window. Two minutes, he says, between the cut and the water, or you are buying a dead tree. We have never had a bare branch by New Year.

THE FALSE ONE, HONESTLY

An artificial tree is only a sound buying decision if it is kept for many years, and the studies disagree about how many. Bought, it should be judged like any piece of furniture on page 194: will it still be here, and still wanted, in ten years? That rules out the cheap, sparse, very green ones, which look artificial from the doorway and are usually replaced within three seasons. If you buy one, buy it once.

- **Look at the tips, not the photograph.** Moulded tips that imitate needles look like a tree; flat, shiny strips of plastic look like tinsel.
- **Choose a darker, slightly blue-green** over a bright lime green. Real fir is darker than people remember.
- **Unlit,** so the lights can be chosen by the rule on page 208 and replaced when they fail. A pre-lit tree with a dead strand is a tree with a dead strand for ever.

Garlands, wreaths and the mantel

Almost every garland I have seen in a client's home was too short, and almost every wreath too small. Both are measured, and neither is.

THE GARLAND

A garland laid flat along a mantel or a shelf should run the whole length and fall a little past each end, so the line continues down the sides rather than stopping at the edge. A garland hung in swags needs far more than people buy, because every dip uses length.

Laid along a shelf — length	shelf + 30–60 cm each end
Hung in swags — length	about one and a half × the width
Along a banister — length	the rail, measured, + a quarter

And thick. A thin garland on a wide mantel reads as a line, not as greenery. Two cheap thin garlands twisted together, or one bought garland filled out with real cut branches tucked into it, read as one generous one.

THE WREATH

A wreath on a front door is seen from the end of the path, and from there a small one looks like a knot. As a working guide, a wreath should be roughly half to two thirds the width of the door. A standard door of about ninety centimetres, three feet, carries a wreath of fifty to sixty centimetres.

Door 80–90 cm · 32–36 in	wreath 50–60 cm · 20–24 in
Its centre, from the floor	about eye level, 150–165 cm

THE MANTEL, IN THREE HEIGHTS

A mantel dressed with one garland and nothing else is flat. The page 28 rule applies to objects as much as to light: something low along the shelf, something at middle height, and something tall at one end — a branch in a jug, a pair of tall candles, the mirror above. Never symmetrical in every detail; a mantel with identical objects at both ends looks like a shop counter.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE GARLAND**
>
> *Measure the garland as you would a curtain. Too short and too thin is the only real mistake a garland can make.*

FOR THE RENTED FLAT, AND FOR EVERYONE IN JANUARY

Hanging it without a drill

Nothing in December needs a hole in the wall. Everything here comes down in January leaving the wall exactly as it was, which is what a deposit is for.

THE FRONT DOOR

- **An over-the-door hook,** a thin metal hanger that hooks over the top of the door. Check that the door still closes on it without forcing, and put a strip of felt where it touches the paint.
- **The ribbon instead,** which needs no hook at all: tie the wreath to a long ribbon, take the ribbon up over the top of the door and fix its end on the inside with a little tape or a drawing pin into the top edge, where nobody will ever see the mark.

WALLS, WINDOWS AND THE MANTEL

- **Adhesive hooks** follow the rules on page 133 in full: half the rating, a wipe with rubbing alcohol, an hour before any weight. In winter add one more: adhesive grips badly on a cold surface, so an outside door or a window frame in a cold room needs the hook put on in the warm, and an extra day.
- **The picture rail,** if your building has one (page 91), will carry garlands and stars on cord, at any height, with no mark at all.
- **A tension rod** fitted inside the window recess carries paper stars, lights or a short garland. Nothing touches the frame but the rod's rubber ends.
- **Suction cups** belong on glass, nowhere else.
- **On a mantel,** the garland is held by weight, not glue: a heavy candle holder or a pair of books at each end, hidden under the greenery. Adhesive on a painted mantel shelf is exactly the place it takes the paint with it.

BANISTERS AND RAILS

Soft ties, ribbon or the paper-covered wire sold for gardens, wound twice around the rail and the garland together. Never adhesive on varnished wood, and never cable ties pulled tight, which mark the finish.

THE FISHING LINE

Clear fishing line disappears against a wall or a window at night, which is why it is so useful for hanging stars and baubles where you want them to float. It is also invisible to anyone walking under it. Hang it out of the way of heads, and never across a doorway.

STAGE FIVE · COLOUR, LAST

A palette for December

The tree is already green and the light is already gold. That is two of your colours chosen before you open a box, and most rooms need only one more.

A Christmas palette is usually chosen in a shop, from a display arranged under shop lighting, and then brought home to a room that has its own colours and its own light. The decorations go up, and they argue with the sofa. The cure is the one the rest of this book gives for paint: choose from the room, not for it.

CHOOSING IT, IN THREE STEPS

1. **Take the colour from the room.** Look at what already stays: the sofa, the curtains, the rug, the wood. The decoration colour should belong to one of them. A rust sofa makes copper and deep red look intended. A blue-grey room makes silver and white look intended.
2. **Add one.** Green and gold are given; add one colour, and white or cream for rest. Three colours is a palette. Five is a sale.
3. **Check it at night.** Lay the decorations on the sofa at nine in the evening, with the lamps on and the ceiling light off. That is when they will be seen, and it is when they will clash, if they are going to.

ONE METAL

Gold, brass and copper sit with warm light and look as if they are lit from inside. Silver and chrome sit with cool light, and under warm bulbs they can look grey. Choose one metal for the room's decorations and let every bauble, candlestick and bell follow it. Mixing the two is possible and is much harder than it looks, which is the definition of a thing to avoid.

THE TROUBLE WITH DEEP RED

Deep red is the colour of Christmas and the colour that disappears first in low evening light, sinking towards brown and then black long before the greens and the whites do. Give red a light of its own — a candle in front of it, a lamp beside it — or a pale neighbour, and it holds. Left in the dark corner, it is a black ribbon.

> ### COLETTE'S RULE OF THREE COLOURS
>
> *Green, gold, and one colour that was already in the room. Everything else is white.*

THE RULE OF PAGE 114, IN DECEMBER

Nothing that came in a box of fifty

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE MATCHED SET, AT CHRISTMAS**
>
> *A tree dressed from one box looks bought. A tree dressed from twenty years looks loved, and nobody can buy that.*

The box of fifty identical baubles is the three-piece suite of December. Every one of them is fine. Together they announce that the whole tree was decided in one afternoon, in one aisle.

A tree needs a great many objects, so the box is tempting, and a box of fifty is cheap. The answer is not to throw it away. It is to use it as the background and interrupt it, exactly as page 114 interrupts a sofa set.

HOW TO BREAK A BOX SET YOU ALREADY OWN

- **Three sizes, not one.** Large, medium and small, in roughly one large to three medium to six small. One size on a tree flattens it into a polka dot.
- **Large inside, small outside.** Hang the big baubles deep in the tree, close to the trunk, and the small ones near the tips. It gives the tree depth, and it puts the weight on the strong part of the branch.
- **Two finishes in one colour.** Shiny and matte, or glass and painted. The same colour in two finishes looks chosen; two colours in one finish looks bought.
- **Add the things that did not come from a shop.** Dried orange slices, cinnamon sticks tied with thread, paper stars, a small wooden figure, an ornament a child made. Ten of these on a tree of fifty baubles changes the whole tree.

THE ONE-A-YEAR HABIT

Buy, or be given, or make, one ornament every December, and write the year on its string tag. In ten years the tree is a diary. It is the slowest way to decorate a tree and the only one that grows more valuable every year rather than less, which is the argument of page 120 about patina, hung on a branch.

And the matched set has one honest use. A tree that must go up in an hour — in a shop, an office, a waiting room — can be dressed from one box and look perfectly correct. That is the point. It looks correct, and it looks like nobody lives there.

STAGE FOUR · TEXTURE

The four families at Christmas

Most Christmas decorations are made of one material, plastic finished to look like something else. That is why a room can be full of decorations and still look thin.

The four families of page 107 — wood, textile, clay and stone, and something living — are the cure in December as in June, and December happens to be the month when the living family is easiest to bring indoors.

FAMILY	IN DECEMBER
Living	Cut branches of fir, pine or eucalyptus in a jug, tucked into a garland, laid along the table. Ivy and holly from a garden. A pot of white paperwhites or a hyacinth forced for the season.
Textile	Ribbon bought by the metre in velvet, linen or cotton rather than shiny polyester. A wool throw. A linen tablecloth, page 109.
Wood	A wooden bowl of nuts or pine cones. Wooden ornaments. The candlesticks you already own. Bare twigs from a walk, sprayed nothing at all.
Clay, glass, stone	Old glass baubles. A stoneware jug for the branches. Candles in glasses, as Lyon does on the eighth.

DRIED ORANGE SLICES, BECAUSE EVERYONE ASKS

1. Slice oranges about half a centimetre thick, and pat both sides dry with a cloth.
2. Lay them on a rack over a baking tray, in the oven at its lowest setting, around a hundred degrees Celsius, two hundred Fahrenheit, with the door just ajar.
3. Turn them every hour. They take two to four hours, and they are done when the flesh is dry and translucent and the rind no longer bends.
4. Thread them on cotton or a thin ribbon. They keep for years in a dry box.

PAPER STARS

White paper stars in a window, hung on thread from a tension rod at different heights, are the cheapest decoration in this book and one of the best. At night they glow with the room behind them; in the daytime they throw small shadows. A sheet of good paper, a pair of scissors and an evening.

GREENERY AND CHILDREN

Holly and mistletoe berries are poisonous to children and to pets. Keep both high, or choose branches without berries.

THE TWENTY-FOURTH

The réveillon table

The French have a phrase for everything that goes on a laid table, les arts de la table, and the whole of it comes down to one question: can every guest see every other guest, and their plate, by candlelight?

THE NUMBERS

Width of table per guest	60 cm · 24 in, at least
Tablecloth drop, for dinner	20–30 cm · 8–12 in
Centrepiece, low	under 30 cm · 12 in
Or tall and thin, with nothing between	above seated eye level
Candles from the nearest greenery	30 cm · 12 in, or more

THE TABLE, IN ORDER

1. **The cloth first,** white or cream, or linen in its own colour, for the reason on page 109. A cloth with a printed Christmas pattern fights the food.
2. **Light, before anything else is laid.** The ceiling light off, the pendant over the table, if you have one, at its proper low height and dimmed (page 151), and the candles placed and lit, so that you set everything else by the light it will be seen in.
3. **Greenery along the middle,** low, as a runner of cut branches straight on the cloth. It costs almost nothing, and it carries the green of the tree to the table.
4. **Plates and glasses last,** and fewer of them than the occasion seems to demand. A table so full that the candles have to be moved to serve is a table that has stopped working.

MÉMÉ'S REHEARSAL

My grandmother laid the réveillon table on the evening of the twenty-third, completely, with the candles lit, and sat in every chair in turn. She moved whatever hid a face. Then she cleared it all away, and laid it again the next evening in a quarter of the time.

The same table, with the same greenery moved to the side, serves the New Year's Eve dinner a week later. Hang the mistletoe in the doorway, not over the table.

The window from the street

In December your window is the one part of your home that strangers see, and it is seen almost only at night. Decorate it for the pavement, not for the room.

The eighth of December in Lyon is the proof that the simplest window is the most beautiful one. A row of small flames along a sill, seen from below, does more than any arrangement of lit reindeer, because it is light doing what light does best: marking the shape of the window and nothing else.

LIGHTING A WINDOW, SIMPLY

- **Along the sill,** where Lyon puts its candles: a row of small lights, or battery candles in glasses, at even spacing. A hand's width apart is enough.
- **Across the top,** a single strand along the head of the window, held by a tension rod inside the recess. Two lines of light, top and bottom, frame the glass.
- **In the middle,** one thing, or paper stars on thread at different heights. One star in a window is a sign. Twelve plastic figures is a shop.
- **The same warm light** as the tree and the lamps, for the reason on page 208. A cool-white window in a street of warm ones is the one everybody notices, for the wrong reason.

THE CURTAINS

Open, in the evening, if the window is the decoration. A lit window with the curtains drawn is a strip of light between two dark panels; with them pulled back to the edges of the frame, it is a picture. Close them at bedtime, with the timer, and the street goes dark with you.

FLAMES BEHIND GLASS

A real flame on a sill sits between the glass and a curtain. If you light real candles in a window, as Lyon does, take the curtains right back, keep the flames in glasses, and never leave the room while they burn. Otherwise, battery candles. From the street, nobody can tell the difference.

Outside the window — on a balcony, a porch, a front door — use only lights and leads made for outdoors, plugged into a socket made for outdoors. The words "indoor use only" on a box mean exactly that, and rain finds out.

THE SHORTEST LIST IN THIS BOOK, AND THE HARDEST TO KEEP

What not to buy for Christmas

The four tests on page 190 apply in December like any other month. They are simply harder to hear over the music in the shop.

- **Cool-white or "bright white" lights.** They turn a tree blue-grey and a sitting room into a shop window. Page 208.
- **Strands that flash, chase or change colour**, unless they also have a steady setting you will use.
- **A pre-lit artificial tree.** When one strand dies, the tree is a dead strand for ever. Buy the tree and the lights separately. Page 213.
- **The box of fifty matching baubles**, bought new to replace last year's box of fifty. Page 217.
- **Tinsel.** Plastic film that sheds into the carpet for the rest of the winter and is rarely recyclable. Light does its job better.
- **Spray snow on the windows.** It looks like spray snow from the street, and on a bad day it looks like it until March.
- **"This year's colours".** A palette designed to be replaced next December. Page 216 has one that lasts.
- **Several scented candles for one room.** One scent per room, none on the table.
- **Shiny polyester ribbon on the roll.** Velvet, linen or cotton by the metre costs a little more, lasts for years and looks like cloth.
- **Large inflatables and plastic light-up figures** for a small flat or a balcony. They are built to be seen from a road, and a room is not a road.
- **Christmas cushion covers**, new every year. A plain cover in your one Christmas colour does the same job in December and stays out in January.
- **Anything that needs its own extension lead** across a walkway.

A FAIR WARNING, AGAIN

As with the main list, these are my opinions, formed on the job, and a family with a particular tradition — the flashing lights a grandmother loved, the box of tinsel a child insists on — should keep it. Tradition beats taste every time. These are the things to stop buying, not the things to throw away.

The ten Christmas things worth buying

Like page 196, in the order I would spend the money, and nine of the ten will still be useful in March.

1. **A timer plug,** or two. Lights on at dusk and off at bedtime, every night, without a crawl behind the tree. The cheapest thing on this page and the most used.
2. **Warm-white strands, one batch,** enough for the tree by the count on page 209. Unlit tree, separate lights, steady setting.
3. **A stand that holds water,** plenty of it, for a real tree. A tree dies in a stand that holds too little.
4. **Unscented candles,** a box of tall ones for the table and some short ones in glasses. Battery candles with a timer wherever a flame would be unsafe.
5. **Ribbon by the metre,** velvet or linen, in your one Christmas colour. It ties the wreath, the garland, the stockings and the presents, and it lasts.
6. **A garland long enough,** by the measure on page 214, or two thin ones to twist together.
7. **Cut greenery,** from a florist, a market or a garden: branches for a jug, a runner for the table, filling for the garland. It costs very little and it is the only decoration that smells right.
8. **A wreath of the right size,** and the ribbon or the over-door hook to hang it on. Page 215.
9. **One ornament,** chosen slowly, with the year written on its tag. Page 217.
10. **Boxes for putting it away,** with dividers, so that next year begins untangled. Page 225.

Most of the money goes on light and on greenery. That is not a coincidence: they are the two things a December room is actually made of.

WHAT THE WHOLE LIST COSTS

Items one to four — timers, lights, a stand, candles — are the ones that change the room, and together they cost less than a box of designer baubles. Items five to nine are the ones that make it look generous, and the greenery is the only one bought again every year. Item ten is the one that saves next December an evening.

THE QUIET PART

Who profits from a new Christmas every year

Nobody plotted it. The trade simply arranged itself around the one season in which almost everybody buys decorations, and the arrangement has a shape worth seeing.

Christmas decorations are sold in a few weeks, mostly to people in a hurry, and much of what is sold is stored in a box for eleven months and brought out again. A decoration that lasts is good for the household and bad for next year's sales. That is not anybody's fault. It is just what the season rewards, and it explains three things you will see in every shop this December.

1. **The palette changes every year.** A colour story for the season, shown on every display, so that last year's perfectly good decorations look like last year. Your tree does not know what year it is.
2. **The set is cheaper than the piece.** Fifty baubles cost little more than five good ones, so the set always looks like the sensible choice, and a tree dressed from it always looks like the shop.
3. **Everything lights up, and nothing can be repaired.** Moulded figures with the lights sealed inside, trees with the strands built in. When one part fails, the whole object is finished, and there is another on the shelf.

None of this needs a villain to work, and none of it needs you to do anything except notice. The household that buys well at Christmas is not the one that buys least. It is the one that buys things which come out of the box next year still wanted: lights that can be replaced on their own, glass that does not date, greenery that is meant to be thrown away.

THE BOX IN THE CELLAR

Our decorations live in two wine crates in the cellar, and the oldest thing in them is a glass bird with a tail of real feathers, older than my mother. It has never matched anything on any tree. It goes on first, every year, and it is the one my daughter looks for.

> ### COLETTE'S RULE OF THE BOX
>
> *Buy for the box in the cellar, not for the photograph. A decoration is good if you are glad to unwrap it in ten years.*

Safe, without spoiling it

December brings more flames, more leads and more dry wood into a home than the rest of the year together. None of the rules below costs anything, and none of them shows.

THIS IS THE ONE PAGE TO FOLLOW EXACTLY

Everything else in these pages is a matter of how a room looks. This page is a matter of whether it is still there in January. If in doubt about any appliance, any socket or any lead, ask an electrician, not a shop.

LIGHTS AND LEADS

- [ ] Every strand checked on the floor before it goes up: no cracked wire, no loose bulb, no scorch mark on the plug
- [ ] Strands joined only up to the number printed on the label
- [ ] Indoor lights indoors, outdoor lights outdoors, on an outdoor socket
- [ ] No lead under a rug, through a closed door or across a walkway
- [ ] Lights off when the house is empty and when everyone is asleep — the timer does it

FLAMES

- [ ] No candle on or near a tree, real or artificial
- [ ] Thirty centimetres, a foot, between any flame and anything that can burn
- [ ] Candles on a stable, non-flammable holder, out of reach of children and animals
- [ ] Never a candle left burning in an empty room

THE TREE

- [ ] A metre from radiators, stoves and fires
- [ ] A real tree watered every day, and taken out once it drops needles at a touch
- [ ] Stable in its stand, and tied discreetly to a hook where there are small children or a climbing cat
- [ ] Glass baubles high, where small hands and tails do not reach

THE REST

- [ ] Holly and mistletoe berries out of reach of children and pets
- [ ] Batteries for remote candles and toys stored away from small children, who can swallow button cells
- [ ] The smoke alarm tested on the day the tree goes up

EARLY JANUARY

Putting it away well

Next Christmas is decided on the day this one comes down, in about an hour, by whether the lights go into the box in a ball or on a card.

In many French homes the season ends with the galette des rois in early January, and the tree goes out soon after. Many towns collect real trees in the weeks after New Year and turn them into mulch or compost; look for the collection point your town announces, rather than leaving the tree on the pavement.

THE HOUR THAT SAVES NEXT DECEMBER AN EVENING

1. **Photograph the tree and the mantel** before anything comes down. Next year you will want to know where the bird went, and how long the garland was.
2. **Lights off the tree in reverse**, tip to trunk, and wound around a piece of stiff card, plug end first, so the plug end comes out first next year. One strand per card, and a note of its length.
3. **Batteries out** of every battery candle, every timer and every lit figure. A battery left in for eleven months can leak and ruin what it powers.
4. **Glass in egg boxes** or wrapped in tissue, never newspaper, whose ink can mark painted glass. Heaviest at the bottom of the box.
5. **Ribbon rolled, not folded**, around a cardboard tube, so it does not crease.
6. **Label the boxes by job,** not by contents: *tree, first*; *mantel*; *table*; *window*. The order you take them out next year is the order of this book.
7. **The swap box back.** The everyday objects return to their places, and the room is the room again.

WHERE TO KEEP IT

Somewhere dry, with a steady temperature. Not a loft that bakes in summer, where candles bend and adhesive perishes, and not a damp cellar, where cardboard softens and ribbon spots. A cupboard in the flat is better than either, if there is room, and the room there is is the reason the swap box exists.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF JANUARY**
>
> *Pack it away the way you would want to find it. Next December begins today.*

EVERY FIGURE IN THESE PAGES, COLLECTED

The Christmas numbers

LIGHT

Strands for the tree and the window	2200–2700 K, one batch
Bulbs per 30 cm · 1 ft of tree, glowing	about 100
Bulbs per 30 cm · 1 ft of tree, soft	60–70
Overhead light, all season	off

THE TREE

Height, against the ceiling	ceiling – stand – topper – a hand
Base width, standard · slim	two thirds · half its height
From radiators, stoves, fires	1 m · 3 ft, at least
Fresh cut off the trunk	1–2 cm
Water in the stand	about 1 l per 2.5 cm of trunk

GARLAND AND WREATH

Garland laid along a shelf	shelf + 30–60 cm each end
Garland in swags	about one and a half × the width
Wreath, against the door	half to two thirds of its width

THE TABLE

Width per guest	60 cm · 24 in
Cloth drop · centrepiece height	20–30 cm · under 30 cm
Any flame, from anything that can burn	30 cm · 12 in, or more

All of these are working figures from the trade and from the people who make the things, not laws. Where a maker's label says something different — about how many strands may be joined, about a stand, about a candle — the label wins.

THE AUDIT · DECEMBER

The Christmas audit

ROOM

DATE, AFTER DARK

BEFORE ANYTHING GOES UP

- [ ] Half of what is on every surface is in the swap box
- [ ] The tree has a floor of its own, a metre from any heat, beside a window, near a socket
- [ ] Every walkway still clears a full basket
- [ ] Every strand tested, one batch, warm white, steady setting, on a timer

SITTING WHERE YOU WILL SIT ON CHRISTMAS EVE

- [ ] The ceiling light is off, and the room is still lit at three heights
- [ ] The tree glows from inside; I cannot see a lead
- [ ] I can see the tree twice — in a mirror or in the black window
- [ ] There are no more than three colours, and one metal
- [ ] At least ten things on the tree did not come out of a box of fifty
- [ ] Something living, something wooden, something cloth and something glass or clay are all in view
- [ ] No flame is within thirty centimetres of anything that can burn

SCORE, OUT OF ELEVEN

KELVIN ON THE STRANDS

Fewer than eight ticks: start with the light, pages 208 to 210, and change nothing else until the ceiling light can stay off all evening.

THE ONE ORNAMENT WE WILL ADD THIS YEAR, AND ITS DATE

WHAT I WANT TO REMEMBER WHEN I PUT IT AWAY

COLOPHON

Colette’s Home Bible

La Belle Maison
Make any room look expensive without buying anything new

Written by Colette Dubois.
Published by Chez Colette.
Second edition — two hundred and twenty-eight pages,
with the Christmas pages.

Set in Bodoni Moda and Spectral.
Drawn, not photographed — every diagram made for the page.

For Mémé Suzanne, who measured everything
and wrote it all down.

We do not decorate a room, ma chère. We correct it.